

Hindi, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one word at a time

Adhithya Rajasekaran

This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they are written.

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Preface

This book teaches Hindi one word at a time, and it teaches each word by taking it apart. It is written for someone starting from zero — who may not read a single Devanagari letter — so the script is taught *inside the word lessons themselves*: each word introduces exactly the letters it needs, so you learn to read नमस्ते and learn that it means “I bow to you” in the same few minutes. There is no alphabet drill to sit through first. (A reader who already knows Devanagari simply skims the “letters in this word” notes.)

Hindi’s depth comes from a double inheritance. Much of its core vocabulary is **Sanskrit** — नमस्ते and धन्यवाद sit on ancient roots (*nam*, “to bow”; *dhanya*, “worthy”). But centuries of Persian as the language of courts layered on a second vocabulary, Persian and (through it) Arabic — so “thanks” is also शुक्रिया (*shukriyā*, the same Semitic root as Arabic *shukran*), and “farewell” is अलविदा (*alvidā*, “the farewell,” carrying the Arabic article *al-*). The book keeps both streams in view.

How to use this book

Every numbered section is one word, or one small phrase, and takes a few minutes — the length of a queue, an errand, or the walk to the bus. Read them in order the first time through: each section stands on the ones before it, and nothing is used before it has been taught. After that the book becomes reference, and you can open it anywhere.

Say the Hindi out loud wherever you can. The prompts under *Your turn* are written to be spoken, and saying a word is most of what makes it stay. The questions under *Before you move on* carry their own answers in brackets: cover them, answer from memory, then look.

Nothing here is gated behind the alphabet. Each lesson introduces exactly the letters and sounds its own word needs, so you are reading real words from the first page rather than drilling a chart. The whole script is

gathered in a reference at the back of the book — somewhere to look things up when you are curious, never a chapter to sit through first.

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Chapter 1

Greetings

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 👁️ eyes (5) ✍️ pen (4) 🖐️ **Hands-free start:** first 5 of 10 lessons.

The Hindi greetings — and, taught through them, how to read Devanagari and Hindi’s double inheritance (Sanskrit and Perso-Arabic). Each lesson introduces the letters its word needs, so you learn to read the word and understand it at once.

1.1 नमस्ते (*namaste*) — “I bow to you”

The letters in this word

Hindi reads **left to right**, and every consonant carries a built-in “a.” न na, म ma, स sa, त ta. A vowel sign changes the vowel: े makes “e” (ते = te). A *halant* (the stroke under स) *removes* the vowel, and the bare consonant leans onto the next as a **conjunct**: स + ते → स्ते. Read left to right: न·म·स्·ते → *namaste*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

नमस्ते = नमः (*namah*, “a bow, reverence,” from Sanskrit root नम् *nam*, “to bow”) + ते (*te*, “to you”) = literally “**I bow to you**.” The root *nam* also builds *namaskār* (next), and *namaste* is borrowed whole into English.

Why it's said this way

A real gesture, not a bland “hi”: said with palms pressed together, in respect. Works as both hello and goodbye, any time, polite without being stiff.

1.2 नमस्कार (*namaskār*) — the more formal bow

The letters in this word

New: क ka, र ra, and the sign ा for long “ā” (का = kā). You already read नमस् (*namas*). न·म·स्·का·र → *namaskār*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

नमस्कार = नमः (*namaḥ*, “bow,” root *nam*) + कार (*kāra*, “the making/doing of,” from Sanskrit कृ *kṛ*, “to do”). Literally “the making of a bow.” That piece *-kāra* (“the act of _____”) recurs across Sanskrit vocabulary.

A notch more **formal** than *namaste* — ceremonial, or for elders and writing.

1.3 धन्यवाद (*dhanyavād*) — “thank you,” the Sanskrit way

The letters in this word

New: ध dha, य ya, व va, द da, and a new conjunct न् + य → न्य (“nya”). ध·न्·य·वा·द → *dhanyavād*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

धन्यवाद = धन्य (*dhanya*, “worthy, blessed,” from धन *dhana*, “wealth”) + वाद (*vāda*, “a saying,” from Sanskrit वद् *vad*, “to speak”). Literally “an utterance of [you are] worthy” — a formal, literary “thanks.”

Why it's said this way

The **formal, Sanskritic** “thank you” — written, official, respectful. For everyday thanks Hindi often reaches for a lighter Persian word, शुक्रिया — next — and holding the two together is the best window into Hindi.

1.4 शुक्रिया (*shukriyā*) — Hindi's other heritage

The letters in this word

New: श sha, and the sign ि for “i” (written *before* the consonant, read *after*). With a conjunct क् + र → क्र (“kra”): शुक्-रि-या → *shukriyā*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

शुक्रिया is *not* Sanskrit. It came through Persian from **Arabic *shukr*** (“gratitude”), root **sh-k-r** — the *same word* as Arabic *shukran*. Two unrelated languages, one Semitic root for thanks.

Why it's said this way

Centuries of Persian as the court language poured Persian and Arabic words into everyday Hindi/Urdu, so Hindi carries **two vocabularies**: Sanskrit (*dhanyavād*, *namaste*) and Perso-Arabic (*shukriyā*, *alvidā*). Often the Sanskrit word is formal and the Persian one everyday. *shukriyā* is the casual, everyday “thanks.”

1.5 अलविदा (*alvidā*) — “the farewell”

The letters in this word

New: the independent vowel अ (“a,” for a word that *starts* with a vowel) and ल la. अ-ल-वि-दा → *alvidā*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

अलविदा came through Persian from **Arabic** *al-widā‘* (“the farewell”), root **w-d-‘**. At the front is अल — the Arabic article **al-**, “the,” the same one riding inside English *algebra* and *alcohol*. So *alwidā* is literally “the farewell.”

Why it’s said this way

Carries **finality** — the goodbye for a long or final parting. For casual “bye,” Hindi uses *namaste* again, or *phir milenge* (“we’ll meet again”). Next chapter: *āp* vs. *tum* (formal and informal “you”), and introducing yourself.

Chapter 2

Introducing Yourself

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 👁️ eyes (5) ✍️ pen (7) 🗣️ **Hands-free start:** first 8 of 16 lessons.

Now a first real exchange — giving your name, asking for someone else’s, and saying you’re glad to meet them:

मेरा नाम मीरा है। (*merā nām Mira hai* — “My name is Mira.”)
आपका नाम क्या है? (*āpkā nām kyā hai* — “What is your name?”)

Built the same way as the greetings — each piece taken apart, its letters and its root, then assembled.

2.1 नाम (*nām*) — “name,” a word older than Europe

The letters in this word

Three letters, left to right: न (*na*), ा the long-ā *mātrā* (ना = *nā*), म (*ma*). Read न+म → *nām*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

नाम (*nām*) ← Sanskrit नामन् (*nāman*), from Proto-Indo-European *h₃nomn. — the *same* ancient root as English **name**, Latin *nōmen* (English **noun**, **nominate**), and Greek *onoma*. So Hindi *nām* and English *name* are cousins from before either language existed — one of the clearest bridges between the Indian and European branches of the same family.

2.2 मेरा (*merā*) — “my”

The letters in this word

म (*ma*) + े (the *e-mātrā*) → मे (*me*); then र (*ra*) + ा (long *ā*) → रा (*rā*). Read मे-रा → *merā*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

मेरा (*merā*, “my”) descends from Sanskrit *mad-īya* (“of me”), on the first-person root *ma-* — the same *ma-/me-* behind English **me**, **my**, **mine** and Latin *meus*. The Hindi “my” and the English “my” are, at the root, the same word.

Grammar Lens

“My” agrees with the noun. Hindi possessives change to match what is owned: *merā* (masculine), *merī* (feminine), *mere* (plural). *nām* is masculine, so it takes *merā*: *merā nām*. (You will meet *merī* the first time you own a feminine noun.)

2.3 है (*hai*) — “is,” cousin of English *is*

The letters in this word

ह (*ha*) + ै (the *ai-mātrā*) → है (*hai*). One syllable.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

है (*hai*, “is”) ← Sanskrit अस्ति (*asti*, “is”), from Proto-Indo-European **h₁es-* — the root of “to be” across the whole family: English **is**, German *ist*, Latin *est*, Spanish *es*, French *est*. Hindi *hai* is the Indian cousin of the same little verb — “is” really is one word from Ireland to India.

2.4 मेरा नाम ...है (*merā nām ...hai*) — “my name is...”

मेरा (my) + नाम (name) + name + है (is) = **merā nām ...hai**, “my name is...” *Merā nām Arun hai.* = “My name is Arun.”

Grammar Lens

Word order: the verb goes last. Hindi is a *subject-object-verb* language — literally “my name Arun *is*.” The *hai* sits at the end, where English puts “is” in the middle. Bank this shape: in Hindi, the verb waits until the end of the sentence.

2.5 आप / तुम (*āp / tum*) — “you,” respectful and familiar

The letters in this word

आप: the independent vowel आ (*ā*, word-initial) + प (*pa*) → *āp*. तुम: त (*ta*) + ण (the *u*-sign) + म (*ma*) → *tum*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

तुम (*tum*, familiar “you”) ← Sanskrit *tvam*, from PIE *tū — the same root as English archaic **thou**, Latin *tū*, French *tu*. आप (*āp*, respectful “you”) is a different, honorific word (originally “oneself”).

Grammar Lens

Three levels of “you.” Hindi grades respect in three: *āp* (respectful — strangers, elders, politeness), *tum* (familiar — friends, peers), *tū* (intimate or to a child, and can insult if misused). Each of the earlier tracks had two levels; Hindi has three. For a first meeting, always *āp*.

2.6 क्या (*kyā*) — “what”

The letters in this word

A **conjunct**: क (*ka*) loses its vowel (*halant*) and joins य (*ya*) → क्या (*kyā*); add the long-ā mātrā → क्या (*kyā*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

क्या (*kyā*, “what”) ← Sanskrit *kim* / the interrogative stem *ka-*, from PIE **k^wo-* — the same question-root behind English **wh-** words (**what**, **who**, **which**) and Latin *qu-*. Hindi’s question-words nearly all start with this *k-*: *kyā* (what), *kaun* (who), *kab* (when), *kyūn* (why) — the Indian branch of the same family of question-words.

2.7 आपका नाम क्या है? (*āpkā nām kyā hai*) — “what’s your name?”

आपका (*āpkā*, “your”) = आप (you) + का (*kā*, the possessive “of,” the same agreeing *kā/kī/ke* that matches the noun). So आपका नाम क्या है? is literally “**your name what is?**” — Hindi keeps the verb last again, and simply drops the question-word *kyā* into the object slot.

Grammar Lens

Answer it with the sentence you built: *Merā nām Arun hai*. The informal version swaps *āpkā* for *tumhārā*: *tumhārā nām kyā hai?*

2.8 खुशी (*khushī*) — “happiness,” and “pleased to meet you”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The Hindi “pleased to meet you” is आपसे मिलकर खुशी हुई (*āp-se milkar khushī huī*) — literally “**having met you, happiness happened.**” The key word खुशी (*khushī*, “happiness”) is **not** Sanskrit — it is **Persian** (*khush*, “happy, pleasant”), one of the thousands of Persian

words in everyday Hindi. So even introducing yourself draws on Hindi's *two* vocabularies: Sanskrit (*nām*, *hai*) and Perso-Arabic (*khushī*).

2.9 The whole exchange

Hindi	English
मेरा नाम मीरा है।	My name is Mira.
आपका नाम क्या है?	What's your name?
मेरा नाम अरुण है।	My name is Arun.
आपसे मिलकर खुशी हुई।	Pleased to meet you.

Every atom traced: *nām* (Sanskrit *nāman*, English *name*), *merā* (root *ma-*, English *my*), *hai* (Sanskrit *asti*, English *is*), *kyā* (root *ka-*, English *what*). And two Hindi habits: the **verb goes last**, and “you” has **three** respect-levels. Next chapter: *āp kaise haiñi?* (“how are you?”) and answering with *thīk* — the responding cycle.

Chapter 3

How Are You?

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) 👁 eyes (6) ⇄ **Hands-free start:** all 7 lessons.

After the name comes the exchange everyone actually has — asking, and answering, how someone is:

आप कैसे हैं? (*āp kaise haiṃ* — “How are you?”)
मैं ठीक हूँ, धन्यवाद। (*maiṃ ṭhīk hūṃ, dhanyavād* — “I’m fine, thank you.”)

Every atom traced, then assembled.

3.1 कैसे (*kaise*) — “how,” another of the k-questions

The letters in this word

क (*ka*) + ै (the *ai*-mātrā) → कै (*kai*); स (*sa*) + े (the *e*-mātrā) → से (*se*). Read कै-से → *kaise*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

कैसे (*kaise*, “how”) ← Sanskrit *kīdrśa* (“of what kind”) / the interrogative stem *ka-*, from Proto-Indo-European **k^wo-* — the same question-root behind English **wh-** words and Latin *qu-*. Hindi’s questions nearly all begin with this *k-*: *kyā* (what), *kaun* (who), *kab* (when), *kahāṃ* (where), *kaise* (how).

Grammar Lens

The adjective कैसा (*kaisā*) agrees: *kaisā* (m.), *kaisī* (f.), *kaise* (m. plural / respectful). Because the respectful “you” (*āp*) takes a plural verb, “how are *you*?” uses the plural कैसे.

3.2 आप कैसे हैं? (*āp kaise haiṃ*) — “how are you?”

हैं is है (*hai*, “is”) + the *anusvāra* ँ → हैं (*haiṃ*), the nasalised plural. So आप कैसे हैं? is literally “**you how are?**” — verb last, and because *āp* is grammatically plural (that is how Hindi shows respect), its verb is the plural *haiṃ*, not *hai*.

Grammar Lens

Respect is plural. To an elder or stranger: *āp kaise haiṃ*? To a friend: *tum kaise ho*? (*ho* is the familiar “are”). Match the “you” to the verb: *āp ... haiṃ*, *tum ... ho*.

3.3 मैं (*maiṃ*) — “I,” the m- of the first person**The letters in this word**

म (*ma*) + ैं (*ai*) + the *anusvāra* ँ → मैं (*maiṃ*). One nasal syllable.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

मैं (*maiṃ*, “I”) ← Sanskrit *mayā* (“by me”), on the first-person root *ma-* — the same root behind Chapter 2’s *merā* (“my”) and behind English **me**, **my**, **mine** and Latin *mē*. Hindi’s “I,” its “my,” and English’s “me/my” grow from one ancient first-person sound.

3.4 हूँ (*hūṃ*) — “am,” cousin of English *am***The letters in this word**

ह (*ha*) + ूँ (long *u*) → हूँ (*hū*); the *chandrabindu* ँ nasalises → हूँ (*hūṃ*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

हूँ (*hūṃ*, “am”) ← Sanskrit *asmi* (“I am”) — the first person of the root that also gave you *hai*. That root, PIE *h₁es-, is “to be” across the family: *asmi* → English **am**, Latin *sum*; *asti* → *hai* / English *is*. The copula lines up person by person: हूँ *am*, है *is*, हैं *are*.

3.5 ठीक (*thīk*) — “fine,” and how to answer

The letters in this word

ठ (*tha*, a **retroflex** *th* — tongue curled to the roof of the mouth) + ी (long *ī*) + क (*ka*) → ठीक. The retroflex ट-ठ-ड series is a hallmark of Indian sound.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ठीक (*thīk*) means “correct, right, fine, exactly, OK.” It is a genuinely **native** Indian word — no European cousin — and one of the most useful in the language. Not every word has a far-flung cognate, and that is worth seeing too: *thīk* is Indian to the core.

Put the atoms together: मैं ठीक हूँ (*maiṃ thīk hūṃ*) — “I am fine” (literally “I fine am”). The whole exchange:

— *āp kaise haiṃ?* — *maiṃ thīk hūṃ, dhanyavād.*

3.6 आपका स्वागत है (*āpkā svāgat hai*) — “you’re welcome”

The letters in this word

The key word स्वागत (*svāgat*): the conjunct स्व (स् *s* + व *va* → *sva*) + ग (*ga*) + त (*ta*), with आपका (*āpkā*, “your”) and है (*hai*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

आपका स्वागत है = “your welcome is” → “**you are welcome.**” The heart, स्वागत (*svāgat*), is Sanskrit *su* (“well, good”) + *āgata* (“come”) — “**well come,**” exactly like English *welcome*. Inside it: *su-* the twin of Greek *eu-* (*euphoria*), and *āgata* from the root *gam* (“go/come”), cousin of English **come**. *Svāgatam* survives unchanged in Sanskrit itself.

3.7 The whole exchange

Hindi	English
आप कैसे हैं?	How are you?
मैं ठीक हूँ, धन्यवाद।	I’m fine, thank you.
आपका स्वागत है।	You’re welcome.

Every atom traced: *kaise* (the interrogative *k-*, English *how*), *maiṃ* (root *ma-*, English *me*), *hūṃ* (Sanskrit *asmi*, English *am*), *svāgat* (*su* + *āgata* = “well come”). You now hold the copula trio — *hūṃ* / *hai* / *haiṃ*. Next chapter: the farewells, from the formal *alvidā* to the warm *phir milenge*.

Chapter 4

Farewells

Modes: ⇐ voice (2) 👁 eyes (4) ⇐ Hands-free start: all 6 lessons.

Chapter 1 gave you the grave, formal अलविदा (*alvidā*). Real days end more warmly — with a promise to meet again:

फिर मिलेंगे! (*phir milenge* — “We’ll meet again!”)

4.1 फिर (*phir*) — “again”

The letters in this word

फ (*pha*, an aspirated *p*) + ि (the *i-mātrā*, written before but read after) + र (*ra*) → फिर.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

फिर (*phir*) means “again, then, afterwards” — a native Indo-Aryan adverb with no tidy English cognate, but a familiar *job*: it turns a parting into a promise. English “see you *again*”; Hindi *phir milenge*.

4.2 मिलेंगे (*milenge*) — “(we) will meet”

The letters in this word

मि (*mi*) + ले (*le*) + the *anusvāra* + गे (*ge*) → मिलेंगे (*milenge*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

मिलेंगे (*milenge*, “we will meet”) is the future of मिलना (*milnā*, “to meet, to be found”), from Sanskrit *mil-* (“to join, unite”) — the root of *milan* (“a meeting, union”). The ending -एंगे (*-enge*) is the plural future.

Grammar Lens

The future is an ending, not a helper. *mil-* (“meet”) + *-enge* (“we/they will”) → *milenge*. No word like English “will” — the tense lives in the ending, as person lives in *hūṃ/hai/haiṃ*.

4.3 फिर मिलेंगे (*phir milenge*) — “we’ll meet again”

फिर (again) + मिलेंगे (we will meet) = “we’ll meet again.” Where अलविदा (*alvidā*) is grave and final — and, fittingly, a Perso-Arabic word (*al-widā*, “the farewell”) — *phir milenge* is native, everyday, and hopeful, the sibling of the “promise of return” goodbyes across South Asia (Tamil, Bengali, Marathi all say “I’ll come again”).

Grammar Lens

Two registers: अलविदा (formal, final, Perso-Arabic) versus फिर मिलेंगे (everyday, warm, native). Even more casual: *phir milte haiṃ* (“(we) meet again,” present for a near future).

4.4 कल मिलते हैं (*kal milte haiṃ*) — “see you tomorrow”

The letters in this word

क (*ka*) + ल (*la*) → कल (*kal*). Two simple letters, one tricky word.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

कल (*kal*) means **both “tomorrow” and “yesterday”** — the day on either side of today — from Sanskrit *kāla* (“time”), the very root behind Punjabi’s *akāl* (“timeless”). Context and the verb’s tense tell which: *kal milte haiṃ* (“tomorrow”), *kal milā* (“yesterday”).

Grammar Lens

मिलते हैं (*milte haiṃ*) is literally “(we) meet” — Hindi, like English (“I’m seeing you tomorrow”), uses the present for a scheduled future.

4.5 चलता हूँ (*caltā hūṃ*) — “I’ll be off”

The letters in this word

च (*ca*) + ल (*la*) + long *ā* → चलता (*caltā*), with हूँ (*hūṃ*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

चलता हूँ literally “**I go / I move**” — used like English “I’ll be off.” The verb चलना (*calnā*, “to move, walk, go”) is from Sanskrit *cal-* (“to move, stir”) — the root of *calan* (“circulation”) and *cañcal* (“restless”). Like Bengali *āshi* and Marathi *yeto*, Hindi leaves by saying “I’m *moving*,” never a blunt “I’m leaving.”

Grammar Lens

The verb agrees with the speaker’s gender. A man says चलता हूँ (*caltā hūṃ*); a woman says चलती हूँ (*caltī hūṃ*). The *-tā* / *-tī* ending marks the speaker — a feature English lacks (compare Marathi *yeto* m. / *yete* f.).

4.6 The farewells

Hindi		Register
अलविदा	<i>alvidā</i>	formal, final (Perso-Arabic)
फिर मिलेंगे	<i>phir milenge</i>	everyday, “we’ll meet again”
कल मिलते हैं	<i>kal milte haiṃ</i>	“see you tomorrow”
चलता हूँ	<i>caltā/caltī hūṃ</i>	casual, “I’ll be off”

Roots banked: *milenge* (*mil-* “to join”), *kal* (*kāla* “time,” cousin of Punjabi *akāl*), *caltā* (*cal-* “to move,” the *-tā/-tī* marking the speaker’s gender). Next chapter: the first real verbs — *maiṃ hindī boltā hūṃ* — and Hindi’s sentences begin to move.

Chapter 5

The First Verbs

Modes: ⇄ voice (2) 👁 eyes (4) ⇄ Hands-free start: first 2 of 6 lessons.

Until now, “to be.” Now verbs that *act* — and sentences that move:

मैं हिंदी बोलता हूँ। (*maiṃ hindī boltā hūṃ* — “I speak Hindi.”)

5.1 बोलना (*bolnā*) — “to speak,” your first full verb

The letters in this word

ब (*ba*) + ो (the *o*-mātrā) → बो (*bo*); ल (*la*); ना (*nā*). Read बो·ल·ना → *bolnā*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

बोलना (*bolnā*, “to speak”) is a native Indo-Aryan verb (Prakrit *bolla-*, “to utter”). Its ending -ना (*-nā*) is the point: **every** Hindi infinitive ends in *-nā* — *bol-nā* “to speak,” *cal-nā* “to move,” *mil-nā* “to meet.” Strip the *-nā* and you have the **stem** (*bol-*) that takes every other ending.

Grammar Lens

Stem + ending. The stem *bol-* holds the action; endings pin down who and when: *bol-tā* (speaking, m.), *bol-tī* (f.), *bol-o* (speak!, familiar). Every tense is built by adding to a stem like this.

5.2 मैं हिंदी बोलता हूँ (*maiṃ hindī boltā hūṃ*) — “I speak Hindi”

मैं (I) + हिंदी (Hindi, the object) + बोलता (speak, m.) + हूँ (am) = literally “I Hindi speaking am” — verb-frame last, as always.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The name हिंदी (*hindī*) is a traveller: from *sindhu* (the river Indus) → Persian *hind* (the land beyond it) → *hindī* (“of Hind”). The same *sindhu* gave Greek *Indos* → English **India**, **Indus**, **Hindu**. The language is named, at two removes, after a river.

Grammar Lens

The present habitual = stem + *-tā/-tī* + “to be.”

	Hindi	
a man	मैं हिंदी बोलता हूँ	<i>boltā hūṃ</i>
a woman	मैं हिंदी बोलती हूँ	<i>boltī hūṃ</i>
you (resp.)	आप हिंदी बोलते हैं	<i>bolte haiṃ</i>

The *-tā/-tī/-te* agrees in gender and number; *hūṃ/hai/haiṃ* agrees in person. Two agreements, one small sentence.

5.3 रहना (*rahnā*) — “to live, to stay”

The letters in this word

र (*ra*) + ह (*ha*) + ना (*nā*) → रहना. The familiar infinitive -ना.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

रहना (*rahnā*, “to live, remain, stay”), from Sanskrit *rah-* (“to remain”), covers both “reside” and “keep on”: *maiṃ Dillī meṃ rahtā hūṃ* (“I live in Delhi”), *thīk rahnā* (“stay well”).

Grammar Lens

“In” comes after the noun. मैं दिल्ली में रहता हूँ — the word मैं (*meṃ*, “in”) sits *after* Delhi. Hindi uses **postpositions** where English uses prepositions: “Delhi-in I live,” verb last.

5.4 करना (*karnā*) — “to do,” the most useful verb in Hindi

The letters in this word

क (*ka*) + र (*ra*) + ना (*nā*) → करना.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

करना (*karnā*, “to do, make”) is from the Sanskrit root *kr* (“to do, make”), PIE **k^wer-* — one of the most productive roots in Sanskrit. Its family is already all around you: *karma* (“a thing *done*”), *namaskār* (“the *making* of a bow,” Chapter 1), and the name *Sanskrit* itself (*saṃskṛta*, “put together, perfected”).

Grammar Lens

करना makes verbs out of anything. Noun + *karnā*: *kām karnā* (“work-do” = to work), *bāt karnā* (“talk-do” = to converse), *intizār karnā* (“to wait”). So *maiṃ kām kartā hūṃ* = “I work.”

5.5 Sentences about yourself

Hindi	English
मैं हिंदी बोलता/बोलती हूँ।	I speak Hindi.
मैं दिल्ली में रहता/रहती हूँ।	I live in Delhi.
मैं काम करता/करती हूँ।	I work.

Three verbs, one engine: a stem, the *-tā/-tī/-te* that agrees in gender/number, and the *hūṃ/hai/haiṃ* that agrees in person — the verb always last, “in” always after its noun. Roots banked: *bolnā* (Prakrit *bolla-*), *rahnā* (*rah-* “remain”), *karnā* (*kr* — the root of *karma*, *namaskār*, *Sanskrit*), and *hindī* (*sindhu*, the Indus). From here, Hindi’s sentences only grow.

Chapter 6

Numbers One to Five

Modes: ⇐ voice (3) ✍ pen (2) ⇐ Hands-free start: first 3 of 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can count from one to five in Hindi and hear the older Sanskrit shapes still sitting inside तीन, चार and पाँच.

Say पाँच beside Sanskrit pañca and point to the moon-dot that is all that survives of the lost nasal consonant.

6.1 एक, दो, तीन, चार, पाँच — the five forms

Five words, and a story about how languages age.

You'll want to know — The five

	Hindi	said
1	एक	ek
2	दो	do
3	तीन	tīn
4	चार	chār
5	पाँच	pāñch

If you did the writing track you'll recognise some pieces: क (Lesson 2), त (Lesson 2), न (Lesson 1), र (Lesson 4), and the ाI mātrā (Lesson 3).

Plenty here you haven't been taught to draw yet — ए, च, द, प, the ी and ो mātrās, and the ँ. Read them now; you'll draw them when the writing track reaches them.

The ँ over pāñch is a *chandrabindu*, “moon-dot” — it nasalises the vowel, the way French does in *bon*.

Your turn

- *Say it:* “ek, do, tīn, chār, pām̐ch”
- *Point to:* the familiar क, त, न, र and ा inside the five words
- *Trace it:* the ̐ moon-dot over pām̐ch

Before you move on

Count to five in Hindi. (*Ek, do, tīn, chār, pām̐ch.*) Which mark nasalises the vowel in पाम̐च? (The **chandrabindu**, “moon-dot.”) Do you need to draw every unfamiliar letter today? (**No** — read them now and draw them when their stroke lessons arrive.) Next: watch the Sanskrit forms wear smooth.

6.2 तीन and चार — weight moves from consonants to vowels

The five modern forms did not jump straight from Sanskrit. The Prakrits did most of the wearing-down in between.

You’ll want to know — Put the stages side by side

Sanskrit	→ Prakrit →	Hindi
<i>éka-</i>	<i>ekka</i>	ek
<i>dvá-</i>	<i>do</i>	do
neuter <i>trīṇi</i>	<i>tiṇṇi</i>	tīn
neuter <i>catvāri</i>	<i>cattāri</i>	chār
<i>pāñca</i>	<i>pañca</i>	pām̐ch

Three and four come from the **neuter** forms. Sanskrit also had masculine *tráyah*, but Hindi *tīn* continues *trīṇi*. The same choice gives *catvāri* → *chār*.

You’ll want to know — The two-step weight trade

1. *trīṇi* → *tiṇṇi*: *r* is lost and **ṇ** **doubles** to make up the weight. Long *ī* shortens because the doubled consonant already makes the syllable heavy.
2. *tiṇṇi* → *tīn*: the double simplifies and the **vowel lengthens** to pay for the lost consonant weight.

The vowel ends long again after being short in the middle. *Ekka* → *ek* shows the second half of the same trade.

This is not decay in a bad sense; it is what heavy use does over two thousand years. The same ancient number wore down on another continent:

	ancient	modern
Latin → Spanish	<i>quattuor</i>	<i>cuatro</i>
Sanskrit → Hindi	<i>catvāri</i>	<i>chār</i>

Same PIE word, two continents, two ordinary histories.

Your turn

- *Say it*: “trīṇi ... tiṇṇi ... tīn”
- *Say it*: “catvāri ... cattāri ... **chār**”
- *Compare*: “quattuor → cuatro · catvāri → chār”

Before you move on

Which Sanskrit forms underlie *tīn* and *chār*? (**Neuter** *trīṇi* and *catvāri*.) What sits between Sanskrit and Hindi? (The **Prakrits**.) In *trīṇi* → *tiṇṇi* → *tīn*, what trades places? (The lost *r* is paid for by a **double consonant**, then the simplified double by a **long vowel**.) Next: follow the nasal that stayed inside *pāṁich*.

6.3 पाँच — the nasal moved into the vowel

Tīn moved weight between consonants and vowels. *Pāṁich* moves a whole nasal sound into the vowel itself.

You’ll want to know — The nasal that stayed

Sanskrit *pañca* → Hindi *pāṁich*. The **n** did not vanish; Sanskrit’s *ñ* consonant became Hindi’s nasalised *ā*. The ॐ chandrabindu records that nasality above the word.

Say *pāṁich* and *pañca* one after the other. You can hear the nasal migrating backward from its own consonant into the vowel.

Your turn

- *Say it:* “pañca ... pānich”
- *Hum:* hold the nasal through the vowel in *pānich*
- *Point to:* ँ, the moon-dot that records it

Before you move on

Did the nasal in *pañca* disappear? (**No** — it moved into the vowel.)
 What records it in पाँच? (The **chandrabindu**.) Count one to five
 once more. (*Ek, do, tīn, chār, pānich.*)

6.4 म — one character, met inside words you already say

A horizontal head-line (shirorekha) runs across the top; letters hang beneath it like laundry on a line.

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: म

म — *ma*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *m*, it is **ma**.

What it is made of:

- a lower loop
- an upper loop
- right spine
- top bar

You already say these, and every one of them has म somewhere inside it:

- नमस्ते *namaste* — hello / goodbye (namaste — “I bow to you”)
- न, म *na, ma* — the first two Devanagari letters

- मेरा *merā* — my
- मेरा नाम *merā nām* — assemble my name from known letters and show word spacing as two head-lines

Writing: म — copy what you see

Put your pen on म and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find म in the ones that have it
नमस्ते · न, म · शिरोरेखा
- *Trace it:* म three times, saying *ma* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find म once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — म? What sound does it carry? (*ma.*)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

6.5 र — one character, met inside words you already say

A horizontal head-line (shirorekha) runs across the top; letters hang beneath it like laundry on a line.

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: र

र — *ra*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *r*, it is **ra**.

What it is made of:

- a top-to-bottom stem curling clockwise around the lower loop
- a diagonal tail
- the top shirorekha

You already say these, and every one of them has र somewhere inside it:

- शिरोरेखा *shirorekha* — the head-line that Devanagari letters hang from
- मेरा *merā* — my
- र, स *ra, sa* — र (ra) and स (sa)
- मेरा नाम *merā nām* — assemble my name from known letters and show word spacing as two head-lines

Writing: र

- **1.** start at the headline junction, descend the stem, and curl left and clockwise around the lower loop to the tail junction
- **2.** lift at that junction and draw the diagonal tail down-right
- **3.** lift and draw the top shirorekha left-to-right

Pen lifts: 2. The pen comes up 2 times and no more.

Verified three-stroke teaching form; another animated learner source joins the loop and diagonal tail.

This is one attested teaching order and not a national standard — handwriting here is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: Opiaterein, ‘Deva-र-order.gif’, strokes 1–3, Wikimedia Commons, 10 May 2009.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find र in the ones that have it

शिरोरेखा · मेरा · नमस्ते

- *Trace it:* र three times, saying *ra* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find र once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — र? What sound does it carry? (*ra.*)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 7

Yes and No

Modes: ⇐ voice (2) ✍ pen (2) ⇐ Hands-free start: first 2 of 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say yes and no in Hindi and use नहीं to negate a whole sentence.

Say नहीं, put it in front of a verb — मैं नहीं जानता — and hear the single PIE *ne behind no, non and nein.

7.1 हँ (hām̐) — yes

A single open vowel, said through the nose — that’s Hindi’s yes.

You’ll want to know — The word

हँ = yes, said hām̐. It’s the letter ह (h) with the ा sign for long ā, and — the key mark — the ँ on top: the **chandrabindu**, the “moon-dot.” It does one thing: it **nasalises** the vowel. So hām̐ isn’t “hah” but a humming hāā̃, the sound sent up through the nose, the way French does in *bon*.

(Don’t confuse the moon-dot ँ with the plain dot ः *anusvara* you’ll see in the next word — both nasalise, but the moon-dot rides a vowel that has nothing above it, like ाI.)

You’ll want to know — Saying it politely

A bare hām̐ is a normal, friendly yes. To an elder, a stranger, or anyone you’d show respect, Hindi adds the honorific जी (jī):

जी हँ — jī hām̐ — “yes” (polite)

jī on its own is already a respectful “yes.” You met *-jī* on names; here it warms up a plain yes into a courteous one.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hām̐” — let the *ā* hum through your nose
- polite — “jī hām̐”
- spot the mark — the moon-dot ँ is what nasalises it

Before you move on

How do you say yes in Hindi? (**hām̐**, हँ.) What does the **chandrabindu** ँ do to the vowel? (**Nasalises** it — sends it through the nose.) How do you make *hām̐* polite? (Add **जी** — *jī* *hām̐*.) Next: **नहीं**, no.

7.2 नहीं (nahīm̐) — no / not

Hindi’s “no” carries a sound so old it also sits inside German and Latin.

You’ll want to know — The word

नहीं = **no**, said **nahīm̐** — न (na) + ह (h) + ी (long *ī*) + the ँ *anusvara* that nasalises the end. The heart of it is that first syllable **na**, which is Hindi’s ancient negator, straight from **Sanskrit na**.

You’ll want to know — The oldest “no” you’ll meet

That **na** is not just Sanskrit’s — it is the same negative root that runs across nearly every Indo-European language, all descended from one ancient sound, **PIE *ne:**

from ***ne**

Sanskrit <i>na</i>	→ Hindi nahīm̐
Latin <i>nōn</i>	→ Spanish no , French non
Germanic	→ German nein , English no / not

German’s *nein* carries this exact idea (“not one”); here it is again at the other end of the family, in Hindi. The word for *no* is one of the most stubbornly unchanged things human languages have.

You’ll want to know — One word, two jobs

Like Spanish *no*, **nahīm** is both the **answer** and the **sentence-negator**:

- **answer**: आप आ रहे हैं? — नहीं. (“Are you coming?” — “No.”)
- **negator**: मैं नहीं जानता — “I do **not** know.”

So this single word gives you both “no” and how to make a sentence negative.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “nahīm” — nasal at the end, from the *anusvara*
- the ancient root — “na... nōn... nein... no”: one PIE *ne*
- as a negator — “maĩ nahīm jāntā”, “I don’t know”

Before you move on

How do you say no in Hindi? (**nahīm**, नहीं.) What Sanskrit word is its core, and what ancient sound is that from? (**na**, from **PIE *ne**.) Which other course words share that root? (Latin *nōn*, German *nein*, English *no/not* — and Spanish/French *no/non*.) Besides “no,” what else does *nahīm* do? (It **negates a sentence** — *maĩ nahīm jāntā*, “I don’t know.”)

7.3 न — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ढ — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: न

न — *na*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *n*, it is **na**.

What it is made of:

- a left bowl
- right spine
- top bar

You already say these, and every one of them has न somewhere inside it:

- नमस्ते *namaste* — hello / goodbye (namaste — “I bow to you”)
- न, म *na, ma* — the first two Devanagari letters
- मेरा नाम *merā nām* — assemble my name from known letters and show word spacing as two head-lines
- नमस्ते *namaste* — assemble namaste

Writing: न — copy what you see

Put your pen on न and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find न in the ones that have it

नमस्ते · न, म · शिरोरेखा

- *Trace it:* न three times, saying *na* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find न once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — न? What sound does it carry? (*na*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

7.4 क — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: र — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: क

क — *ka*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *k*, it is **ka**.

What it is made of:

- a counterclockwise left bowl
- a top-to-bottom central stem
- a separate right-hand arch
- the top shirorekhā

You already say these, and every one of them has क somewhere inside it:

- नमस्कार — hello (namaskār — more formal)
- क, त *ka, ta* — write ka and ta
- क्या *kyā* — what
- कैसे *kaise* — how (also कैसा/कैसी, agreeing)

Writing: क

- **1.** start at the bowl's upper-right junction and sweep left over the top, down around the left side, and back to the lower-right junction
- **2.** lift and draw the central stem top-to-bottom
- **3.** lift at the upper junction and sweep the right-hand arch clockwise down to its open lower tip
- **4.** lift and draw the top shirorekḥā left-to-right

Pen lifts: 3. The pen comes up 3 times and no more.

Verified four-stroke teaching form; everyday handwriting may join or simplify the body differently.

This is one attested teaching order and not a national standard — handwriting here is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: Opiaterein, ‘Deva-क-order.gif’, strokes 1–4, Wikimedia Commons, 8 May 2009.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find क in the ones that have it

नमस्कार · नमस्ते

- *Trace it:* क three times, saying *ka* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find क once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — क? What sound does it carry? (*ka.*)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 8

Please

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ✍ pen (2) ⇄ Hands-free start: first 1 of 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say please in Hindi, both with कृपया and with the polite verb ending everyday speech actually prefers.

Say कृपया with its vocalic ऋ, unpack it as 'of your compassion', then switch to the everyday बैठिए, 'please sit'.

8.1 कृपया (kṛpayā) — please (kindly)

Hindi's dictionary word for “please” is really the word **compassion** in disguise — and it's more formal than you might expect.

You'll want to know — The word

कृपया = **please**, literally “**kindly / graciously**.” It's built on the Sanskrit noun कृपा (*kṛpā*), “**grace, compassion, mercy**” — so asking with *kṛpayā* means, at heart, “of your compassion.”

That places Hindi in good company: **Arabic** asks *min faḍlik* (“from your **grace**”), and the Dravidian languages ask with *daya* (“**compassion**”). A whole swathe of Asia says *please* by naming the kindness it hopes for — a different instinct from French's “if it **pleases** you.”

The first letter hides a sound you met in the syllabary track: कृ is *ka* carrying the **vocalic r** (the ृ mark) — *kṛ*, the same *r* vowel Sanskrit and the Dravidian scripts share.

You'll want to know — Be honest about how it's used

Here's the catch a textbook often hides: कृपया is formal and bookish. You'll see it on signs and hear it in announcements (“*kṛpayā* mind the gap”), but in everyday speech Hindi speakers rarely say it. Real politeness usually rides on **the verb** instead — the respectful request ending -इए / -इएगा (-*iye* / -*iyegā*): *baiṭhiye* “please sit,” *sunīye* “please listen.” And very often, people simply say the English word “please.”

So learn *kṛpayā* to read it and to be formally polite — but know that the living “please” of Hindi is baked into the verb.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*kṛpayā*” — *kṛ* with the vocalic *r*, then -*payā*
- the root — “*kṛpā* = compassion” → “of your compassion”
- the everyday way — the verb ending: “*baiṭhiye*” = “please sit”

Before you move on

What is the formal Hindi word for please? (कृपया *kṛpayā*.) What does its root *kṛpā* mean, and which other languages ask the same way? (“**Grace / compassion**” — like Arabic *min faḍlik* and Dravidian *daya*.) Is *kṛpayā* what people usually say out loud? (No — it's formal; everyday politeness rides on the verb ending -*iye*/-*iyegā*, or people say English “please.”)

8.2 अ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: न — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: अ

अ — *a*.

It is an **independent vowel** — the shape the vowel *a* takes when a word begins with it, rather than the sign it becomes inside a word.

What it is made of:

- a joined upper-and-lower left body
- a middle shoulder
- a right vertical stem
- the top shirorekhā

You already say these, and every one of them has अ somewhere inside it:

- अलविदा — goodbye (alvidā — a final farewell, Persian/Arabic-derived)

Writing: अ

- **1.** curve around the upper bowl, then continue down and around the lower bowl without lifting
- **2.** lift and sweep the middle shoulder right
- **3.** lift and draw the right stem top-to-bottom
- **4.** lift and draw the top shirorekhā left-to-right

Pen lifts: 3. The pen comes up 3 times and no more.

Verified modern printed teaching form; other Devanagari traditions split the body into more strokes.

This is one attested teaching order and not a national standard — handwriting here is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: Saurmandal, ‘Devanagari अ stroke order.svg’, frames 1–4, Wikimedia Commons, 5 August 2023.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find अ in the ones that have it
अलविदा · नमस्ते
- *Trace it:* अ three times, saying *a* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find अ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — अ? What sound does it carry? (*a*)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

8.3 े — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: क — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: े

े — *e*.

It is a **vowel sign**. It is not a letter and never stands alone: it attaches to a consonant and **replaces** the *a* built into it with *e*. Replaces, not adds — the *a* is gone.

Where it sits: a stroke above the top bar.

Worked through: म + े = मे — *me*.

You already say these, and every one of them has े somewhere inside it:

- नमस्ते *namaste* — hello / goodbye (namaste — “I bow to you”)
- शिरोरेखा *shirorekha* — the head-line that Devanagari letters hang from
- मेरा *merā* — my
- मेरा नाम *merā nām* — assemble my name from known letters and show word spacing as two head-lines

Writing: े — copy what you see

Put your pen on े and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in

front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ࣳ in the ones that have it
नमस्ते · शिरोरेखा
- *Trace it:* ࣳ three times, saying *e* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ࣳ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ࣳ? What vowel does it put on the consonant it attaches to — and what does it take off? (**Puts *e* on; takes the built-in *a* off.**) Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 9

Sorry

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) ✍️ pen (2) 🗣️ Hands-free start: first 1 of 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can apologise in Hindi with माफ़ कीजिए and reach for its more formal cousin when the moment calls for it.

Say माफ़ कीजिए as ‘please do forgiveness’, then क्षमा करें when the setting is formal.

9.1 माफ़ कीजिए (māf kījiye) — please forgive me / sorry

You already know the formal कृपया (*kṛpayā*), “please.” Hindi’s everyday “sorry” is built the same way you build a request: **name the kindness, ask for it to be done.**

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

- माफ़ (*māf*) = “**forgiven, pardoned**” — not a native Hindi word at all! It’s borrowed through **Persian** from **Arabic** عفو (*‘afw*), “to pardon, efface, wipe away [a wrong].” Look closely at the spelling: the dot under फ़ (called a **nuqtā**) turns the plain *pha* sound into **fa** — Hindi’s way of writing sounds that arrived from Persian and Arabic.
- कीजिए (*kījiye*) = the **respectful imperative** “**please do,**” from करना (*karnā*), “to do.”

So माफ़ कीजिए is literally “**please do forgiven[-ness]**” — *please make [this] forgiven*. It’s the same light-verb move you’ve already met: naming a state (forgiveness, kindness, compassion) and asking someone to *do* it.

You’ll want to know — Be honest about register — and about English creeping in

माफ़ कीजिए is warm and genuinely everyday — but Hindi keeps a **more formal, Sanskritic** cousin for writing and ceremony: क्षमा करें (*kṣamā karēṁ*), “please grant **kṣamā**” — from Sanskrit क्षमा (*kṣamā*), “patience, forbearance, forgiveness.” Where *kṛpayā* was the bookish “please,” **kṣamā karēṁ** is the bookish “sorry.”

And here’s the honest twist: in casual conversation, many Hindi speakers simply say the **English word “sorry”** outright — it has been fully adopted into everyday Hindi, the same way English “please” sometimes stands in for *kṛpayā*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “māf” — forgiven — then “kījiye,” please do
- the whole phrase — “māf kījiye” = please forgive me
- the formal cousin — “kṣamā karēṁ”

Before you move on

What does माफ़ कीजिए literally mean? (“**Please do forgiven[-ness]**” — *māf* “forgiven” + *kījiye* “please do.”) Where does *māf* come from? (**Borrowed via Persian from Arabic** *‘afw*, “to pardon.”) What’s the more formal, Sanskritic cousin? (क्षमा करें *kṣamā karēṁ*, from *kṣamā* “patience/forgiveness.”) What do many Hindi speakers just say instead, casually? (**The English word “sorry.”**)

9.2 आ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: अ — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: आ

आ — $\bar{a}$.

It is an **independent vowel** — the shape the vowel $\bar{a}$ takes when a word begins with it, rather than the sign it becomes inside a word.

What it is made of:

- the joined upper-and-lower left body of अ
- a middle shoulder
- an inner vertical stem
- a trailing vertical stem
- the top shirorekha

You already say these, and every one of them has आ somewhere inside it:

- आप / तुम — you (respectful / familiar)
- आपका नाम क्या है? — what's your name?
- आप कैसे हैं? — how are you? (respectful)
- आपका स्वागत है — you're welcome (also “welcome!”)

Writing: आ

1. curve around the upper bowl, then continue down and around the lower bowl without lifting
2. lift and sweep the middle shoulder right
3. lift and draw the inner stem top-to-bottom

- 4. lift and draw the trailing stem top-to-bottom
- 5. lift and draw the top shirorekḥā left-to-right

Pen lifts: 4. The pen comes up 4 times and no more.

Verified modern printed teaching form; other Devanagari traditions split the shared आ body into more strokes.

This is one attested teaching order and not a national standard — handwriting here is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: Saurmandal, ‘Devanagari आ stroke order.svg’, frames 1–5, Wikimedia Commons, 5 August 2023.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find आ in the ones that have it
आप / तुम · आपका नाम क्या है? · नमस्ते
- *Trace it:* आ three times, saying ā as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find आ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — आ? What sound does it carry? (ā.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

9.3 प — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: े — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: प

प — *pa*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *p*, it is **pa**.

What it is made of:

- a left stem curving around the lower bowl to its upper-right junction
- a top-to-bottom right stem
- the top shirorekha

You already say these, and every one of them has प somewhere inside it:

- आप / तुम — you (respectful / familiar)
- आपका नाम क्या है? — what's your name?
- पाँच *pāñch* — Sanskrit's nasal consonant survives inside the Hindi vowel
- कृपया *kṛpayā* — please (kṛpayā — “kindly,” from kṛpā “grace/compassion”)

Writing: प

1. descend the left stem, then curve right around the lower bowl and rise to its upper-right junction without lifting
2. lift and draw the right stem top-to-bottom
3. lift and draw the top shirorekha left-to-right

Pen lifts: 2. The pen comes up 2 times and no more.

Verified three-stroke teaching form; everyday handwriting may join or simplify the bowl differently.

This is one attested teaching order and not a national standard — handwriting here is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: Opiaterein, ‘Deva-प-order.gif’, strokes 1–3, Wikimedia Commons, 10 May 2009.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find प in the ones that have it

नमस्ते

- *Trace it:* प three times, saying *pa* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find प once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — प? What sound does it carry? (*pa.*)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 10

Days of the Week

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) 👁 eyes (1) ✍ pen (2) ⇄ Hands-free start: none of the 4 lessons.

***By the end of this chapter:** I can name all seven days of the week in Hindi and say which planet each day is named for.*

Recite सोमवार through रविवार end to end, naming Saturn's day and the Sun's day to close the planet-week.

10.1 सोमवार to शुक्रवार — Hindi's own planet-week

You've seen Spanish, Latin, and French name their weekdays for planet-gods. Here's the surprise: **Hindi does too** — with its own, independent set of gods.

You'll want to know — The pattern: [deity] + वार, “day”

Every Hindi weekday is a **deity's name** plus वार (*vār*), “day” (Sanskrit *vāra*):

Hindi	literally	deity/planet	day
सोमवार (<i>somavār</i>)	Soma’s day	the Moon	Monday
मंगलवार (<i>maṅgalvār</i>)	Mangala’s day	Mars	Tuesday
बुधवार (<i>budhvār</i>)	Budha’s day	Mercury	Wednesday
गुरुवार (<i>guruvār</i>)	Guru’s day	Jupiter (<i>Bṛhaspati</i> , called “Guru,” teacher of the gods)	Thursday
शुक्रवार (<i>śukravār</i>)	Śukra’s day	Venus	Friday

You’ll want to know — Be honest about where this system came from

This is **the same seven-body idea** as Rome’s planetary week — Sun, Moon, Mercury, Venus, Mars, Jupiter, Saturn — and it is **not** an isolated Indian invention: historians trace it, ultimately, to a shared source in **Babylonian astronomy**, and most accounts hold that it reached both Rome and India through the **same Hellenistic-Greek channel** of transmission (India’s own horoscopic-astrology texts, like the *Yavanajātaka*, are explicitly adapted from Greek originals). The exact path and timing into India are still debated among historians of astronomy, but the system isn’t a case of Rome and India copying each other directly — both are more like **cousins**, downstream of one much older shared idea of the sky.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “somavār” — Soma/Moon’s day — then “maṅgalvār,” Mangala/Mars’s day
- the pattern — “[deity] + vār” = [deity]’s day
- “guruvār” — Thursday — Bṛhaspati, called “Guru”

Before you move on

What does every Hindi weekday end in, and what does it mean? (वार *vār*, “day.”) Which planet is गुरुवार, and what title does its deity carry? (**Jupiter** — the deity Br̥haspati, called “**Guru**,” teacher of the gods — an ancient title Br̥haspati bears, not the source of the word itself.) Did Hindi borrow its planet-week from Rome? (**No** — both likely trace back through **Hellenistic Greece** to a shared **Babylonian** astronomical source, though the exact route into India is still debated.)

10.2 शनिवार and रविवार — Saturday and Sunday, no rewrite needed

You’ve met five Hindi weekdays, each a deity’s name plus वार (*vār*), “day.” The last two complete the set — and here, unlike Spanish or French, **nothing ever got renamed**.

You’ll want to know — The last two days

- शनिवार (*śanivār*) = “**Śani’s day**” — **Saturn**.
- रविवार (*ravivār*) = “**Ravi’s day**” — the **Sun** (*Ravi*, one of the Sun’s many Sanskrit names).

You’ll want to know — Be honest about the contrast with Spanish and French

Remember: Spanish’s **sábado/domingo** and French’s **samedi/dimanche** are **not** simple planet-names — Christianity renamed both (Saturn’s day became the *Sabbath*; the Sun’s day became “*the Lord’s day*”). Hindi’s week-end went through **no such rewrite**: शनिवार and रविवार are still, today, plainly “Saturn’s day” and “Sun’s day” — the full planet-week, all seven days, standing untouched by any later religious relabeling.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “śanivār” — Saturn’s day — then “ravivār,” Sun’s day

- the whole week — “somavār, maṅgalvār, budhvār, gurvār, śukravār, śanivār, ravivār”
- the contrast — Spanish/French renamed their weekend; Hindi never did

Before you move on

What do शनिवार and रविवार literally mean? (“**Saturn’s day**” and “**Sun’s day**.”) How is Hindi’s weekend different from Spanish’s or French’s? (**No religious rewrite ever happened** — Hindi kept the plain planet-names for all seven days, while Spanish/French swapped in *Sabbath* / *Lord’s day* for the weekend.)

10.3 ँ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: आ — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: ँ

ँ — *no sound of its own — it takes one away.*

It is a **vowel-killer**. Every consonant in this script arrives with an *a* already inside it — that is what an abugida is. This mark takes the *a* back, leaving the bare consonant. It is how the script writes two consonants in a row.

Where it sits: a stroke below that removes the inherent ‘a’ and forms a conjunct with the next consonant.

Worked through: क + ँ = क् — *k*.

You already say these, and every one of them has ँ somewhere inside it:

- नमस्ते *namaste* — hello / goodbye (namaste — “I bow to you”)
- क्या *kyā* — what
- स्त *sta* — a vowel-less consonant usually fuses with the next consonant into a conjunct
- नमस्ते *namaste* — assemble namaste

Writing: ँ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ँ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ँ in the ones that have it
नमस्ते · क्या · शिरोरेखा
- *Trace it:* ँ three times, and each time say what it does: **it kills the built-in a**
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ँ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ँ? What does it do to the consonant it sits on? (**Takes away the built-in a.**) Name one word you already say that contains it.

10.4 ह — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ण — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ह

ह — *ha*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *h*, it is **ha**.

What it is made of:

- a descending right stem joined to the leftward shoulder and clockwise hooked body
- a separate down-right outer curve and tail
- the top shirorekha

You already say these, and every one of them has ह somewhere inside it:

- मेरा नाम ... है — my name is...
- आपका नाम क्या है? — what's your name?
- आप कैसे हैं? — how are you? (respectful)
- आपका स्वागत है — you're welcome (also “welcome!”)

Writing: ह

- **1.** start at the right stem's headline junction, descend, sweep left through the shoulder, then curve clockwise around the hooked body to its lower-right tip without lifting
- **2.** lift at the body's left junction and sweep down-left around the outer curve, then continue diagonally down-right through the tail
- **3.** lift and draw the top shirorekha left-to-right

Pen lifts: 2. The pen comes up 2 times and no more.

Verified three-stroke teaching form; the corroborating deskbook stages the joined first body in more component steps.

This is one attested teaching order and not a national standard — handwriting here is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: Opiaterein, ‘Deva-ह-order.gif’, strokes 1–3, Wikimedia Commons, 9 May 2009.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ह in the ones that have it
नमस्ते
- *Trace it:* ह three times, saying *ha* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ह once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ह? What sound does it carry? (*ha.*)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 11

Four Core Colours

Modes: ⇄ voice (2) ✍ pen (2) ⇄ Hands-free start: first 2 of 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name black, white, red and blue in Hindi and say which of them came from Sanskrit and which from Persian.

Say लाल and नीला beside काला and सफ़ेद, keeping nīla and 'indigo' honestly linked by trade rather than by sound.

11.1 काला, सफ़ेद (kāla, safed) — black and white

Hindi's word for black hides something bigger inside it: the very same word Sanskrit uses for **time itself** — and for death.

You'll want to know — काला — black, time, and death, tangled together

काला (kāla) = “**black**,” from Sanskrit काल (kāla), a word that covers both “**black/dark**” and “**time**.” Sanskrit's own tradition ties the two together poetically — **time devours everything**, and that devouring is imagined as *dark* — and the same word names the fierce goddess **Kālī** (“the black/dark one”) and stands as an epithet of **Yama**, the god of death. Be honest, though: whether “black” and “time” are truly **one and the same root**, or two separate ancient words that Sanskrit poetry and theology later **fused** into a single idea, is a real, still-debated question among linguists — the cultural connection is certain; the precise etymology underneath it is not.

You'll want to know — सफ़ेद — a Persian loan

सफ़ेद (*safed*) = “white” — borrowed from **Persian** (سفید *safēd*), the same kind of Persian-into-Hindi borrowing you’ve already met in माफ़ (*māf*, “forgiven,” from the “sorry” lesson). Notice the नुक्ता (*nuqtā*, the dot under फ़): it turns *pha* into **fa**, the tell-tale mark of a sound that arrived from Persian or Arabic.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “kāla” — time/black/death, then “kāla” — black
- “safed” — white, a Persian loan
- the dot — नुक्ता under फ़ turns pha into fa

Before you move on

What does काला’s root काल (*kāla*) also mean, besides “black”? (“**Time**” — and by extension, **death**; the same word names the goddess **Kālī** and Yama’s epithet **Kāla**.) Is it settled that “black” and “time” are the same root? (**No** — the cultural link is real and ancient, but linguists still debate whether it’s one true root or two words later fused.) Where does सफ़ेद come from? (**Persian** *safēd* — the same kind of loan as *māf*, “sorry.”)

11.2 लाल, नीला (*lāl, nīlā*) — a gemstone’s name, and India’s dye

One more color pair, and one more Persian loan — plus a Sanskrit word connected to why English itself says “**indigo**.”

You'll want to know — लाल — named for a gem, not a color

लाल (*lāl*) = “red” — borrowed from Persian لعل (properly *laʿl*, with a middle *ʿayn* the Hindi/Persian pronunciation *lāl* smooths over), which originally named a specific **deep-red gemstone** (a ruby or spinel), and only later widened to mean the color itself. Hindi’s everyday word for “red” started life as a jeweler’s word.

You'll want to know — नीला — Sanskrit's dark blue, and the world's word for indigo

नीला (*nīlā*) = “**blue**,” from Sanskrit नील (*nīla*), “dark blue” — also the name of the **indigo plant** and its dye. Here's the honest, careful version of a famous connection: English “**indigo**” does **not** come from *nīla* by sound change. It comes from **Greek** *indikón*, simply meaning “**the Indian [thing]**” — because Greek and Roman traders imported the blue dye **from India**. So *nīlā* and “indigo” aren't the same word evolving — they're two **separate** words for the same dye, one Indian (*nīla*, describing the color) and one foreign (*indikón*, describing the dye's *origin*). The connection is real, but it's a connection of **history and trade**, not of sound.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “lāl” — red, originally a gemstone's name
- “nīlā” — blue, from Sanskrit *nīla*
- the honest distinction — *nīla* and “indigo” are two different words linked by trade, not by sound

Before you move on

What did लाल originally name, before it meant “red”? (A **deep red gemstone**, borrowed from Persian.) Does English “**indigo**” come directly from Sanskrit नील *nīla*? (**No** — indigo is from Greek *indikón*, “the Indian [thing],” describing where the dye came from; *nīla* and “indigo” are two separate words connected by history, not by sound change.)

11.3 ऌ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ॠ — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ा

ा — $\bar{a}$.

It is a **vowel sign**. It is not a letter and never stands alone: it attaches to a consonant and **replaces** the a built into it with $\bar{a}$. Replaces, not adds — the a is gone.

Where it sits: a vertical bar to the right of the consonant.

Worked through: न + ा = ना — $n\bar{a}$.

You already say these, and every one of them has ा somewhere inside it:

- शिरोरेखा *shirorekha* — the head-line that Devanagari letters hang from
- मेरा *merā* — my
- क्या *kyā* — what
- मेरा नाम *merā nām* — assemble my name from known letters and show word spacing as two head-lines

Writing: ा — copy what you see

Put your pen on ा and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ा in the ones that have it

शिरोरेखा · मेरा · नमस्ते

- *Trace it:* ा three times, saying $\bar{a}$ as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ा once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ा? What vowel does it put on the consonant it attaches to — and what does it take off? (**Puts *ā* on; takes the built-in *a* off.**) Name one word you already say that contains it.

11.4 य — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ह — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: य

य — *ya*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *y*, it is **ya**.

What it is made of:

- a clockwise inner curl
- a lower bowl rising to the right-stem junction
- a top-to-bottom right stem
- the top shirorekḥā

You already say these, and every one of them has य somewhere inside it:

- धन्यवाद — thank you (dhanyavād — formal, Sanskritic)
- शुक्रिया — thanks (shukriyā — everyday, Persian/Arabic-derived)
- क्या *kyā* — what
- कृपया *kṛpayā* — please (kṛpayā — “kindly,” from kṛpā “grace/compassion”)

Writing: य

- **1.** start beneath the headline, curve clockwise around the inner curl, and finish at the left waist
- **2.** lift at that waist, curve down and right around the lower bowl, and rise to the right-stem junction
- **3.** lift and draw the right stem top-to-bottom
- **4.** lift and draw the top shirorekha left-to-right

Pen lifts: 3. The pen comes up 3 times and no more.

Verified four-stroke teaching form; another animated learner source joins the inner curl and lower bowl.

This is one attested teaching order and not a national standard — handwriting here is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: Opiaterein, ‘Deva-य-order.gif’, strokes 1–4, Wikimedia Commons, 10 May 2009.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find य in the ones that have it
धन्यवाद · शुक्रिया · नमस्ते
- *Trace it:* य three times, saying *ya* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find य once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — य? What sound does it carry? (*ya.*)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 12

Family

Modes:  voice (2)  pen (2)  Hands-free start: first 2 of 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name my father, mother, brother and sister in Hindi.

Say भाई and बहन beside पिता and माता, and name which one is a true cousin of English 'brother' and which is not.

12.1 पिता, माता (pitā, mātā) — father and mother, cousins across a huge family

You've already met Latin **pater/māter** and their English cousins **father/mother** — all descending from one ancient shared word. Hindi keeps a cousin of its own, in the very same family.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

- पिता (*pitā*) = “**father**” — Sanskrit पितृ (*pitṛ*), from the **same PIE root, *ph₂tēr***, as Latin *pater* and English *father*.
- माता (*mātā*) = “**mother**” — Sanskrit मातृ (*mātr*), from ***méh₂tēr***, the same root as Latin *māter* and English *mother*.

So *pitā* and *father* are, at the deepest level, the **same ancient word** — reaching you here through Sanskrit rather than through Latin or Germanic, one more branch of the same very old family tree.

You'll want to know — Be honest about register — the everyday words

पिता/माता are correct, respectable Hindi — but the words you'll hear **most often in daily life** are different: बाप (*bāp*, “father,” an everyday/colloquial word) and माँ (*māṁi*, “mother,” universally the warm, everyday word — closer to English “mom” than “mother”). These aren't uncertain outliers, either — they're **also** Sanskrit-descended, just by a different path than *pitā*/*mātā*: बाप traces through Prakrit to Sanskrit वप्त् (*vapṭr*, “father,” a different Sanskrit root from *pitṛ*), while माँ is a genuine **doublet** of *mātā* — both come from the very same Sanskrit *māṭr*, just worn down along a more colloquial Prakrit line.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “pitā, mātā” — the Sanskrit-descended, formal pair
- “bāp, māṁi” — the everyday, spoken pair
- the deep cousin — “pitā and father are the same ancient PIE word”

Before you move on

What are पिता and माता cousins of, in Latin and English? (**Pater**/father and **māter**/mother — all from the same PIE roots.) What are the everyday, spoken words instead? (बाप **bāp** and माँ **māṁi**.) Are *bāp* and *māṁi* also Sanskrit-descended? (**Yes** — *bāp* traces to Sanskrit *vapṭr*, a different root from *pitṛ*; *māṁi* is a genuine **doublet** of *mātā*, both from *māṭr*.)

12.2 भाई, बहन (bhāī, bahin) — one cousin word, one different word entirely

You've met *frāter* and *soror* as PIE cousins of “brother” and “sister.” Hindi's pair has a genuine surprise hiding in it: only **one** of these two continues that ancient family.

You'll want to know — भाई — the expected cousin

भाई (*bhāī*) = “**brother**” — from Sanskrit भ्रातृ (*bhrātr*), which **does** continue the same PIE root, *b^hréh₂tēr*, as Latin *frāter* and English *brother*. This one is exactly what you'd expect: one more cousin in the same old family.

You'll want to know — बहन — NOT the expected cousin

Sanskrit did have a direct PIE-cognate word for “sister” too: स्वसृ (*svasr*), the very cousin of Latin *soror* and English *sister*. But that word **faded from use**. In its place, Sanskrit built a **different** word, भगिनी (*bhaginī*) — and *that* word, not *svasr*, is the confirmed ancestor of Hindi's everyday बहन (*bahin*). (Where *bhaginī* itself comes from is the less certain part: it's often explained as भग (*bhaga*, “a share, good fortune”) plus a feminine suffix, “the one who shares” — but Sanskritists don't all agree on this, and some suspect it's a reshaping of an older form avoiding an unrelated, indelicate sense of *bhaga*. That deeper question is worth a linguist's extra check; the *bahin* ≠ *svasr* finding itself is solid.)

So Hindi's brother/sister pair is **lopsided** in its ancestry: *bhāī* genuinely continues the ancient PIE word; *bahin* comes from an entirely different Sanskrit formation that **replaced** the PIE-cognate word before Hindi ever inherited it. (Sanskrit-to-Hindi sound history has plenty of non-obvious turns.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “bhāī” — brother — the true PIE cousin of “brother”
- “bahin” — sister — from *bhaginī*, “the one who shares,” NOT from the PIE word for sister
- the asymmetry — one cousin, one completely different word

Before you move on

Does भाई continue the same ancient root as English “brother”? (**Yes** — Sanskrit *bhrātr* < PIE *b^hréh₂tēr*, same as Latin *frāter*.) Does बहन continue the same ancient root as English “sister”? (**No** — Sanskrit's PIE-cognate word, *svasr*, faded; *bahin* comes from भगिनी *bhaginī*, an unrelated Sanskrit formation — often glossed “the one

who shares,” though *bhaginī*’s own deeper origin is itself debated.)

12.3 त — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ऀ — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: त

त — *ta*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *t*, it is **ta**.

What it is made of:

- a small left curl
- a tall spine
- top bar

You already say these, and every one of them has त somewhere inside it:

- नमस्ते *namaste* — hello / goodbye (namaste — “I bow to you”)
- क, त *ka, ta* — write ka and ta
- स्त *sta* — a vowel-less consonant usually fuses with the next consonant into a conjunct
- नमस्ते *namaste* — assemble namaste

Writing: त — copy what you see

Put your pen on त and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find त in the ones that have it
नमस्ते · क, त · शिरोरेखा
- *Trace it:* त three times, saying *ta* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find त once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — त? What sound does it carry? (*ta*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

12.4 ी — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: य — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ी

ी — $\bar{i}$.

It is a **vowel sign**. It is not a letter and never stands alone: it attaches to a consonant and **replaces** the *a* built into it with $\bar{i}$. Replaces, not adds — the *a* is gone.

Where it sits: a curl to the right with a tail over the top bar.

Worked through: द + ी = दी — $d\bar{i}$.

You already say these, and every one of them has ी somewhere inside it:

- खुशी — happiness / pleased to meet you
- ठीक — fine, well, correct — and the reply "मैं ठीक हूँ"
- मैं हिंदी बोलता हूँ — I speak Hindi (gendered)
- बोलता हूँ, बोलती हूँ, बोलते हैं — the present-habitual template — stem + -tā/-tī/-te + honā

Writing: ी — copy what you see

Put your pen on ी and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ी in the ones that have it

खुशी · ठीक · नमस्ते

- *Trace it:* ी three times, saying ī as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ी once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ी? What vowel does it put on the consonant it attaches to — and what does it take off? (**Puts ī on; takes the built-in a off.**) Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 13

Head and Hand

Modes: ⇄ voice (2) ✍ pen (2) ⇄ **Hands-free start:** first 2 of 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the head and the hand in Hindi and trace both back to the Sanskrit words they wore down from.

Say हाथ, then हस्त, then the shape of the change between them: the -st- cluster simplifies and the vowel lengthens.

13.1 सिर (sir) — the head

A short, everyday word — and, once you look, a worn-down piece of a much older Sanskrit word you may recognize from yoga or anatomy.

You'll want to know — The word

सिर (*sir*) = “head” — from Sanskrit शिरस् (*śiras*), “head.” Centuries of everyday use wore the word down from the fuller, formal Sanskrit shape to the short, simple *sir* you use every day.

Sanskrit’s *śiras* root is still alive in more formal/technical registers too — related *śirṣa*-based vocabulary shows up in yoga and Ayurvedic anatomical terms (as in poses and positions named for the head), even while everyday Hindi kept the shorter, worn-down *sir*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “sir” — head
- the fuller Sanskrit source — “śiras”
- worn down over time — “śiras → sir”

Before you move on

What does सिर mean, and what Sanskrit word is it worn down from? (“**Head**” — from शिरस् *śiras*.) Where else does this root show up, in a more formal register? (**Yoga/anatomical terms** built on the related *śīrṣa* root.)

13.2 हाथ (hāth) — the hand

This word looks nothing like its Sanskrit ancestor at first glance — but the change between them follows a real, traceable pattern, not a random drift.

You’ll want to know — The word

हाथ (*hāth*) = “**hand**” — from Sanskrit हस्त (*hasta*), “hand.”

You’ll want to know — The honest sound-change story

Getting from *hasta* to *hāth* isn’t one clean step — it passed through **Prakrit** (the everyday spoken languages that stood between Sanskrit and modern Hindi) along the way: Sanskrit’s **-st-** consonant cluster regularly simplified in Prakrit into a **geminate** (doubled), **aspirated** consonant (giving an intermediate form like *hattha*). Later, as that doubled consonant simplified further down to modern Hindi’s single **-th-**, the **vowel just before it lengthened** — *a* becoming *ā* — as if to make up for the sound that was lost. That’s the general shape of the change: **- st- → (Prakrit geminate aspirate) → single aspirate + a longer vowel** — a recognized pattern in how Sanskrit consonant clusters evolved into modern Hindi, not a one-off coincidence for this word alone.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hāth” — hand
- the Sanskrit source — “hasta”
- the shape of the change — “-st- cluster → simplified consonant + longer vowel”

Before you move on

What does हाथ mean, and what Sanskrit word is it from? (“**Hand**” — from हस्त *hasta*.) What’s the general shape of the sound change between them? (**Sanskrit’s -st- cluster simplified** through Prakrit into a **geminate** aspirated consonant (*hattha*), which later simplified to a single consonant — and the vowel before it **lengthened** to compensate.)

13.3 स — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: त — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: स

स — *sa*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *s*, it is **sa**.

What it is made of:

- a left curl
- a body
- right spine
- top bar

You already say these, and every one of them has स somewhere inside it:

- नमस्ते *namaste* — hello / goodbye (namaste — “I bow to you”)

- र, स *ra, sa* — र (ra) and स (sa)
- स्त *sta* — a vowel-less consonant usually fuses with the next consonant into a conjunct
- नमस्ते *namaste* — assemble namaste

Writing: स — copy what you see

Put your pen on स and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find स in the ones that have it
नमस्ते · र, स · शिरोरेखा
- *Trace it:* स three times, saying *sa* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find स once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — स? What sound does it carry? (*sa.*)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

13.4 च — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ी — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: च

च — *ca*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *c*, it is **ca**.

What it is made of:

- a short upper bar joined to a rounded body opening right
- a top-to-bottom right stem
- the top shirorekha

You already say these, and every one of them has च somewhere inside it:

- चलता हूँ — I'll be off (lit. "I go"), gendered
- एक दो तीन चार पाँच — one to five
- तीन, चार — three and four descend from Sanskrit neuter forms through Prakrit weight trades
- पाँच *pāñch* — Sanskrit's nasal consonant survives inside the Hindi vowel

Writing: च

- 1. draw the short upper bar left-to-right, turn down and left through the shoulder, then curve around the rounded body to its open right junction without lifting
- 2. lift and draw the right stem top-to-bottom
- 3. lift and draw the top shirorekha left-to-right

Pen lifts: 2. The pen comes up 2 times and no more.

Verified three-stroke teaching form; everyday handwriting may join or simplify the body differently.

This is one attested teaching order and not a national standard — handwriting here is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: Opiaterein, 'Deva-च-order.gif', strokes 1–3, Wikimedia Commons, 10 May 2009.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find च in the ones that have it

नमस्ते

- *Trace it:* च three times, saying *ca* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find च once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — च? What sound does it carry? (*ca*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 14

Seasons

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) ✍️ pen (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: first 1 of 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name all six traditional Indian seasons in Hindi, including the one the four-season frame has no word for.

Say all six ऋतु in order and point to वर्षा, the monsoon season no Western four-season label maps onto.

14.1 वसंत, ग्रीष्म, वर्षा, शरद्, हेमंत, शिशिर — six seasons, not four

European languages generally split the year into **four** seasons. Hindi's own tradition doesn't — it recognizes **six**, and this isn't extra vocabulary bolted onto a four-season frame. It's a genuinely different way of dividing the year.

You'll want to know — The six ऋतु (ṛtu, “seasons”)

Hindi	rough Western match
वसंत (<i>vasant</i>)	spring
ग्रीष्म (<i>grīṣma</i>)	summer
वर्षा (<i>varṣā</i>)	monsoon/rains — no Western equivalent
शरद् (<i>śarad</i>)	autumn
हेमंत (<i>hemant</i>)	pre-winter/late autumn
शिशिर (<i>śiśir</i>)	deep winter

This six-season calendar, ऋतु (*ṛtu*), is rooted in classical Sanskrit tradition and Indian astronomy/astrology, and it maps onto the actual climate of much of the Indian subcontinent far better than a four-season frame does: the **monsoon** (*varṣā*) is a real, distinct, and hugely important season there — not a subdivision of “summer” or “autumn,” but its own season with no clean Western counterpart. And the cold season splits into **two** stages, *hemant* (the onset) and *śiśir* (deep winter), rather than being lumped into one “winter.”

You’ll want to know — Be honest: don’t force the four-season frame onto this

It would be a mistake to just match these six words one-to-one against Spanish’s four or French’s four the way earlier lessons matched *tala* to *talai*. The **structure itself is different** — six real seasons, not four plus two extras. Everyday spoken Hindi *does* also use looser, more casual four-part talk about seasons (borrowing straightforwardly from the idea of “summer,” “winter,” etc.), but the traditional, classical ऋतु system is genuinely six-fold, and it’s worth learning as its own thing rather than squeezed into someone else’s frame.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all six — “vasant, grīṣma, varṣā, śarad, hemant, śiśir”
- the one with no Western match — “varṣā,” the monsoon
- the honest point — six seasons is a different STRUCTURE, not extra vocabulary

Before you move on

How many seasons does Hindi’s traditional ऋतु calendar recognize? (**Six**, not four.) Which season has no clean Western equivalent, and why? (वर्षा *varṣā*, the **monsoon** — a real, distinct season central to the subcontinent’s climate.) Is this just extra vocabulary added to a four-season frame? (**No** — it’s a genuinely different structural division of the year.)

14.2 ँ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: च — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ँ

ँ — *a nasal, ridden on the syllable before it.*

It is a **nasal vowel** mark — the vowel itself is spoken through the nose, rather than a nasal consonant being added after it.

You already say these, and every one of them has ँ somewhere inside it:

- चलता हूँ — I'll be off (lit. "I go"), gendered
- मैं हिंदी बोलता हूँ — I speak Hindi (gendered)
- बोलता हूँ, बोलती हूँ, बोलते हैं — the present-habitual template — stem + -tā/-tī/-te + honā
- पाँच *pāñch* — Sanskrit's nasal consonant survives inside the Hindi vowel

Writing: ँ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ँ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ँ in the ones that have it

नमस्ते

- *Trace it:* ǣ three times, humming the nasal at the end of the syllable as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ǣ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ǣ? What does it add to the syllable before it? (**A nasal.**) Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 15

Water and Bread

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ✍ pen (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: first 1 of 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask for water and bread in Hindi and say what पानी literally means.

Ask for पानी and रोटी, then unpack पानी as 'the drinkable one' — pā, to drink, plus -nīya, fit for.

15.1 पानी, रोटी (pānī, roṭī) — water (the “drinkable thing”) and bread

Hindi’s everyday word for water isn’t the ancient Sanskrit word you might expect — it names water by what you **do** with it, not by what it **is**.

You’ll want to know — पानी — “the drinkable thing”

पानी (pānī) = “**water**.” Sanskrit actually has older, more “basic” words for water — आप् (āp) and जल (jala) among them — but Hindi’s everyday word descends from neither. It comes from Sanskrit पानीय (pānīya), built on the verb पा (pā), “**to drink**,” plus a suffix meaning roughly “**fit for**.” So pānīya, and Hindi’s pānī after it, literally means “**the drinkable thing**” — water defined by its use, not named as a substance in its own right.

You'll want to know — रोटी — bread, honestly uncertain in origin

रोटी (*roṭī*) = “bread, flatbread” — the everyday word for the flatbreads (roti, chapati-style breads) central to North Indian meals. Be honest: unlike *pānī*, *roṭī*'s deeper history is **not cleanly traced** back through Sanskrit the way many everyday Hindi words are. It comes through Prakrit रोट्ट (*roṭṭa*, “a kind of bread”) from Sanskrit रोटिका (*roṭikā*); beyond that, one proposal (Turner's Indo-Aryan dictionary) tentatively links it to a root meaning “**to strike / to press or crush**” — perhaps evoking the pounding and flattening of dough — but this is genuinely uncertain, one guess among scholars rather than a settled chain. Worth knowing honestly rather than forcing a confident derivation that isn't there.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “pānī” — water, “the drinkable thing”
- the root — “pā,” to drink, + “-nīya,” fit for
- “roṭī” — bread, flatbread

Before you move on

Does पानी come from Sanskrit's ancient water-words, *āp* or *jala*? (No — from पानीय *pānīya*, “the drinkable thing,” from पा *pā*, “to drink.”) Is रोटी's etymology as clearly traced as *pānī*'s? (No — it traces to Prakrit *roṭṭa* < Sanskrit *roṭikā*, but beyond that the deeper root is genuinely uncertain — one proposal links it to “striking/pressing” dough, not a settled chain.)

15.2 ष — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ॠ — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ष

ष — *ssa*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *ss*, it is **ssa**.

You already say these, and every one of them has ष somewhere inside it:

- वसंत ग्रीष्म वर्षा शरद् हेमंत शिशिर — SIX traditional seasons, not four

Writing: ष — copy what you see

Put your pen on ष and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ष in the ones that have it
- नमस्ते
- *Trace it:* ष three times, saying *ssa* as you finish each one
 - *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ष once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ष? What sound does it carry? (*ssa*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 16

Months

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) ✍️ pen (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: first 1 of 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the twelve months in Hindi and explain why the festivals move against the Gregorian calendar.

Say जनवरी through दिसंबर, then name Chaitra and Vaiśākh and explain that the festivals are dated by Vikram Samvat instead.

16.1 जनवरी to दिसंबर — borrowed names, and a second calendar underneath

Like Arabic, Hindi doesn't have just **one** set of months — everyday civil life and traditional/religious life run on **two different calendars**.

You'll want to know — The Gregorian months — recent, borrowed

For dates, school, business, and government, Hindi uses month names borrowed straightforwardly from **English**:

जनवरी, फ़रवरी, मार्च, अप्रैल, मई, जून, जुलाई, अगस्त, सितंबर, अक्टूबर, नवंबर, दिसंबर (*janvarī, farvarī, mārc, aprail, maī, jūn, jūlāī, agast, sitambar, ak-tūbar, navambar, disambar*) — you can hear “January,” “March,” “August” right through the Hindi pronunciation. This is a modern civil borrowing, not an ancient Sanskrit system.

You’ll want to know — Be honest: the traditional calendar is a genuinely different structure

Hindu tradition keeps its **own**, much older lunisolar calendar — विक्रम संवत् (*Vikram Samvat*) — with twelve **different** month names: चैत्र, वैशाख, ज्येष्ठ, आषाढ़, श्रावण, भाद्रपद, आश्विन, कार्तिक, मार्गशीर्ष, पौष, माघ, फाल्गुन (*Chaitra, Vaiśākh, Jyēṣṭha, Āṣāḍh, Śrāvaṇ, Bhādrapad, Āśvin, Kārtik, Mārgaśīrṣ, Pauṣ, Māgh, Phālgun*).

This isn’t just a second set of labels for the same twelve solar months — these months are tied to the **six-ṛtu** seasonal calendar from the seasons lesson (in the traditional/classical scheme, each pair of Vikram Samvat months corresponds to one of the six *ṛtu*), and major festivals (Holi, Diwali, and many others) are dated by **this** calendar, not the Gregorian one — which is why their Gregorian-calendar date shifts from year to year.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “janvarī, mārc, agast” — hear the borrowed English names
- the traditional calendar — “Chaitra, Vaiśākh, Jyēṣṭha”
- the honest point — festivals shift on the Gregorian calendar because they’re dated by Vikram Samvat instead

Before you move on

Where do Hindi’s everyday civil month names come from? (**Borrowed from English** — *janvarī, mārc, agast...*) What traditional calendar runs alongside it, and what is it tied to? (**Vikram Samvat** — tied to the **six ṛtu** seasons, not the four-season Western frame.) Why do festivals like Holi and Diwali fall on different Gregorian dates each year? (**They’re dated by Vikram Samvat**, a different calendar system entirely.)

16.2 ः — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ष — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ु

ु — *u*.

It is a **vowel sign**. It is not a letter and never stands alone: it attaches to a consonant and **replaces** the *a* built into it with *u*. Replaces, not adds — the *a* is gone.

Where it sits: a small hook below the consonant.

Worked through: त + ु = तु — *tu*.

You already say these, and every one of them has ु somewhere inside it:

- शुक्रिया — thanks (shukriyā — everyday, Persian/Arabic-derived)
- आप / तुम — you (respectful / familiar)
- खुशी — happiness / pleased to meet you
- सोमवार मंगलवार बुधवार गुरुवार शुक्रवार — Monday–Friday

Writing: ु — copy what you see

Put your pen on ु and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ु in the ones that have it

शुक्रिया · नमस्ते

- *Trace it:* ु three times, saying *u* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ु once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — **g**? What vowel does it put on the consonant it attaches to — and what does it take off? (**Puts *u* on; takes the built-in *a* off.**) Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 17

Noon and Midnight

Modes:  voice (1)  pen (1)  Hands-free start: first 1 of 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say noon and midnight in Hindi and explain the old three-hour pahar hidden inside दोपहर.

Say दोपहर as 'two pahars' and आधी रात as 'half night', contrasting one built on an old time-unit with one built plainly.

17.1 दोपहर, आधी रात — noon by an old clock, midnight fully transparent

Hindi's word for noon hides a whole traditional timekeeping system inside it — one very different from hours and minutes.

You'll want to know — दोपहर — “two pahars”

दोपहर (*dopahar*) = “**noon, midday**” — literally “**two** (*do*) + **pahar**.” A पहर (*pahar*, from Sanskrit *prahara*) is a traditional Indian unit of time, roughly **three hours** long, with the day traditionally divided into eight *pahars* (four for daytime, four for night), counted from sunrise. Noon falls right around the end of the **second** daytime *pahar* after sunrise — so *do-pahar*, “two pahars [in],” became the everyday word for midday. (This traditional *pahar*-based account is the standard one, though — as with any folk-timekeeping etymology this old — treat the exact number of *pahars* as the general shape of the story rather than a precisely dated fact.)

You'll want to know — आधी रात — fully transparent “half night”

आधी रात (*ādhī rāt*) = “**midnight**,” literally “**half night**” — आधी (*ādhī*, the feminine form of आधा, *ādhā*, “half”) + रात (*rāt*, “night”). No erosion, no double meaning — structurally identical to Latin’s *media nox* and Spanish’s *medianoche*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “pahar” — a traditional ~3-hour watch — then “do-pahar,” two pahars, noon
- “ādhī rāt” — half night, midnight
- the contrast — dopahar counts an old time-unit; ādhī rāt is plainly “half” + “night”

Before you move on

What does दोपहर literally mean, and what’s a *pahar*? (“**Two pahars**” — a *pahar* being a traditional ~3-hour time-unit, with noon falling around the end of the second one after sunrise.) What does आधी रात literally mean? (“**Half night**” — *ādhī* “half” + *rāt* “night,” fully transparent, just like Latin’s *media nox*.)

17.2 ल — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ु — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: ल

ल — *la*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *l*, it is **la**.

What it is made of:

- a clockwise open left loop
- an up-right diagonal arm
- a top-to-bottom right stem
- the top shirorekhā

You already say these, and every one of them has ल somewhere inside it:

- अलविदा — goodbye (alvidā — a final farewell, Persian/Arabic-derived)
- मिलेंगे *milenge* — (we) will meet
- फिर मिलेंगे — we'll meet again (goodbye)
- कल मिलते हैं — see you tomorrow (and the कल puzzle)

Writing: ल

- 1. start at the open lower-left tip, curve up and clockwise around the left loop, and finish at the inner junction
- 2. lift at that junction and sweep the diagonal arm up-right to the right stem
- 3. lift and draw the right stem top-to-bottom
- 4. lift and draw the top shirorekhā left-to-right

Pen lifts: 3. The pen comes up 3 times and no more.

Verified four-stroke teaching form; another animated learner source writes the same parts in a stem-first order.

This is one attested teaching order and not a national standard — handwriting here is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: Opiaterein, ‘Deva-ल-order.gif’, strokes 1–4, Wikimedia Commons, 11 May 2009.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ल in the ones that have it

अलविदा · मिलेंगे · नमस्ते

- *Trace it:* ल three times, saying *la* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ल once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ल? What sound does it carry? (*la*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 18

Telling Time

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) ✍️ pen (1) 📞 Hands-free start: first 1 of 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can tell someone what o'clock it is in Hindi.

Say एक बज रहा है and दो बज रहे हैं — the hour striking, exactly as the ghaṇṭā bell once did.

18.1 घंटा — “hour,” literally “bell”

Here’s a word that wears its history on its sleeve: Hindi’s word for “hour” is the exact same word as “bell.”

You’ll want to know — घंटा — bell AND hour, one word

घंटा (ghaṇṭā) = “hour” — and it means “bell, gong” just as commonly. It comes from Sanskrit घण्टा (ghaṇṭā), “bell, gong.” The connection isn’t a coincidence: temples, towns, and later clock towers historically marked the passing of time by **striking a bell** — the hour was announced by sound, not read off a face — so the word for the bell itself came to mean the unit of time it announced. Compare this to English **o’clock**, itself a worn-down “**of the clock**,” or French’s **il est ... heures**: different languages, but time-telling vocabulary keeps circling back to the *instrument* used to mark it.

Grammar Lens: बजना — “to strike, to toll”

Hindi tells the time with the verb बजना (bajnā), “to strike, to toll” — the same imagery as a bell striking the hour:

एक बज रहा है। — “It is one o’clock.” (literally “**one is striking**”) दो बज रहे हैं। — “It is two o’clock.” (literally “**two are striking**”)

Just like Spanish switches from singular *es* to plural *son* after “one,” Hindi switches बज रहा है (singular) to बज रहे हैं (plural) once the count passes one — matching the number, not just tacking on “o’clock.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ghaṇṭā” — hour, also “bell”
- “ek baj raha hai” — it is one o’clock, “one is striking”
- “do baj rahe hain” — it is two o’clock, “two are striking”

Before you move on

What does घंटा literally mean besides “hour”? (“**Bell, gong**” — from Sanskrit *ghaṇṭā*.) Why did “bell” come to mean “hour”? (Because clocks/towns historically **struck a bell** to announce the hour.) What verb does Hindi use to tell the time, and what does it literally mean? (बजना, *bajnā* — “to strike, to toll,” as in *ek baj raha hai*, “one is striking.”)

18.2 ख — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ल — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: ख

ख — *kha*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *kh*, it is **kha**.

You already say these, and every one of them has ख somewhere inside it:

- शिरोरेखा *shirorekhā* — the head-line that Devanagari letters hang from
- खुशी — happiness / pleased to meet you

Writing: ख — copy what you see

Put your pen on ख and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ख in the ones that have it
शिरोरेखा · खुशी · नमस्ते
- *Trace it:* ख three times, saying *kha* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ख once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ख? What sound does it carry? (*kha*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 19

Asking Someone's Age

Modes: ⇄ voice (2) ✍ pen (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: first 2 of 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask someone's age in Hindi and give my own in the belonging-to-years shape Hindi uses.

Ask तुम कितने साल के हो? and answer मैं बीस साल का हूँ, with के/का carrying the 'belonging to' work.

19.1 उम्र — the same word as Arabic

You just met Arabic's *ʿumr*. Hindi's everyday word for “age” is the **exact same word**, carried through Persian.

You'll want to know — उम्र — a Perso-Arabic loan, and a native alternative

उम्र (*umr*) = “age” — this is **Arabic's ʿumr**, borrowed into Hindi through Persian, and it's the everyday, colloquial word most Hindi speakers use. Hindi also has a fully **native Sanskrit** alternative, आयु (*āyu*, “age, lifespan”), which feels more formal or literary — a register split you've now seen several times (compare Kannada's Sanskrit-tatsama *madhyāhna* vs. Tamil's native words for the same concepts, just flipped here: the **borrowed** word is the everyday one, the **native** word is the formal one).

Your turn

- *Say it:* “umr” — age, same word as Arabic's ʿumr
- *Contrast:* everyday *umr* · formal/literary *āyu*

Before you move on

What language does Hindi's उम्र come from, and what's the native Sanskrit alternative? (**Arabic** *ʿumr*, via Persian; native alternative is आयु, *āyu*.) Which one is ordinary conversational Hindi? (**Umr**.) Next: use a genitive marker to say how many years someone belongs to.

19.2 कितने साल के हो? — belonging to so many years

Languages do not agree on whether age is something you have, are, were born with, or state without a verb. Hindi gives the idea a fifth shape.

You'll want to know — The two sentences

तुम कितने साल के हो? — “How old are you?” (informal), literally “you, **of how many years, are?**” (*tum kitne sāl ke ho?*)

मैं बीस साल का हूँ। — “I am twenty years old,” literally “I [am one] **belonging to twenty years.**” (*main̄ bīs sāl kā hūñ.*)

के/का (*ke/kā*) is Hindi's **genitive postposition**, “of, belonging to.” The same marker family handles possession elsewhere: *merā ghar*, “my house.”

So Hindi does not copy Romance's “I **have** years,” Germanic's simple “I **am** [a number],” Latin's “**born** + N years,” or Arabic's verbless “my age [is] N.” It says “I am [one] **belonging to** N years,” with a genitive marker plus होना (*honā*, “to be”).

Your turn

- *Say it:* “tum kitne sāl ke ho?” — how old are you?
- *Say it:* “main̄ bīs sāl kā hūñ” — I belong to twenty years
- *Point to:* **ke/kā** — the genitive, “of/belonging to”

Before you move on

What does के/का mark? (A **genitive/possessive** relationship.)
Does Hindi use Romance “have,” simple Germanic “be,” Latin
“born,” or Arabic’s verbless sentence? (**None**: it says “belonging to
N years” + *honā*.)

19.3 द — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ख — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: द

द — *da*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *d*, it is **da**.

What it is made of:

- a short top-to-bottom stem
- an outer body joined to an inward curl and down-right tail
- the top shirorekhā

You already say these, and every one of them has द somewhere inside it:

- धन्यवाद — thank you (dhanyavād — formal, Sanskritic)
- अलविदा — goodbye (alvidā — a final farewell, Persian/Arabic-derived)
- मैं हिंदी बोलता हूँ — I speak Hindi (gendered)
- एक दो तीन चार पाँच — one to five

Writing: द

- **1.** draw the short stem top-to-bottom
- **2.** lift at the stem's lower junction, sweep left through the upper shoulder and around the outer body, curl inward and clockwise through the loop, then continue down-right through the tail without lifting
- **3.** lift and draw the top shirorekḥā left-to-right

Pen lifts: 2. The pen comes up 2 times and no more.

Verified three-stroke teaching form; another learner source stages the outer body and curl-tail separately.

This is one attested teaching order and not a national standard — handwriting here is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: Opiaterein, ‘Deva-द-order.gif’, strokes 1–3, Wikimedia Commons, 8 May 2009.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find द in the ones that have it
धन्यवाद · अलविदा · नमस्ते
- *Trace it:* द three times, saying *da* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find द once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — द? What sound does it carry? (*da*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 20

Weather

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ✍ pen (1) ⇄ **Hands-free start:** first 1 of 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what the weather is doing in Hindi and stay out of the बारिश / वर्षा false-friend trap.

Say मौसम, then गर्मी है and ठंड है, and keep everyday बारिश apart from formal वर्षा despite the resemblance.

20.1 मौसम — another Perso-Arabic loan, and a false-friend trap

You’ve already seen Hindi borrow *umr* from Arabic. Here’s another one — and this time, English borrowed the SAME root too.

You’ll want to know — मौसम — the same root as “monsoon”

मौसम (*mausam*) = “weather” — borrowed from Classical **Persian** موسم (*mawsim*), itself from **Arabic** مَوْسِم (*mawsim*, “season, time of year, occasion”; likely originally used by Arab sailors for seasonal winds). This is the **exact same root** that gave English **monsoon** — carried into English in the **1580s**, well before the British Raj, via **Portuguese and Dutch** traders in the Indian Ocean spice trade (Portuguese *monção*, Dutch *monssoen*, both from this same Arabic *mawsim*). So “monsoon” and Hindi’s everyday word for “weather” are, quite directly, the same word.

You'll want to know — गर्मी है, ठंड है — heat and cold, native words

गर्मी है। — “It’s hot.” — literally “**there is heat.**” (*garmī hai.*)
 ठंड है। — “It’s cold.” — literally “**there is cold.**” (*ṭhaṇḍ hai.*)

Both use ordinary Hindi nouns (गर्मी, “heat”; ठंड, “cold”) plus है (*hai*, “is/there is”) — simpler in shape than Arabic’s fully verbless pattern, since Hindi still needs *hai* here.

You'll want to know — बारिश vs. वर्षा — a genuine false-friend trap

Hindi has **two** words for “rain” that sound similar enough to assume they’re related — **don’t** make that assumption:

- बारिश (*baarish*) — from **Persian** بارش (*bāriš*) — the everyday, colloquial word: बारिश हो रही है (“it’s raining,” literally “rain is happening”).
- वर्षा (*varṣā*) — fully **native Sanskrit**, from वर्ष (*varṣá*, “rain”), tracing to **Proto-Indo-European** *h₁wers-* (“to rain”) — cousin of Greek *hḗrsē* (“dew”) and Old Irish *frass* (“rain-shower”). This is the more formal/literary word.

Despite the similar sound, dictionaries flag *baarish* and *varṣā* as **probably not related** — one’s a Persian loan, the other a native Sanskrit inheritance from deep in the Indo-European family. A likely false-friend trap, not a confirmed doublet.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “mausam” — weather, same root as English “monsoon”
- “garmī hai. ṭhaṇḍ hai.” — it’s hot / it’s cold
- “baarish hai” (everyday) vs. “varṣā” (formal) — probably NOT related despite sounding alike

Before you move on

What English word shares मौसम's exact root, and how did it reach English? (**Monsoon** — from Arabic *mawsim* via Persian, carried into English in the 1580s by Portuguese/Dutch traders, well before the British Raj.) Are बारिश and वर्षा related words? (**Probably not** — despite sounding similar, *baarish* is a Persian loan and *varṣā* is native Sanskrit; dictionaries flag them as likely unrelated.) What PIE root does वर्षा trace to, and what's its Greek cousin? (*h₁wers-*, “to rain” — cousin of Greek *hērsē*, “dew.”)

20.2 ध — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: द — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ध

ध — *dha*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *dh*, it is **dha**.

What it is made of:

- an upper spiral ending in a rightward shoulder
- a separate lower bowl
- a top-to-bottom right stem
- the top shirorekha

You already say these, and every one of them has ध somewhere inside it:

- धन्यवाद — thank you (dhanyavād — formal, Sanskritic)
- सोमवार मंगलवार बुधवार गुरुवार शुक्रवार — Monday–Friday
- दोपहर आधी रात — noon (literally “two pahars,” a traditional ~3-hour time unit) and midnight (“half night,” fully transparent)

Writing: ध

- **1.** start at the upper spiral's inner crossing, curl around the small opening, widen left and down around the outer loop, then sweep right through the shoulder without lifting
- **2.** lift at the left waist and sweep down and around the lower bowl to its right junction
- **3.** lift and draw the right stem top-to-bottom
- **4.** lift and draw the top shirorekḥā left-to-right

Pen lifts: 3. The pen comes up 3 times and no more.

Verified four-stroke teaching form; everyday handwriting may join or simplify the loops differently.

This is one attested teaching order and not a national standard — handwriting here is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: Opiaterein, ‘Deva-ध-order.gif’, strokes 1–4, Wikimedia Commons, 10 May 2009.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ध in the ones that have it
धन्यवाद · नमस्ते
- *Trace it:* ध three times, saying *dha* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ध once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ध? What sound does it carry? (*dha.*)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 21

Numbers Six to Ten

Modes: ⇐ voice (2) ⇐ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can count from six to ten in Hindi and hear the sound changes that wore the Sanskrit numerals down.

Trace *ṣaṣ* → *chhah*, *nava* → *nau* and *daśa* → *das*, naming the one change each numeral underwent.

21.1 छह, सात, आठ, नौ, दस — six to ten, the same erosion twice more

You already watched *trīṇi* wear down to *tīn* in two careful steps. Two more numbers here do exactly the same thing.

You'll want to know — The five

	Hindi	said
6	छह	<i>chhah</i>
7	सात	<i>sāt</i>
8	आठ	<i>āṭh</i>
9	नौ	<i>nau</i>
10	दस	<i>das</i>

You'll want to know — *sapta* → *satta* → *sāt*, *aṣṭa* → *aṭṭha* → *āṭh* — the same mechanism again

Put seven and eight beside their Sanskrit ancestors:

Sanskrit	→ Prakrit →	Hindi
<i>saptá</i>	<i>satta</i>	sāt
<i>aṣṭá</i>	<i>aṭṭha</i>	āṭh

This is the **identical two-step process** you already watched turn *trīṇi* into *tīn*:

1. The consonant cluster (-*pt*-, -*ṣt*-) **simplifies into a doubled consonant** (-*tt*-, -*ṭṭh*-) — the same weight, packed into one place. 2. The doubled consonant **simplifies again**, and the **vowel lengthens** to pay for what was lost — *satta* → *sāt*, *aṭṭha* → *āṭh*.

Same trade, same reason, two more numbers. This is exactly what the anchor lesson meant by “not decay in any bad sense” — it’s the standard Prakrit weight-conservation move, and by now you’ve seen it three times.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “chhah, sāt, āṭh, nau, das”
- the repeated mechanism — “saptá ... satta ... **sāt**” and “aṣṭá ... aṭṭha ... **āṭh**”

Before you move on

Count six to ten in Hindi. (*Chhah, sāt, āṭh, nau, das.*) What mechanism do *sāt* and *āṭh* share with lesson 6’s *tīn*? (**Cluster simplifies to a geminate, then the geminate simplifies again and the vowel lengthens** — the same weight-conservation move, three numbers running.) Next: compare the three different histories inside six, nine, and ten.

21.2 छह, नौ, दस — three different paths

Seven and eight repeated a familiar weight trade. Six, nine, and ten show that not every number took the same road.

You’ll want to know — ṣaṣ → chhah — a sibilant moves forward

छह (*chhah*) continues Sanskrit **ṣaṣ**, “six.” The retroflex sibilant **ṣ** shifted forward into Hindi छ (*ch*). This is separate from cluster simplification, but

it is still two thousand years of ordinary speech reshaping a Sanskrit word.

You'll want to know — nava → nau — a consonant dissolves

नौ (*nau*) continues Sanskrit **nava**. The **v** between vowels weakened and disappeared; the vowels on either side contracted into the diphthong *-ava-* → *-au-*. Compare *pāmich*: there a nasal moved into the vowel; here an intervocalic consonant dissolved between two vowels.

You'll want to know — daśa → das — the quiet path

दस (*das*) continues Sanskrit **daśa** most plainly: the final vowel drops. There is no cluster to simplify and no middle consonant to lose.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ṣaṣ ... chhah” — the sibilant shifts
- “nava ... nau” — *v* dissolves into a diphthong
- “daśa ... das” — only the final vowel drops

Before you move on

What happened to **v** in *nava* → *nau*? (It **dissolved between vowels**, which contracted.) Which form changed least? (**Das** — only the final vowel dropped.) Count six to ten once more. (*Chhah*, *sāt*, *āṭh*, *nau*, *das*.)

Chapter 22

Numbers Eleven to Twenty

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can count from eleven to twenty in Hindi and spot the subtractive nineteen sitting inside the list.

Count ग्यारह to बीस, then read उन्नीस as 'one less than twenty', the same logic as Latin's ūndēvīgintī.

22.1 ग्यारह, बीस — genuinely irregular, and one honest exception

Be honest about this one: Hindi's teens don't follow a clean, predictable pattern the way Spanish's or Latin's do. But hiding inside that irregularity is a real echo of something Latin does too.

The two words — Eleven to twenty

	Hindi	said
11	ग्यारह	<i>gyārah</i>
12	बारह	<i>bārah</i>
13	तेरह	<i>terah</i>
14	चौदह	<i>chaudah</i>
15	पंद्रह	<i>pandrah</i>
16	सोलह	<i>solah</i>
17	सत्रह	<i>satrah</i>
18	अठारह	<i>aṭhārah</i>
19	उन्नीस	<i>unnīs</i>
20	बीस	<i>bīs</i>

The two words — Honest irregularity

Unlike Spanish’s transparent *dieciséis-diecinueve* or even the fused-but-regular *once-quince*, Hindi’s 11-18 each descend from their own Sanskrit number-word (*ekādaśa*, *dvādaśa*, *trayodaśa*...) through centuries of individually unpredictable erosion. Most end in **-rah**, a worn-down echo of Sanskrit’s “-daśa” (“ten”), but the erosion of each number’s front half isn’t predictable from the number itself — these genuinely have to be memorized one by one, the way English speakers just memorize “eleven” and “twelve” rather than deriving them.

The two words — उन्नीस

Here’s the honest exception: उन्नीस (*unnīs*, 19) most likely isn’t simply a worn-down “nine-ten” — it likely continues Sanskrit’s **own** special, **subtractive** name for 19: ऊनविंशति (*ūnaviṃśati*), literally “**one less than twenty**” (from *ūna*, “less, deficient,” + *viṃśati*, “twenty” — a later, shortened form of the fuller Vedic *ekonaviṃśati*, “one-less-twenty,” with the *eka*, “one,” eventually dropped). Sanskrit used this same *ūna*-/ *ekona*- (“one-less-than”) subtractive pattern for every number ending in 9 up through 99 — 29, 49, 99, all named as “one less than” the next round number.

This is a genuine, striking parallel to something you already met: **Latin’s own ūndēvīgintī** (“one from twenty”) for 19, from the numbers-11-20 lesson. Two completely unrelated language families — Indo-Aryan and Italic, both descended from Proto-Indo-European but separated for thou-

sands of years — independently landed on the exact same subtractive logic for naming nineteen.

The two words — बीस

बीस (*bīs*, “twenty”) continues Sanskrit विंशति (*viṃśati*, “twenty”).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “gyārah, bārah, terah” — 11, 12, 13, each individually memorized
- “unnīs” — 19, most likely “one less than twenty” (*ūnaviṃśati*), echoing Latin’s *ūndēvigintī*
- “bīs” — twenty

Before you move on

Do Hindi’s numbers 11-18 follow a predictable pattern the way Spanish’s teens do? (**No** — each is individually eroded from its own Sanskrit ancestor and must be memorized.) What does उन्नीस most likely preserve from Sanskrit, and what does it mean? (Sanskrit’s **subtractive** *ūnaviṃśati*, “**one less than twenty**.”) What Latin number from an earlier lesson uses the exact same subtractive logic? (*ūndēvigintī*, “one from twenty” — two unrelated language families, the same idea.)

Chapter 23

Dog and Cat

Modes: ⇐ voice (2) ⇐ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name a dog and a cat in Hindi and say honestly how far back each word can actually be traced.

Trace बिल्ली back through biḍālikā to biḍāla, then say out loud where the evidence stops being solid.

23.1 कुत्ता — a third mystery dog-word

Spanish has a mystery dog-word, and English/German another. Hindi genuinely gives you a **third**.

You’ll want to know — कुत्ता — a third mystery, displacing Sanskrit’s own PIE word

Sanskrit’s actual, **inherited** word for dog was श्वान (*śvān*) — the **exact same PIE root**, **kwon-*, behind Latin’s *canis*, English’s *hound*, and German’s *Hund*. It’s the **only** word for dog found in the Rigveda. But everyday Hindi doesn’t use *śvān* at all — the ordinary word is कुत्ता (*kuttā*), which traces through Prakrit to a Sanskrit form, कुर्कुर (*kurkura*). Its ultimate origin is honestly **unresolved** — serious proposals split between an **onomatopoeic** origin (imitating a dog’s bark) and a **non-Indo-Aryan substrate** word borrowed from an unrelated language family, with no consensus on which is right. Either way, *kuttā* quietly pushed *śvān* into rare, formal, literary use — the **exact same shape of story** as Spanish’s *perro* displacing *can*, and English’s *dog* displacing *hound*. Three unrelated language families, three mystery words, all crowding out the same inherited PIE word for “dog.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “kuttā” — dog, genuinely uncertain origin, displacing Sanskrit’s own śvān
- “śvān” — the PIE-inherited word, now rare and formal

Before you move on

What was Sanskrit’s actual inherited word for “dog,” and what family does it belong to? (श्वान, śvān — same PIE root as Latin *canis*, English *hound*, German *Hund*.) Does everyday Hindi use śvān? (**No** — *kuttā* displaced it, echoing Spanish’s *perro* and English’s *dog*.) Is *kuttā*’s own origin settled? (**No** — genuinely disputed between an onomatopoeic origin and a non-Indo-Aryan substrate word.) Next: follow Hindi’s cat-word into a probable fourth family.

23.2 बिल्ली — a probable fourth cat-word family

Hindi’s dog-word joined three mysteries. Its cat-word probably opens a family separate from the widespread *qitt/cattus/gato/chat/Katze* story.

You’ll want to know — The route into Hindi

बिल्ली (*billī*, “cat”) traces through Sauraseni Prakrit to Sanskrit बिडालिका (*biḍālikā*), a diminutive of बिडाल (*biḍāla*, “cat”).

Be honest about the deeper step: most linguists consider *biḍāla* a loan-word **into Sanskrit from Dravidian**, but this is not universal. Some scholars are skeptical of the comparison; another serious proposal derives it from an unattested native compound, *vidāla*, “that which tears apart small birds.”

If the leading Dravidian account is right, *billī* belongs to a probable fourth cat-word family. Arabic *qitt*, Latin *cattus*, Spanish *gato*, French *chat*, and German *Katze* are usually linked to one Afro-Asiatic source; Hindi’s word would instead descend from a word Sanskrit borrowed from Dravidian.

Your turn

- *Say it*: “billī” — cat
- *Trace it*: *biḍāla* → *biḍālikā* → Prakrit → *billī*
- *Qualify*: “probably Dravidian, not proven”

Before you move on

Where does बिल्ली most likely come from? (**Dravidian**, via Sanskrit *biḍāla*.) Is that universally agreed? (**No** — it is the leading account with serious alternatives.) Why is this a new cat-word family? (It is probably separate from the *qitt/cattus* family.)

Chapter 24

Green and Yellow

Modes: ⇨ voice (2) ⇨ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name green and yellow in Hindi and trace पीला step by step back to Sanskrit.

Trace pīta · pītala · pīāla · pīlā in order, and flag the drink-to-yellow link as uncertain rather than settled.

24.1 हरा — a color cousin hiding in plain sight

Hindi’s green word shares deep roots with words other languages use for yellow.

You’ll want to know — हरा — a hidden cousin of jaune and gelb

हरा (harā, “green”) comes from Sanskrit हरित (harita, “green, yellowish, tawny”) — a well-documented descendant of Proto-Indo-European **ǵʰelh₃-*, “to shine.” That confirmed root is also behind German’s gelb (via Proto-Germanic **gelwaz*) and English’s own “yellow” and “gold” — making Hindi’s word for GREEN a genuine cousin of German’s word for YELLOW. French’s jaune is usually traced to this same family too, via Latin *galbinus* — though, honestly, that particular link is less secure than the others: some modern Latin scholarship treats *galbus*’s origin as unknown rather than confirming the **ǵʰelh₃-* connection. So here’s the honest surprise: Hindi’s word for GREEN and German’s word for YELLOW are, at the deepest level, cousins — not a contradiction, since this root originally

covered a blurry “shining, yellow-to-green” zone before languages carved out different pieces of it. Sanskrit *harita* itself kept some of that blur, historically covering shades from green through yellowish and tawny, before Hindi’s *harā* settled specifically on “green.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “हरा” — green, a hidden PIE cousin of German’s *gelb*
- “**g^helh₃-*” — shine, then a yellow-to-green color zone”

Before you move on

What ancient Proto-Indo-European root connects **harā** to German’s *gelb*? (**g^helh₃-*, “to shine” — Hindi’s GREEN word is a genuine cousin of German’s YELLOW word; French’s *jaune* is usually placed in this family too, though that link is less secure.) Why can one root yield green and yellow words? (It once covered a broader **shining yellow-to-green zone**.) Next: the yellow word whose sound history is clear but meaning history is not.

24.2 पीला — clear sounds, uncertain meaning

Harā gave a secure ancient color family. Hindi’s yellow word gives a secure sound chain wrapped around an unsolved semantic mystery.

You’ll want to know — The chain

पीला (*pīlā*, “yellow”) traces through Prakrit पीअल (*pīala*) to Sanskrit पीतल (*pītala*), built on पीत (*pīta*).

Pīta means “yellow,” but also literally “**drunk, quaffed,**” from a root meaning “to drink.” Why do “yellow” and “drunk” share a word? The connection is **not settled**. One proposed path runs “drink” → “become full or swell” → “the color of fat” → “yellow,” but sources flag that mechanism as uncertain.

What is solid is the ordinary sound history:

pīta → *pītala* → *pīala* → *pīlā*

Keep the evidence levels separate: trust the forms; label the semantic bridge a hypothesis.

Your turn

- *Say it*: “pīlā” — yellow
- *Trace it*: “pīta · pītala · pīala · pīlā”
- *Qualify*: “drink → yellow is uncertain”

Before you move on

What does **pīta** also mean? (**Drunk, quaffed.**) Is the bridge from drinking to yellow settled? (**No.**) What part is secure? (The sound chain $pīta \rightarrow pītala \rightarrow pīala \rightarrow pīlā$.)

Chapter 25

Day

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say day in Hindi and explain how दिन both is and is not related to Latin’s diēs.

*Say दिन, put it and diēs on the same PIE *dyew- root but different branches, then name द्यु/दिव् as the closer cousins.*

25.1 दिन (din) — “day,” the same root as diēs, a different branch

You’ve already met this word once, tucked inside *dopahar* (“noon,” literally “two pahars” of the **day**). Now it stands alone — and its connection to Latin’s *diēs* is real, but more careful than it first looks.

You’ll want to know — दिन — “day”

दिन (**din**) — “**day**” — is the ordinary Hindi word for “day,” already implicit in दोपहर (*dopahar*, “noon,” Chapter 17).

You’ll want to know — The same ultimate root as diēs — but a separate branch

Din traces to **Sanskrit** दिन (*dina*), from **Proto-Indo-Iranian** **dinám* — a **suffixed** formation built on **Proto-Indo-European** **dyew-* (“to shine, sky”), the same ultimate root behind **Latin**’s own **diēs**. But be careful: *din*

and *diēs* aren't the closest possible cousins — they took **separate derivational paths** off that shared root. *Din*'s own closest relatives are actually the Baltic/Slavic “day”-words, **Lithuanian** *diena* and **Proto-Slavic** **dьnъ*. The genuinely **direct**, unsuffixed cousins of *diēs* are Sanskrit's own द्यु (*dyu*, “heaven, sky”) and दिव् (*div*, “sky”) — which give दिवस (*divasa*), yet another everyday Hindi word for “day.” So the honest picture: *din* and *diēs* share one distant ancestor, but *dyu/div* are the tighter match.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “din” — “day,” already met inside dopahar
- the shared root — *din* and Latin's *diēs*, same PIE root *dyew-*, “to shine,” but different derivational branches
- the closer cousins — *dyu*, *div*, “heaven/sky” — the tighter, unsuffixed match for *diēs*

Before you move on

Where have you already met दिन before this lesson? (दोपहर, *dopahar*, “noon.”) What ancient PIE root connects Hindi's **din** to Latin's **diēs**, and what does it mean? (**dyew-*, “to shine, sky” — but through **separate branches**, not as the closest cousins.) Which Sanskrit words are actually the **tighter, more direct** cousins of *diēs*? (द्यु *dyu* and दिव् *div*.)

Chapter 26

Night

Modes: ⇐ voice (1) ⇐ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say night in Hindi and explain why रात and Latin’s nox are not cousins at all.

Trace rātri → ratti → raat, then state the honest twist: unlike दिन and diēs, रात and nox share no root.

26.1 रात (raat) — “night,” and an honest false cousin of Latin’s nox

Last lesson, *din* turned out to be a real (if distant) cousin of Latin’s *diēs*. This lesson is the mirror image: *raat* looks like it should be *nox*’s cousin too — but it genuinely isn’t.

You’ll want to know — रात — “night”

रात (raat) — “night” — is the word already hiding inside आधी रात (*ādhī rāt*, “midnight,” Chapter 17). It comes down through a completely ordinary sound-change chain: **Sanskrit** रात्रि (*rātri*) → **Prakrit** रत्ति (*ratti*, consonant cluster simplifying) → Hindi रात (*raat*) — the same shape of erosion you’ve already seen in Hindi’s numbers (*saptá* → *sāt*, *aṣṭá* → *āṭh*).

You’ll want to know — A genuine false cousin — not a true cognate

Here’s the honest twist: रात्रि (*rātri*) traces to **Proto-Indo- Iranian** **HráHtriH*, from **Proto-Indo-European** **h₁reh₁-trih₂* — built from

a root meaning “**to rest, remain still**,” plus a feminine suffix. This is a **completely different** PIE root from Latin’s **nox** (from ***nók^wts**, the root behind English “night” itself, German *Nacht*, Greek *nyx*). Both *rātri* and *nox* are genuine Indo-European “night” words, in related language branches — but they are **not** cousins. Unlike *din* and *diēs* last lesson, which really do share one ancestor, *raat* and *nox* just happen to both mean “night,” from two entirely separate ancient roots. Sanskrit actually **does** keep a true *nók^wts* cousin of its own — नक्तम् (*naktam*, “by night”) — but it’s an archaic, adverbial word; it’s *rātri*, not *naktam*, that won the job of everyday Hindi’s *raat*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*raat*” — “night,” already met inside *ādhī rāt*
- the sound chain — *rātri* → *ratti* → *raat*, the same erosion pattern as *saptá* → *sāt*
- the honest twist — *raat* and *nox* are NOT cousins, unlike *din* and *diēs*

Before you move on

Where have you already met रात before this lesson? (आधी रात, *ādhī rāt*, “midnight.”) What Sanskrit word, and what sound-change chain, gives Hindi **raat**? (रात्रि *rātri* → Prakrit *ratti* → *raat*.) Are *raat* and Latin’s *nox* true cognates, the way *din* and *diēs* are? (**No** — genuinely different PIE roots, **h₁reh₁-* “to rest” vs. **nók^wts* — a false cousin, despite both meaning “night.”)

Chapter 27

Good Night

Modes: ⇌ voice (1) ⇌ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can wish someone good night in Hindi and say why the phrase uses literary रात्रि rather than everyday रात.

Say शुभ रात्रि at parting, name the raat / rātri register pair, and trace śubh from 'to shine' to 'auspicious'.

27.1 शुभ रात्रि (śubh rātri) — “good night,” the formal doublet in action

Hindi keeps two versions of “night” side by side — one for everyday speech, one for set phrases. Here’s where the formal one gets used.

You’ll want to know — शुभ रात्रि — “auspicious night”

शुभ रात्रि (śubh rātri) — “good night” — literally “auspicious night.” Notice: this uses रात्रि (rātri), the very Sanskrit word last lesson’s raat descended from — but here, kept in its full, unworn Sanskrit form. This is a classic tatsama/tadbhava doublet: rātri (tatsama, a direct, unchanged Sanskrit borrowing) sits alongside raat (tadbhava, the same word worn down by centuries of ordinary sound change) — Hindi keeps both, one for everyday speech, one for set formal phrases like this one.

You’ll want to know — शुभ — “auspicious,” from a root meaning “to shine”

शुभ (śubh) — “auspicious, good, fortunate” — comes from the Sanskrit verbal root शुभ् (śubh), whose core sense is “to be beautiful, splendid.” This traces to a well-sourced **Proto-Indo-European** root, **kewb^h*- (“to be beautiful”). Some scholars propose a **further, more speculative** connection beyond that — to **(s)kewh₁*- (“to perceive”) or **kew*- (“to shine”) — but that deeper link, not the **kewb^h*- root itself, is the genuinely uncertain part. Either way, the underlying idea is a familiar one: **auspiciousness imagined as a kind of radiance or beauty** — something good “shines.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “śubh rātri” — “good night,” literally “auspicious night”
- the formal doublet — rātri here, raat in everyday speech
- śubh’s own root — śubh, “to shine” → “auspicious”

Before you move on

Does शुभ रात्रि use the everyday *raat* or the formal *rātri*? (**The formal *rātri*** — Hindi keeps both versions, one for everyday speech, one for set phrases.) What does शुभ literally trace back to? (A root meaning “to be beautiful, splendid,” PIE **kewb^h*- — auspiciousness as a kind of radiance.) Is that root itself uncertain, or is a *further* proposed connection the shakier part? (**The root **kewb^h*- itself is well-sourced** — it’s the *deeper* proposed link, to “to shine” or “to perceive,” that’s genuinely speculative.)

Chapter 28

Morning

Modes: ⇨ voice (1) ⇨ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say morning in Hindi and recognise सुबह as a Persian-Arabic loan rather than a Sanskrit word.

Say सुबह, find the ṣ-b-ḥ root it shares with Arabic ṣabāḥ, and name the break from Sanskrit दिन and रात.

28.1 सुबह (subah) — “morning,” and a root that also sits in Arabic

दिन and रात were both Sanskrit words, straight through. This one breaks that pattern completely — and lands on a root that also sits inside a different language entirely.

You’ll want to know — सुबह — a real surprise: not Sanskrit at all

सुबह (subah) — “morning” — is Hindi’s everyday, ordinary word for morning. Unlike दिन (*din*) and रात (*raat*, both Sanskrit tatsama, met the last two lessons), *subah* is genuinely **borrowed**: from **Persian** صبح (*subh*), itself from **Arabic** صبح (*ṣubḥ*), built on the Arabic trilateral root ح-ب-ص (*ṣ-b-ḥ*, “dawn, to become morning”).

You'll want to know — A root that also sits inside an Arabic goodnight

Here's the honest connection: this is the **exact same** Arabic root that sits inside the Arabic goodnight *خير على تصبح* (*tuṣbiḥ ʿalā khayr*, “good night,” literally “may **you wake into goodness**,” built on this very root). Hindi's everyday word for “morning” and Arabic's own good-night farewell — a phrase that never even mentions “night” — both trace to the **same three Arabic consonants**, ح-ب-ص, arriving in Hindi by a completely different route (via Persian) than they did staying in Arabic.

You'll want to know — Be honest: *din* and *raat* didn't prepare you for this

Don't assume every Hindi time-word will be Sanskrit just because *din* and *raat* were. *Subah* is a genuine break in the pattern — a reminder that “everyday Hindi word” and “Sanskrit tatsama” aren't the same category, even when the last two examples made it look that way.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “subah” — “morning,” genuinely a Persian/Arabic loan
- the shared root — ṣ-b-ḥ, the same three consonants inside Arabic's *tuṣbiḥ ʿalā khayr*
- the honest break — unlike *din* and *raat*, *subah* is NOT Sanskrit

Before you move on

Is सुबह a Sanskrit tatsama, like दिन and रात? (**No** — a genuine Persian/Arabic loanword.) Which Arabic phrase, met earlier in this lesson, shares सुबह's exact root? (*خير على تصبح*, *tuṣbiḥ ʿalā khayr*, “good night” — both trace to the Arabic root ح-ب-ص, ṣ-b-ḥ.)

Chapter 29

Evening

Modes: ⇨ voice (1) ⇨ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say evening in Hindi and refuse the tempting but false link between शाम and Sanskrit śyāmā.

Say शाम, reject the śyāmā resemblance as a false cognate, and pair it with सुबह as two loans from the same source.

29.1 शाम (shaam) — “evening,” and a tempting false cognate

Last lesson’s सुबह was Persian, not Sanskrit. This word is the same story — but this time there’s a Sanskrit look-alike close enough to trip you up on purpose.

You’ll want to know — शाम — Persian again, not Sanskrit

शाम (shaam) — “evening” — is, like *subah*, a genuine **Persian** loan-word: from Persian شام (*šām*), which traces back through **Proto-Iranian** **xšáfnyah* to **Proto-Indo-Iranian** **kšápā* (“night”). Hindi’s two every-day time-words for “morning” and “evening” both entered the language **via Persian**, not Sanskrit — though their deeper roots differ: *subah*’s traces further back to **Arabic**, while *shaam*’s is native **Indo-Iranian**, a sister branch to Sanskrit itself. Persian is what they share directly; their ultimate origins are not the same.

You'll want to know — Be careful: a tempting, but FALSE, cognate

Here's the trap: Sanskrit has its own word, श्यामा (*śyāmā*, “dark, night-colored”), that *looks* like it should be *shaam*'s cousin — similar sound, overlapping “darkness/night” meaning, right in the neighborhood you'd expect. It **isn't**. *Shaam* and *śyāmā* trace to **two completely separate roots** that simply converged on similar sounds and meanings by coincidence — a genuine **false cognate**, not a shared one. Don't let the resemblance fool you into inventing a connection that isn't there.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “shaam” — “evening,” another genuine Persian loan
- the tempting trap — Sanskrit *śyāmā* looks related but ISN'T
- subah and shaam — both Persian, Hindi's whole “morning and evening” pair borrowed from the same source language

Before you move on

Is शाम Sanskrit or Persian? (**Persian** — from शाम, *śām*, like subah.)
 Is शाम related to Sanskrit श्यामा (*śyāmā*, “dark”)? (**No** — a genuine false cognate; the resemblance is coincidental, not a shared root.)
 What do subah and shaam have in common, beyond both meaning a time of day? (**Both are Persian loanwords** — Hindi's morning/evening pair, unlike din/raat, isn't Sanskrit at all.)

Chapter 30

Afternoon

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say afternoon in Hindi using दोपहर in its modern, widened sense.

Say दोपहर में for 'in the afternoon' — the Chapter 17 word doing a wider job than its etymology promises.

30.1 दोपहर — the same word, a wider job than its etymology promised

You already know दोपहर means “noon” — two pahars after sunrise, precisely. This lesson’s honest twist is that the word doesn’t stay that precise in everyday use.

You’ll want to know — दोपहर — same word, a broader modern meaning

दोपहर (dopahar) is the exact word you met in Chapter 17, still literally “**two pahars**” (traditional ~3-hour watches, counted from sunrise) — but in **modern, everyday Hindi**, it no longer points only at that precise midday instant. Say दोपहर में (*dopahar mein*, “in the dopahar”) to arrange a meeting, and you’re pointing at a stretch of time — roughly **noon through late afternoon** — not a single moment. The historical etymology gave the word a very specific target (the end of the second daytime *pahar*); everyday usage has since widened that target into the general block of time most languages call “the afternoon.”

You'll want to know — Be honest: etymology and modern meaning have drifted apart

This is worth sitting with: **दोपहर**'s **literal** story still holds up the way Chapter 17 described it — “two pahars,” with noon falling around the end of the second — though, as that lesson itself noted, treat the exact pahar-count as the general shape of the story rather than a precisely dated fact. Either way, the **word's job** in the language has moved on well past that etymology. This kind of drift — a word for one precise instant loosening into a name for a whole surrounding stretch of time — isn't unique to Hindi, but here it's especially visible because Chapter 17 showed you exactly how tight the original math was.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “dopahar” — the same word from Chapter 17, “two pahars”
- “dopahar mein” — “in the afternoon,” a modern, widened usage
- the honest twist — the etymology stayed precise; the word's actual job widened past it

Before you move on

Is **दोपहर** a new word, or the same one from Chapter 17? (**The same word** — “two pahars.”) Does modern Hindi use **दोपहर** to mean only the exact instant of noon? (**No** — it's widened to cover the whole afternoon, roughly noon through late afternoon.) Has **दोपहर**'s etymology itself changed to match this wider modern use? (**No** — the etymology still points precisely at noon; only the word's everyday job has widened.)

Chapter 31

Good Morning

Modes: ⇨ voice (1) ⇨ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can wish someone good morning in Hindi and judge when सुप्रभात fits and when नमस्ते is the better choice.

Say सुप्रभात, split it into su + prabhāt, and set that native Sanskrit dawn against the Persian loan सुबह.

31.1 सुप्रभात (suprabhāt) — “good morning,” a different root than the noun

सुबह was Persian, borrowed whole. This lesson’s “good morning” isn’t built on it at all — it reaches for entirely different, native vocabulary.

The two words — सुप्रभात

सुप्रभात (suprabhāt) — “good morning” — is built from सु (*su*, “good”) plus प्रभात (*prabhāta*, “dawn, daybreak”) — and *prabhāta* is **native Sanskrit**, from प्रभा (*prabhā*, “light, splendour”), itself from the root भा (“to shine”) plus the preverb प्र- (“forth”), plus the suffix -त (-*ta*). This is a **completely different word** from सुबह (*subah*, HI-C28), the Persian/Arabic loan you use for the everyday noun “morning.” Hindi’s “morning” and “good morning” don’t share a root at all.

The exchange — Formal register

Here’s a genuine, checked-not-assumed finding — hedged carefully, because the evidence behind it is thin: some sources describe Telugu speakers often code-switching to English “good night” instead of their own Sanskrit-descended phrase, though that claim might apply more broadly across South Asian languages, not just Telugu. सुप्रभात’s own story is different again, and just as worth hedging: it skews toward **formal, written** contexts — speeches, radio, the well-known Hindi WhatsApp-forward “good morning image” culture — rather than casual spoken conversation, where नमस्ते commonly covers mornings too. That’s a real formal/everyday split, but it isn’t the same thing as being displaced by **English** specifically — there’s no strong evidence for that particular substitution here. Don’t assume every “good ____” greeting in every language follows the same displacement story; verify each one on its own, and don’t flatten a hedge into a fact either way.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “suprabhāt” — “good morning,” su + prabhāt
- the root contrast — subah is Persian, prabhāt is native Sanskrit — completely different words
- the honest note — suprabhāt skews formal/written; नमस्ते covers casual mornings; no strong evidence of English displacement

Before you move on

Does सुप्रभात share a root with सुबह? (**No** — सुबह is Persian/Arabic; प्रभात, inside suprabhāt, is native Sanskrit, ultimately from भा, “to shine.”) Is सुप्रभात commonly used in casual spoken Hindi? (**Not especially** — it skews formal/written, with नमस्ते commonly covering mornings in everyday speech.) Is it being displaced by English “good morning,” the way some sources (thinly) suggested for other languages’ night greetings? (**No strong evidence of that** — its own story is a formal/everyday split, not an English substitution.)

Chapter 32

Good Evening

Modes: ⇨ voice (2) ⇨ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can wish someone good evening in Hindi and choose between शुभ संध्या and नमस्ते by register.

Pick शुभ संध्या for a written evening card and नमस्ते for a casual 7 p.m. hello, treating the split as a tendency, not a ban.

32.1 शुभ संध्या (shubh sandhyā) — “good evening,” a twilight word with two lives

शाम was Persian. This greeting reaches for something else again — a native Sanskrit word for the exact moment day and night meet.

You’ll want to know — संध्या — “the junction of day and night”

संध्या (sandhyā) — “evening, twilight” — is **native Sanskrit**, from सम् (sam-, “together”) + धा (dhā, “to hold, to place”), literally “**holding together**” — the **junction** where day and night meet. This is a genuinely different word from शाम (shaam, HI-C29’s Persian loan): Hindi’s everyday evening noun and its “good evening” greeting don’t share a root, the same pattern already found for morning.

You’ll want to know — साँझ — a doublet, but not a simple “casual” version

संध्या has its own Hindi **tadbhava** doublet, साँझ (*sāñjh*), worn down through Prakrit the same way रात्रि became रात (HI-C26/27). But be careful not to force that exact parallel: unlike *rātri/raat*, where the tadbhava form clearly became the everyday word and the tatsama stayed formal, sources describe साँझ as used across **both** literary/poetic **and** everyday communication — not simply “the casual one.” The doublet exists; the clean formal/casual split doesn’t carry over as neatly this time.

Your turn

- *Say it*: “shubh sandhyā” — “good evening,” su + sandhyā
- *Say it*: sandhyā’s own meaning — “holding together,” the junction of day and night
- *Contrast*: tatsama *sandhyā* · evolved doublet *sāñjh*

Before you move on

What does संध्या literally mean, and what is it built from? (“**Holding together**” — सम् + धा — i.e. the junction of day and night.) Does साँझ work the same way रात्रि/रात’s tatsama/tadbhava split did — one strictly formal, one strictly casual? (**No** — साँझ is used across both literary and everyday registers, not confined to one.) Next: choose between the written greeting and the casual all-day greeting.

32.2 शुभ संध्या or नमस्ते? — choose by setting

Shubh sandhyā is structurally transparent. The final question is where Hindi speakers actually reach for it.

You’ll want to know — Written warmth and casual speech

Like सुप्रभात, शुभ संध्या appears heavily in **written and social greeting-card culture**: greeting poetry, WhatsApp messages, and evening well-wishes. It is less likely to open an ordinary mid-conversation exchange.

नमस्ते works at any time of day, evenings included, and is more common in casual conversation than either *shubh prabhāt* or *shubh sandhyā*. The native language has divided the jobs: a Sanskrit “good _____” phrase for formal or written warmth, and another native greeting for everyday speech.

This is not English displacing a Hindi greeting. It is Hindi choosing between two of its own expressions by register and medium.

Your turn

- *Choose:* a WhatsApp evening card → शुभ संध्या
- *Choose:* greeting someone casually at 7 p.m. → नमस्ते
- *Say it:* “formal/written is a tendency, not an absolute ban”

Before you move on

Where does शुभ संध्या especially thrive? (**Written and social greeting-card culture.**) Does नमस्ते genuinely work in the evening? (**Yes** — it works at any time and is common casually.) Is the distinction Hindi versus English? (**No** — it is a native register/medium choice.)

Chapter 33

Good Afternoon

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can wish someone good afternoon in Hindi and say honestly how rarely शुभ दोपहर is actually used.

Say शुभ दोपहर with दोपहर in its widened sense, then rank it honestly below नमस्ते/नमस्कार for everyday afternoons.

33.1 शुभ दोपहर (shubh dopahar) — “good afternoon,” this arc’s rarest greeting

You already know दोपहर’s meaning widened from “precisely noon” to “the afternoon.” This greeting rides that widened sense — but it’s the least commonly heard of the three you’ve now met.

You’ll want to know — शुभ दोपहर — “good afternoon,” using the widened sense

शुभ दोपहर (shubh dopahar) — “good afternoon” — pairs शुभ (“good”) with दोपहर used in the **widened, modern sense** from last lesson: “the afternoon” generally, not the narrow etymological “exactly noon.” Good news for consistency: this greeting confirms दोपहर’s widened meaning is the one people actually reach for here — nobody uses शुभ दोपहर to mean “good [precise instant of] noon.”

You'll want to know — Be honest: the rarest of the three, not just another formal phrase

Here's the twist this lesson adds, verified independently rather than assumed from सुप्रभात or शुभ संध्या's pattern: of this arc's three शुभ+timeword greetings, शुभ दोपहर is **described as the rarest** in actual spoken use — even more so than the other two. Sources call it formal/written, note that casual alternatives like आपका दोपहर शुभ हो (“may your afternoon be good”) exist but are themselves still uncommon, and confirm नमस्ते/नमस्कार do the real everyday greeting work across the whole afternoon, same as for morning and evening. This isn't just “another formal Sanskrit-style greeting” — it's the weakest-attested of the three, a genuine difference in **degree**, not just the same story repeated a third time.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “shubh dopahar” — “good afternoon,” using दोपहर's widened modern sense
- the honest ranking — of सुप्रभात, शुभ संध्या, and शुभ दोपहर, this one is the rarest in actual spoken use
- नमस्ते/नमस्कार — the real everyday greeting, covering afternoons too

Before you move on

Does शुभ दोपहर use दोपहर's narrow “noon” sense or its widened “afternoon” sense? (**The widened sense** — “good afternoon,” not “good [exact] noon.”) Is शुभ दोपहर the most, or least, commonly used of this arc's three शुभ+timeword greetings? (**Least** — described as the rarest of the three in actual spoken use.) What covers the real everyday afternoon greeting instead? (नमस्ते/नमस्कार.)

Chapter 34

Four Verbs of the Mind

Modes: ⇨ voice (1) 👁 eyes (3) ⇨ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I think, understand, read and write in Hindi, run all four through the present habitual, and say “Sorry, I don’t understand” when I need to.

Run सोचना, समझना, पढ़ना and लिखना through मैं ...ता/ती हूँ, spell out मेरा नाम from the letters you first wrote by hand, and name the one meaning — to scratch — that four unrelated families each chose for “write”.

34.1 सोचना (sochnā) — “to think,” and it used to mean “to grieve”

You can already run a Hindi verb: strip the -ना, keep the stem, add -ता/-ती/-ते and होना. Here is a verb worth running that machine on, because its history is a small shock.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

सोचना (sochnā) = “to think.” It behaves itself completely: the infinitive ends in -ना like every Hindi verb, and the stem is सोच- (soch-). So मैं सोचता हूँ (maĩ sochtā hūmī, m.) / मैं सोचती हूँ (sochtī, f.) — “I think.” Respectfully, आप सोचते हैं (āp sochte haiñ).

The stem is also a noun on its own. सोच (soch) means “a thought” — and, just as ordinarily, “worry.” Hold on to that double meaning; the word’s history is the reason for it.

You'll want to know — thinking that started out as grieving

सोचना comes down from Sanskrit शोचति (*śocati*) — “**burns; grieves; mourns**” — on the root शुच् (*śuc-*). Through Prakrit the sound softened and the sense drifted: *burn* → *be consumed by something* → *brood on it* → plain *think*. Hindi's ordinary word for thinking is an old word for sorrow that cooled down.

Be honest about the limits: शुच् has **no secure English cousin**. Nothing *think*-shaped waits at the other end of this trail, and inventing one would be worse than saying so.

What travels instead is the **shape** of the change. English **think** and **thank** are one Germanic root — to thank someone was to *think well of* them. Latin **pēnsāre** meant “**to weigh**,” which is why English has **pensive**. Three unrelated families, three mind-verbs, not one of them starting out meaning “to think.”

Your turn

- [YOU SAY (m.): *mairi sochtā hūmī* · (f.): *mairi sochtī hūmī*]
- *Say it*: “you (resp.) think” — *āp sochte haimi*
- *Say it*: *nahīmī* on its own, then slide it in front of the verb — *mairi nahīmī sochtā / sochtī*, “I don't think so.” Hindi's negator sits **before** the verb, never after it
- *Say it*: the noun *soch*, and both things it means — a thought, and a worry

Before you move on

What did *śocati* mean before it meant “think”? (**To burn, to grieve.**) Which everyday Hindi noun still carries both halves, and where does *nahīmī* sit in *mairi nahīmī sochtā*? (सोच, a thought *and* a worry; *nahīmī* goes **before the verb**.) Is there an English cousin of *śuc-*? (**No.**)

34.2 समझना (samajhnā) — “to understand,” which is to say “to wake up”

Sochnā got you thinking. This verb gets you the single most useful sentence a beginner owns — the one you say when you have **not** understood.

The letters in this word

स (*sa*) + म (*ma*) → सम; then झ (*jha*), the breathy pair of *ja*; then ना (*nā*). Read स • म • झ • ना → *samajhnā*. The झ is one puff of air heavier than a plain *j*, the same aspiration that separates Hindi’s *k* from its *kh*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

समझना (*samajhnā*) = “to understand.” Stem समझ-, so मैं समझता हूँ (m.) / मैं समझती हूँ (f.), and respectfully आप समझते हैं.

Like *soch*, the bare stem is a noun: समझ (*samajh*) is “understanding, sense, judgement.”

And the sentence to bank tonight: मैं नहीं समझता / समझती — “I don’t understand.” Put माफ़ कीजिए in front of it and you have a complete, polite repair: *māf kījiye, maini nahīn samajhtā* — “Sorry, I don’t understand.” Every word of that you already had.

You’ll want to know — the root that gave the Buddha his name

The standard derivation takes समझना back to Sanskrit सम् (*sam*-, “fully, together”) + the root बुध् (*budh*-, “to wake, to become aware”). Older Hindi still says समुझना (*samujhnā*), and that surviving *-u-* is the fingerprint of *budh*- before it wore down.

So you already know this root in English, twice over, because English took the words whole:

- बुद्ध (*buddha*) — “the one who woke up.” English **Buddha**.
- बोधि (*bodhi*) — the awakening itself; and बुद्धि (*buddhi*), intellect.

Further back, *budh*- rests on the reconstructed root *bheudh*-, and its Germanic branch surfaces in English **bode**, **forebode** and **forbid** (*for*- + “announce”). Hindi’s “I understand,” then, is a claim to have woken up — and the Buddha’s title is the same claim, made once and for all.

Your turn

- [YOU SAY (m.): *māim samajhtā hūmī* · (f.): *māim samajhtī hūmī*]
- Say it: the repair, slowly — *māf kījiye, māim nahīm samajhtā / samajhtī*
- Say it: *māim sochtā hūmī* then *māim samajhtā hūmī* — thinking, then getting it
- Say it: *buddha* and *bodhi*, and what *budh-* means underneath them (to wake)

Before you move on

What are the two pieces inside *samajhnā*? (सम् “fully” + बुध् “to wake.”) Say “Sorry, I don’t understand.” (*Māf kījiye, māim nahīm samajhtā / samajhtī.*) Which famous title is built on the same root, and what does it mean? (**Buddha** — “the one who woke up.”)

34.3 पढ़ना (*paṛhnā*) — “to read,” and just as often “to study”

One verb, two English words. And one letter you have never had to say out loud before.

The letters in this word

प (*pa*), then ढ, then ना (*nā*) → प · ढ · ना.

That middle letter is ढ (*dha*) wearing the **nuqtā** — the same small dot you met under फ़ in *māf*, Hindi’s mark for a sound the plain letter cannot carry. Dotted, ढ becomes a **flap**: curl the tongue back to the roof of the mouth and let it snap forward, with a breath behind it. That is **ṛh**. The word is *paṛhnā*, not *padhna*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

पढ़ना (*paṛhnā*) = “to read” — and, with no change at all, “to study.”

Stem पढ़-: मैं पढ़ता हूँ (m.) / मैं पढ़ती हूँ (f.); आप पढ़ते हैं.

Two words grow straight off that stem, and both are everywhere in Indian life: पढ़ाई (*paṛhāī*) = “studies, schooling,” and पढ़ाना

(*paṛhānā*) = “**to teach**” — literally “to cause to read.”

You’ll want to know — reading, when reading meant reciting

The ancestor is Sanskrit पठति (*paṭhati*) — “**recites; reads aloud.**” Not *scans a page*. Sanskrit’s name for its oldest texts is श्रुति (*śruti*), “**that which is heard**”: the Veda was memorised and spoken, and to “read” it was to say it. That is why one Hindi verb still covers reading and studying — for centuries they were the same act.

The sound wore down on the ordinary road: *paṭhati* → Prakrit *paḍhai* → *paṛhnā*, the hard **ṭh** loosening between two vowels into the flap you just made.

And the honest note: **paṭh-** has no secure Indo-European ancestry. No English cousin, and possibly not an inherited Indo-Aryan word at all. Where the trail stops, this book stops with it.

Your turn

- *Say it*: the flap alone — *ṛh*, *ṛh* — then the whole word, *paṛhnā*
- [YOU SAY (m.): *māim paṛhtā hūmī* · (f.): *māim paṛhtī hūmī* — and mean both “I read” and “I study”]
- *Say it*: do what the verb originally meant — recite एक, दो, तीन, चार, पाँच, छह, सात, आठ, नौ, दस aloud, one to ten, then say *māim paṛhtā hūmī*
- *Say it*: *māim paṛhtā hūmī*, then *māim samajhtā hūmī* — read it, then get it

Before you move on

What two English verbs does *paṛhnā* cover? (**Read** and **study**.)
 What did *paṭhati* mean, and why does that explain the pair? (**To recite aloud** — reading was saying.) Recite one to five in Hindi from memory. (*Ek, do, tīn, chār, pāñch.*)

34.4 लिखना (likhnā) — “to write,” which everywhere means “to scratch”

Reading has its verb. Here is the other half — and the chapter’s four mind-verbs come back together at the end of it.

The letters in this word

ल (*la*) with the short ि → लि (*li*); then ख (*kha*); then ना (*nā*) → लि • ख • ना.

The ि is the one that runs ahead of itself: it is drawn to the **left** of ल but sounded **after** it, exactly as in हिंदी. Devanagari writes the mark first and your mouth says it second — *li*, never *il*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

लिखना (*likhnā*) = “to write.” Stem लिख-: मैं लिखता हूँ (m.) / मैं लिखती हूँ (f.); आप लिखते हैं.

Its Sanskrit ancestor is लिखति (*likhati*), and *likhati*’s first meaning is not “writes” at all. It is “**scratches, scrapes, furrows.**” Writing entered the verb afterwards, once there was something to scratch a mark into.

You’ll want to know — five families, one picture

Now the striking part. Ask what “write” meant before it meant writing, and the same answer comes back from languages that never borrowed it from each other:

- Sanskrit लिखति — to **scratch**.
- Latin **scribere** — to **incise, cut**. English took **scribe, script, describe, manuscript** from it.
- Greek **gráphein** — to **scratch, carve**; behind **graph** and every **-graphy**. It is genuinely cousin to English **carve**.
- Old English **writan** — to **score, cut**; that is English **write** itself.

These are **four different roots**, not one worn four ways. Nobody handed this metaphor around. Four peoples with wax, stone, bark and bone each looked at their sharp tool and named the act after the damage it did. Hindi’s verb is one of them, and it kept the older sense honestly enough that *likhati* still glosses as “scrapes.”

Your turn

- [YOU SAY (m.): *maini likhtā hūmī* · (f.): *maini likhtī hūmī*]
- *Say it*: the chapter in one breath — *maini sochtā hūmī*, *maini samajhtā hūmī*, *maini parhtā hūmī*, *maini likhtā hūmī*; then the same four as a woman, in *-tī*
- *Say it*: spell out मेरा नाम, the two words you first assembled by hand — म, the *e*-mātrā above it, र, the ā-tail; then न, ā, म — and finish with *maini likhtā hūmī*
- *Say it*: *likhati*, *scribere*, *gráphein*, *writan* — and the one meaning all four started from (to scratch)

Before you move on

What did *likhati* mean first? (**To scratch.**) Are Sanskrit *likh*-, Latin *scribere* and English *write* one root or four? (**Four** — the picture is shared, the word is not.) Run the chapter's four verbs in the *maini ... hūmī* frame. (*Sochtā*, *samajhtā*, *parhtā*, *likhtā*.)

Chapter 35

Taking, Asking, Helping — and Liking

Modes: 🗣️ voice (3) 👁️ eyes (1) 🦋 Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say I take, ask and help in Hindi, build a conjunct verb out of any noun plus करना, and say what I like the way Hindi says it — with the thing liked as the subject and me in the dative.

Say लेना, पूछना and मदद करना, then turn the sentence inside out: मुझे रोटी पसंद है is bread being pleasing to me, so है agrees with the bread and I move into मुझे — the same inversion Spanish and Italian reached on their own.

35.1 लेना (lenā) — “to take,” a verb that lost a consonant

Four verbs of the mind are behind you. This chapter puts your hands back in the world — starting with the shortest verb in it.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

लेना (lenā) = “to take.” Two syllables, and one of the most-used verbs in the language. Stem ले-: मैं लेता हूँ (m.) / मैं लेती हूँ (f.); आप लेते हैं. It reaches further than English “take”. Offered a drink, a Hindi speaker answers मैं पानी लेता हूँ — “I’ll have water,” the same lenā. It pairs with its opposite in the fixed phrase लेन-देन (len-den), “taking and giving” — Hindi’s word for dealings, transactions, business between people.

You'll want to know — the consonant that fell out

लेना looks too short to have a history. It has a long one. Sanskrit's verb was लभते (*labhate*) — “**takes, obtains, receives.**” Through Prakrit *lahai* the **-bh-** thinned to a breath and then vanished, and the two vowels left behind fused into the single ले- you now say. Almost the whole word eroded.

The proof is sitting in Hindi's own vocabulary. लाभ (*lābh*) — “**profit, gain, benefit**” — was borrowed back from Sanskrit later, straight out of the books, so it never went through that erosion. Verb and noun are the same word at two different ages: one worn smooth by mouths, one preserved on the shelf.

Further out, the standard comparison lines *labh-* up with Greek **lam-bánein**, “to take” — and English quietly holds three of its descendants: a **syllable** is letters “taken together”; **epilepsy** is “a seizing upon”; so is **catalepsy**.

Your turn

- [YOU SAY (m.): *mairi letā hūmī* · (f.): *mairi letī hūmī*]
- *Say it:* accept a drink — *mairi pānī letā hūmī*; then a meal — *mairi roṭī letā hūmī*. Object first, verb last, as always
- *Say it:* *pānī* and what it literally means (the drinkable thing), then *roṭī*
- *Say it:* *lenā* and *lābh* one after the other — the same Sanskrit verb, worn down and preserved

Before you move on

Which Sanskrit verb is *lenā*, and which consonant did it lose? (लभते *labhate*; the **-bh-**.) Which Hindi noun still shows that consonant, and why? (लाभ — borrowed back from Sanskrit, so it never eroded.) Say “I'll have water.” (*Mairi pānī letā / letī hūmī*.)

35.2 पूछना (*pūchnā*) — “to ask,” and the reason English says “pray”

You have been asking questions since chapter two. Here, at last, is the verb for doing it.

The letters in this word

प (*pa*) with the long ू hanging beneath it → पू (*pū*); then छ (*cha*), the breathy pair of *ca*; then ना (*nā*) → पू · छ · ना.

The *ū* is genuinely long, and छ takes a puff of air, one degree heavier than the च in *sochnā*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

पूछना (*pūchnā*) = “to ask,” in the sense of asking a **question**. Stem पूछ-: मैं पूछता हूँ (m.) / मैं पूछती हूँ (f.); आप पूछते हैं.

You already own a question — कितने साल के हो, “how many years are you of.” Now you can name the act itself: मैं उम्र पूछता हूँ, “I ask (someone’s) age.” The thing asked about sits in front of the verb, where every object has gone.

You’ll want to know — asking a person, asking a god

Behind पूछना stands Sanskrit पृच्छति (*pr̥cchati*, “asks”), and behind that a reconstructed root *prek-*, “to ask.” This one paid out generously across the family:

- Latin **precārī**, “to beg, to entreat” — English **pray**, **prayer**, **deprecate**, **imprecation**.
- Latin **precārius**, “held only so long as another allows” — English **precarious**. A precarious thing is one you keep by asking.
- German **fragen**, Dutch **vragen** — everyday “to ask” to this day.

English is the odd one out, instructively. Its own inherited cousin, Old English **frignan**, died out, and **ask** comes from somewhere else entirely — so the *prek-* word survived in English only in its religious clothes. Saying मैं पूछता हूँ, you use the verb English kept for **praying**, because asking a person and asking a god were once one act with one name.

Your turn

- [YOU SAY (m.): *maini pūchtā hūni* · (f.): *maini pūchtī hūmī*]
- *Say it*: the chapter-19 question, then name what you just did — *kitne sāl ke ho? ... maini umr pūchtā hūni*

- Say it: *māimī pūchtā hūmī*, then *māimī letā hūmī* — I ask, I take
- Say it: *pūchnā*, then **pray**, **precarious**, **fragen** — one root, three destinations

Before you move on

Which English verb is *pūchnā*'s true cousin — *ask* or *pray*? (**Pray** — *ask* is unrelated.) What does *precarious* literally describe? (Something **held only by asking**.) Say “I ask (someone's) age.” (*Māimī umr pūchtā / pūchtī hūmī*.)

35.3 मदद करना (madad karnā) — “to help,” and the machine that builds it

This one is not a verb. It is a noun with a verb attached — and once you spot the join, you can build hundreds more.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

मदद (*madad*) is a **noun**: “help, aid.” On its own it does nothing. Bolt करना (*karnā*, “to do”) on the end and you have the verb: मदद करना, literally “to do help.”

Only करना ever conjugates. The noun sits still:

- मैं मदद करता हूँ (m.) / मैं मदद करती हूँ (f.) — “I help.”
- आप मदद करते हैं — “you (resp.) help.”

This is the **conjunct verb**, and you have already used two without being told: काम करना, “to do work” = to work; and माफ़ कीजिए, “please do forgiveness” = sorry. One join, three verbs.

You'll want to know — a stretched-out hand, and why the pattern matters

मदद is Arabic **madad**, on the root م-د-د (*m-d-d*), “to stretch out, to extend.” Help, in Arabic, is a thing **extended** toward you — the picture English reaches for when it *extends* a hand. It came into Hindi through **Persian**, the same road as उम्र (age) and माफ़ (forgiven).

State the gap plainly: English inherited **nothing** from *m-d-d*, and English **help** is a Germanic word unrelated to any of this. The picture is shared; the word is not.

Now why this matters more than one verb. A borrowed noun cannot be conjugated — Hindi would have to bend a foreign word through its own endings. With करना it never has to: the loan stays a frozen noun and native grammar does the work. That is how Hindi swallowed centuries of Persian and Arabic vocabulary without disturbing its verb system at all.

Your turn

- [YOU SAY (m.): *māim madad kartā hūmī* · (f.): *māim madad kartī hūmī*]
- *Say it*: the three joins in a row — *kām karnā, māf karnā, madad karnā*; hear that only the second word ever moves
- *Say it*: *māim pūchtā hūmī*, then *māim madad kartā hūmī* — I ask, I help
- *Say it*: what *m-d-d* means underneath *madad* (to stretch out, extend)

Before you move on

Which half of *madad karnā* takes the endings? (करना — the noun never changes.) Name two conjunct verbs you had already used. (काम करना; माफ़ कीजिए.) Why does this pattern let Hindi borrow so freely? (The loan **stays a noun**; native *karnā* carries the grammar.)

35.4 पसंद (pasand) — Hindi does not like things; things please Hindi

Every verb so far let you be the one doing something. This last one takes that away.

You'll want to know — मुझे, the shape of “to me”

मुझे (*mujhe*) = “to me.” It is what मैं (“I”) becomes when the sentence will not let you be its subject. *Mujhe* is not “I.”

Grammar Lens: the thing you like is the subject

मुझे रोटी पसंद है = “I like bread” — or, taken apart: मुझे (“to me”) + रोटी (“bread”) + पसंद (“pleasing”) + है (“is”). “To me, bread is pleasing.”

रोटी is the **subject**, and that is what है agrees with. You are only the person it happens to. Hindi has no “I like bread” with *I* in front. Two languages walked here alone: Spanish **me gusta el café** (“to me, the coffee pleases”) and Italian **mi piace**. Those two are close cousins; Hindi is not, and nobody borrowed it. Two families, one decision — liking happens **to** you.

You’ll want to know — a Persian word doing a verb’s job

Because **पसंद is not a verb**. It is **Persian** — from پسندیدن (*pasandīdan*, “to approve, to find pleasing”) — and it entered Hindi as a noun and adjective, “**liked, one’s choice**.” A non-verb cannot carry the person doing the liking, so the grammar put them elsewhere: मुझे.

It came by the Persian road that also gave you शाम (evening) — and see what these two chapters have shown. Hindi’s verbs of the mind (*sochnā, samajhnā, parhnā, likhnā*) are inherited Indo-Aryan to a word, while *madad* and *pasand* — helping and liking — are borrowed. Thinking stayed home; the social vocabulary travelled.

For an active “like”, Hindi uses last lesson’s join: पसंद करना, “to do liking,” nearer to “I choose, I prefer.” For everyday liking, मुझे ... पसंद है.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *mujhe rotī pasand hai*, then the Hindi meaning — “to me, bread is pleasing”
- swap the thing, leaving *mujhe ... pasand hai* untouched — *mujhe pānī pasand hai* · *mujhe kuttā pasand hai* · *mujhe shām pasand hai*
- the chapter end to end — *maim letā hūmī, maim pūchtā hūmī, maim madad kartā hūmī, mujhe rotī pasand hai*
- *pasand karnā* beside *madad karnā* — one join, twice

Before you move on

In *mujhe rotī pasand hai*, what is the subject? (रोटी — which is why it is *hai*.) What part of speech is *pasand*, and from where? (A **noun/adjective**, from **Persian** — not a verb.) Say “I like the dog,” then what it literally means. (*Mujhe kuttā pasand hai* — “to me, dog is pleasing.”)

Chapter 36

One House, Four Languages

Modes: 👁 eyes (4) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name a house, its door, a room and the chair I am offered, give each one the possessive its gender demands, and say where each of the four words came from — Sanskrit, Persian, Portuguese and Arabic.

Run घर, दरवाज़ा, कमरा and कुर्सी with the right possessive — and hear मेरा turn into मेरी at the first feminine noun, the promise chapter 2 made and never kept. Then name the four languages one room drew on, spell कुर्सी with its virāma and its conjunct, and say नमस्ते at the door coming in and शुभ रात्रि going out.

36.1 घर (ghar) — “house,” and the fence that came first

You can say your name. Now say where you live — and meet the one thing every Hindi noun carries that English nouns do not.

The letters in this word

Two letters. घ (gha), the breathy pair of ga, then र (ra), already yours from मेरा.

र is the spineless one: no upright stroke of its own, so the शिरोरेखा, the head-line, is all that ties it to its neighbour. Both letters keep their inherent $a \rightarrow$ घर, ghar.

Grammar Lens: the word arrives with a gender

घर (*ghar*) = “**house, home.**” And it is **masculine**.

Every Hindi noun is masculine or feminine. Not the thing — the **word**. There is nothing manly about a house; the gender is a fact about *ghar* the way its spelling is, and you learn the two together or you learn them twice.

It is not decoration: it changes the words around the noun. Because *ghar* is masculine, “my house” is मेरा घर (*merā ghar*), the masculine मेरा, exactly as in मेरा नाम.

Whole sentence: यह मेरा घर है (*yah merā ghar hai*), “**this is my house.**”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

घर comes from Sanskrit गृह (*gr̥ha*), worn smooth through Prakrit *ghara* into the short word you just said. Hindi kept गृह too, borrowed back out of Sanskrit for formal use, so both shapes survive.

Further back, *gr̥ha* descends from an ancient root meaning **enclosure**, *gʰerdʰ-* — and English holds two plain descendants of it: **yard** and **garden**. Slavic holds the *-grad* in **Belgrade**, “town.”

So the oldest sense is not walls and a roof. It is **a fenced-in piece of ground**. You enclose the land first; the house is what goes inside afterwards.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ghar* — house; then *merā ghar*; then *yah merā ghar hai*
- *merā nām* and *merā ghar* one after the other — the same *merā*, because both nouns are masculine
- the two letters, *gha* and *ra*, and which of them has no spine
- *gr̥ha*, then *ghar* — the Sanskrit shape and the worn one; then the old meaning, *enclosure*

Before you move on

Is घर masculine or feminine, and how do you know from the sentence? (**Masculine** — *merā*, not *merī*.) What did the root

behind *gr̥ha* mean before it meant a building? (**An enclosure** — the root behind *yard* and *garden*.) Which of घ and र hangs from the head-line without a spine of its own? (र.)

36.2 दरवाज़ा (darvāzā) — the door, and the oldest word you already know

You have a house. This is what you stand at to be let into one — and it is where नमस्ते is said and where शुभ रात्रि is said back.

The letters in this word

द • र • वा • ज्ञा — and the ा you already write does two of the four.

The new mark is the dot under ज्ञ: the **nuqta**. Plain ज्ञ is *ja*. Persian arrived carrying a **z** Devanagari had no letter for, so the script put a dot beneath the nearest shape and made one — ज्ञ, *za*. The same dot makes फ़ (*fa*) and ख़, the sound in खुशी.

A nuqta is a small confession in ink: *this sound came from somewhere else*.

Grammar Lens: the shape that usually tells you

दरवाज़ा (*darvāzā*) = “door,” and it is **masculine** — so मेरा दरवाज़ा. Here is your first piece of help. A noun ending in long **-ā** is usually masculine, and *darvāzā* ends in -ा. Keep it as a lean, not a law: later chapters will show you where it fails, in both directions. घर ends in a consonant and is masculine too — so a consonant ending tells you nothing at all. That one you simply learn.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

दरवाज़ा is **Persian**, دروازه (*darvāza*), and its first syllable is where this gets remarkable. Persian در (*dar*) means “door,” and it descends from the ancient root ***d^hwer-*** — as do English **door**, Latin **forēs**, Greek **thúrā** and Sanskrit द्वार (*dvāra*).

Now the twist. Hindi *also* has द्वार (*dvār*), taken straight out of Sanskrit for formal use. So the borrowed Persian word and the learned Sanskrit one are **the same ancient word, arrived twice**, by two roads, centuries apart.

The **-vāza** part is less settled: usually connected to a Persian word for “open,” but disputed, and worth leaving open.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *darvāzā*, then *merā darvāzā*, then *merā ghar* — one *merā*, two masculine nouns
- the arrival and the leaving at the same door — *namaste* going in, *shubh rātri* going out
- *ja*, then *za* — the letter, then the letter with the dot
- *dar*, *door*, *thūrā*, *dvāra* — one word, four languages

Before you move on

What does the dot under ञ tell you? (That the sound is **borrowed** — Devanagari had no *z*.) Persian *dar* and English *door* — coincidence or cousins? (**Cousins**, from *d^hwer-* — and Hindi’s own द्वार is the third.) Which ending gives you a fair guess at masculine? (**Long -ā**, as in *darvāzā*. A consonant ending, as in *ghar*, tells you nothing.)

36.3 कमरा (kamrā) — the room that is also a camera

Through the door, and into this. A short, ordinary word — which travelled to India by sea, on Portuguese ships.

The letters in this word

क • म • रा — and म (*ma*) is one of the first two letters you ever wrote, beside न.

Both of those hang from the head-line and both stand on a right-hand spine; that upright is what your eye follows along a line of Devanagari. क and र you have as well, so this word costs you nothing new — only the ा riding on the final र.

Grammar Lens: the lean holds

कमरा (*kamrā*) = “room,” and it is **masculine** — मेरा कमरा.

Long -ā, masculine again, exactly as दरवाज़ा was. Three nouns in, and the possessive has not changed once: *merā ghar*, *merā darvāzā*, *merā kamrā*.

Hold on to that flatness. It is about to break.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

कमरा is neither Sanskrit nor Persian. It is **Portuguese** — *câmara*, “chamber, room” — left behind on India’s western coast by the traders who ran that shore from the sixteenth century, along with चाबी (*chābī*, “key”) and अलमारी (*almārī*, “cupboard”).

Portuguese *câmara* is Latin **camera**, “a vaulted chamber,” and Latin took it from Greek **kamára** — where the trail honestly stops; the Greek word’s own origin is unknown.

Then the good part. English **camera** is that same Latin word: a *camera obscura* was literally a “dark room,” and when the dark room shrank into a box the name went with it. And Hindi later borrowed it back through English as कैमरा (*kaimrā*) for the device.

So कमरा and कैमरा are the *same Latin word*, arrived twice by two different routes — the second time carrying a machine that did not exist when the first one landed.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kamrā*, then *merā kamrā*
- the three so far, in one breath — *merā ghar*, *merā darvāzā*, *merā kamrā*
- *kamrā* and *kaimrā* — one Latin word, two arrivals
- where each of the three came from — Sanskrit, Persian, Portuguese

Before you move on

Which language handed Hindi कमरा, and how did it get there? (**Portuguese**, by sea, on the western coast.) What does *kamrā*

share with English *camera*? (**One Latin word**, *camera*, “vaulted chamber” — Hindi has it twice, as *kamrā* and *kaimrā*.) Say “my house, my door, my room.” (*Merā ghar, merā darvāzā, merā kamrā*.)

36.4 कुर्सी (kursī) — sit down, and watch मेरा change

House, door, room — and now what you are offered once inside.
This word breaks the pattern the other three set.

The letters in this word

कु · र · सी — three old letters, क, र, स, and two working marks.

क takes ु for *ku*. Then र with the **virāma**, the stroke that kills a consonant’s built-in *a*: a bare र cannot stand alone, so it fuses with the स, and the hook above स *is* that र — the fusing you met in स्त.

Then सी: the long ी stands after its consonant and sounds after it, while ि stands before and still sounds after. One of the two lies to your eye.

Grammar Lens: your first feminine noun

कुर्सी (*kursī*) = “**chair**,” and it is **feminine**.

So मेरी कुर्सी, not *merā*. When you learnt मेरा you were told you would meet मेरी at your first feminine noun. Here it is.

Nothing about a chair is female. The gender belongs to the **word**, and it changes मेरा. Get it wrong and every word beside the noun goes wrong too.

Grammar Lens: the lean, and where it leans wrong

The rule of thumb: **long -ā tends masculine, long -ī tends feminine, a consonant ending tells you nothing**. A lean, not a law: *darvāzā, kamrā* and *kursī* obey it, *ghar* sits outside it, and later words will disobey it outright.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

कुर्सी is **Arabic**, كرسي (*kursī*), “seat, throne,” reaching Hindi through **Persian**, the road most Arabic words took.

Arabic did not invent it either. It has passed along the Near East for four thousand years: Sumerian **guza**, Akkadian **kussû**, then Ugaritic, Hebrew and Aramaic, Arabic most likely taking it from **Aramaic**. Not one family — the word crossed between unrelated families because the object did.

English **chair**? Greek **kathédra**, through Latin and French. No relation at all.

And what this chapter has done: घर Sanskrit, दरवाज़ा Persian, कमरा Portuguese, कुर्सी Arabic. One room, four languages — that is Hindi, not an accident of these four words.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *merī kursī*, then *merā kamrā* — one possessive, two shapes
- the chapter — *merā ghar*, *merā darvāzā*, *merā kamrā*, *merī kursī*
- each word's source — Sanskrit, Persian, Portuguese, Arabic
- *namaste* at the *darvāzā*, then *shubh rātri* at the same door

Before you move on

Why मेरी कुर्सी? (कुर्सी is **feminine**; the possessive agrees with the noun.) How far back does *kursī* go, and did it stay in one family? (**Sumerian** — and no, it crossed unrelated families.) Name the chapter's four sources. (**Sanskrit, Persian, Portuguese, Arabic.**)

Chapter 37

One Tea, Please

Modes: 🗣️ voice (2) 👁️ eyes (2) 🖐️ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask for tea, milk, food or a book in the words Hindi speakers actually use rather than the dictionary's, I know that कृपया belongs on a sign and दीजिए in the street, and I can name which of the four nouns take मेरी.

Ask for all four — एक चाय दीजिए, एक दूध दीजिए, खाना दीजिए, and the किताब that is मेरी — then unpack the Arabic root k-t-b into book, scribe and school, and place कृपया where it belongs, beside पुस्तक at the formal end of the language.

37.1 चाय (chāy) — tea, and how to actually ask for one

You are in the chair, in the room Portuguese named. Somebody is about to offer you this — and by the end of these few minutes you will be able to ask for it yourself, in the words people actually use.

Grammar Lens: the lean fails, quietly

चाय (chāy) = “tea,” and it is **feminine**.

Nothing outside the word says so. It does not end in -ी the way कुर्सी does; it ends in a consonant, and the lean warned you a consonant ending tells you nothing. चाय is feminine and you simply learn it — now, with the word.

You'll want to know — how you really ask

एक चाय दीजिए (*ek chāy dījie*) — “one tea, please.”

दीजिए is “give” spoken to आप: the polite request form. That -िए ending is the politeness. Nothing else is needed.

Which means a correction. You learnt कृपया as “please,” and it is a real word — but it belongs to **signs, forms and station announcements**. Across a counter it lands like *kindly furnish me with tea*.

So: कृपया when you write, दीजिए when you speak. And you already have the shape — माफ़ कीजिए carries the very same -िए.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

चाय is **Chinese**. In most of China the word for the leaf is **chá**, which Persian took as چای (*chāy*) and handed to Hindi.

Now the English word: **tea**. French **thé**, Dutch **thee** — a different sound entirely, for the identical leaf.

They are the same word. China writes it with one character everywhere, but reads that character differently: in the Hokkien of the south-eastern coast it is **tê**, and Dutch ships bought their tea *there*.

The tempting story is overland versus sea. It is wrong: Portuguese say **chá**, and Portuguese tea came by sea. The variable is **which Chinese port a trader dealt with**. Your word for tea records a harbour.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *chāy*; then *ek chāy dījie*
- the same request for water — *ek pānī dījie*
- *dījie* and *māf kījie* one after the other — hear the shared *-ie*
- *chā* and *tê* — the two Chinese pronunciations, and which one English bought

Before you move on

Is चाय masculine or feminine, and does its ending help? (**Feminine** — and no, a consonant ending never does.) Where does कृपया belong, and what carries the politeness when you speak? (**Signs**

and announcements — in speech the -**िए** of *dījie* does it.) Are *chāy* and *tea* related? (The same Chinese word, bought at two different ports.)

37.2 दूध (dūdh) — “milk,” which is really a verb wearing a noun’s coat

What goes into the tea. And it is named the same sly way पानी was — by what happens to it, not by what it is.

Grammar Lens: the pair that disagrees

दूध (*dūdh*) = “milk,” and it is **masculine**.

Which makes these two a useful pair, because they sit side by side in every cup and disagree: चाय feminine — the leaf that came by way of a Chinese port — and दूध masculine. Both end in consonants. Neither ending tells you anything. This is the ordinary state of a Hindi noun, and it is why the gender is part of the word, not an afterthought.

एक दूध दीजिए — same request, new noun.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

दूध comes from Sanskrit दुग्ध (*dugdha*) — and *dugdha* is not a noun at all. It is a **past participle** of the verb दुह् (*duh-*), “to milk.” It means “milked.”

So the substance is named for the act. Somebody said “the milked” often enough that the adjective hardened into a thing. You have seen this exact move already: पानी is *pānīya*, “the drinkable.” Hindi’s two commonest liquids are both named by what is done to them.

Behind *duh-* stands the old root *d^hewg^h-*, and its meaning is broader than milk: “to yield, to be strong, to be of use.” Greek *teúkhēin*, “to produce,” is from it, and so is English **doughty**, “stout, valiant.” One trap, since the shape invites it: English **dough** is **not** related. It comes from a different root meaning “to knead, to form.” *Dūdh* and *dough* look like cousins and are strangers.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *dūdh*; then *ek dūdh dījīe*
- the disagreeing pair — *chāy* feminine, *dūdh* masculine
- what each one literally is — *dugdha*, “the milked”; *pānīya*, “the drinkable”
- *dūdh* and *dough* — and that they are not related

Before you move on

What part of speech was *dugdha* before it was milk? (**A past participle** — “milked.”) Which Hindi word plays the same trick, and how? (**पानी** — *pānīya*, “the drinkable thing.”) Is English *dough* a cousin of *dūdh*? (**No** — different root; *doughty* is the real one.)

37.3 खाना (*khānā*) — “food,” and the dot that separates it from a house

Drink is behind you. This is the general word for what you eat — and it has a twin on the page that means something else entirely.

The letters in this word

खा • ना — two syllables, and the ा does both.

ख (*kha*) takes ा → खा. Then न (*na*), your very first letter, takes ा → ना. The ा is the *mātrā* that replaces a consonant’s built-in *a* with a long one, exactly as in नाम.

Two consonants, one mark used twice, and the word is yours.

Grammar Lens: one word doing two jobs

खाना (*khānā*) = “food,” and it is **masculine** — long *-ā*, and this time the lean holds. Unlike दूध, whose name is a participle, this one is plainly a thing.

It is also the verb “to eat.” Same spelling, same sound: the infinitive doubles as a noun, the way English says *the eating was good*.

So खाना दीजिए is “give me food,” and खाना alone can be the act. Which one you mean, the sentence decides.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Both come from Sanskrit खाद् (*khād-*), “to eat” — the noun through खादन (*khādana*), “the act of eating, food,” and the verb through खादति (*khādati*), “eats.”

Now the twin. Hindi also has खाना (*khāna*) — with the **nuqta** under the first letter — and it is **Persian**, خانه (*xāna*), “**house, compartment, section**.” You meet it inside दवाखाना (*davākhāna*), a “medicine-house”: a pharmacy.

Two unrelated words, one from Sanskrit and one from Persian, separated on the page by a single dot. And here is the honest part: **that dot is very often left off**. In ordinary printing and handwriting both are simply written खाना, and the reader is expected to sort it out from context. The nuqta tells you where a sound came from — when somebody bothers to write it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *khānā*; then *khānā dījie*
- the three requests together — *ek chāy dījie*, *ek dūdh dījie*, *khānā dījie*
- *roṭī* and *khānā* — the particular bread and the general word for food
- *khānā* and *khāna* — food and house; then *davākhāna*, the medicine-house

Before you move on

What two jobs does खाना do? (**Food**, and the verb **to eat**.) What is खाना, and where does it come from? (**House, compartment** — Persian خانه, as in *davākhāna*.) Can you always tell them apart on the page? (**No** — the nuqta is often dropped, and context decides.)

37.4 किताब (kitāb) — a book, and the root it is cut from

Not something to eat — something to ask for. Its Arabic root hands you three more words free.

The letters in this word

कि · ता · ब — the first mark is the tricky one.

क with the short ि gives कि (*ki*): the ि is drawn to the **left** of क and sounded **after** it, never *ik*. Then ता, then ब keeping its built-in *a*.

क and त showed you Devanagari's mouth-map: क far back at the soft palate, त at the teeth. Say *ki-tā-b* and feel the tongue travel.

Grammar Lens: feminine, and no ending to prove it

किताब (*kitāb*) = “**book**,” and it is **feminine** — मेरी किताब.

The second consonant-final noun to turn out feminine, after चाय. Two of this chapter's four disobey any guess their shape allows.

Which is the real lesson: **Hindi gender is information about the word, not the thing and not the spelling.**

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

किताब is **Arabic**, كتاب, come by the Persian road कुर्सी took.

Arabic builds words on **three-consonant roots**, and this one is **k-t-b**, “write.” Slot those three into different patterns and a family appears:

- کتاب *kitāb* — a **book**, the thing written.
- كاتب *kātib* — a **scribe**, the one writing.
- مكتب *maktab* — a **place** of writing: an office, a school.

Learn the root and you have a family, which is how much of Hindi's Perso-Arabic vocabulary is built underneath.

You'll want to know — three books, three registers

Hindi has three words for a book, and they are not synonyms — they are **registers**.

- किताब — Perso-Arabic, the ordinary word. Say this one.
- पुस्तक (*pustak*) — straight out of Sanskrit. Libraries, textbooks, formal writing.
- पोथा (*pothā*) — the inherited descendant of that Sanskrit word. Old, homely, a bit dusty.

You have met this split: कृपया is the *pustak* end of “please,” दीजिए the *kitāb* end.

And that is the chapter — चाय from a Chinese port, दूध named for what was done to it, खाना shadowed by a Persian house, किताब cut from an Arabic root.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kitāb*, then *merī kitāb*
- the chapter’s four — *merī chāy*, *merā dūdh*, *merā khānā*, *merī kitāb*
- the k-t-b family — *kitāb*, *kātib*, *maktab*
- *kṛpayā* for the sign; *ek chāy dījie* and *māf kījie* for the street

Before you move on

Which two words here are feminine, and does their shape say so? (चाय and किताब — no, both end in consonants.) Give the k-t-b family. (*Kitāb*, *kātib*, *maktab*.) Which word for “book” do you say, and which belongs with कृपया? (किताब — पुस्तक is the formal one.)

Chapter 38

Six Words for Where It Hurts

Modes: ⇐ voice (1) 👁 eyes (3) ⇐ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name six parts of my body, say that one of them is not well, and tell which three are word-for-word cousins of their English translations — and which one has no traceable ancestry at all.

Say all six body words with the possessive each one demands — मेरा सिर, मेरा हाथ, मेरी आँख, मेरा दाँत, मेरा पैर, मेरा पेट — then say मेरा पेट ठीक नहीं है, and separate the three exact Indo-European cousins from the two words, पेट and रोटी, whose histories genuinely stop.

38.1 आँख (āṁikh) — the eye, which is the same word in English

You have a head and a hand. Here is the part of the face — and this one is not merely *related* to its English translation. It is the same word.

The letters in this word

आँ • ख — and the mark on top is an old friend.

आ is the standalone long *ā*. Over it sits ँ, the **chandrabindu**, the moon-dot, which sends the vowel up through the nose — exactly what it does in हाँ. Then ख (*kha*), breathy, with its inherent *a* still attached.

So the word is a nasalised *ā* followed by *kh*: **āṁikh**, humming at the start.

Grammar Lens: feminine, and one you will use daily

आँख (*āṁkh*) = “eye,” and it is **feminine** — मेरी आँख.

Third feminine noun, third consonant ending: चाय, किताब, आँख. If you were still hoping the spelling would rescue you, let this settle it.

And it is worth the effort, because these are the words a doctor asks about. मेरी आँख ठीक नहीं है — “my eye is not well.”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

आँख comes from Sanskrit अक्षि (*akṣi*), “eye” — and *akṣi* comes from the root *h₃ekʷ-*, which is one of the securest words in the whole family.

Its descendants:

- Latin **oculus** — inside English **ocular**, **monocle**, **binoculars**.
- Old English **ēage**, which is English **eye** itself.
- Lithuanian **akis**, Armenian **akn**, and Greek **ósse**, the old dual form meaning “the two eyes.”

A caution on the Greek, because the obvious candidate is a trap: **ophthalmós** is *usually* connected here, but its first part has never been explained, and serious opinion treats it as a pre-Greek word. Cite **ósse** and stay honest.

हाथ had to travel a long, battered road from *hasta*. आँख barely travelled at all — *akṣi* to *āṁkh* is a short, clean walk, and at the far end of it an English speaker is saying a version of the same word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *āṁkh*, then *merī āṁkh*
- the three body words you now have — *sir*, *hāth*, *āṁkh*
- *hāmi* and *āṁkh* — the same moon-dot, the same hum
- *akṣi*, *oculus*, *eye* — one root, three languages

Before you move on

Is आँख masculine or feminine? (**Feminine** — *merī āmkh.*) Which Greek word is the safe cousin, and which is the trap? (*ósse* is safe; **ophthalmós** is unexplained.) What does the ँ over the आ do, and where did you first meet it? (**Nasalises** the vowel — on हँ.)

38.2 दाँत (dāmit) — the tooth, and the gender trap of this chapter

Built like the last word, spelled like the last word, and the opposite gender. This is the pair learners get wrong most often.

The letters in this word

दाँ · त — three known parts and no new letter at all.

द (*da*) takes ा, and the ँ rides above the head-line for the nasal hum — the same **chandrabindu** that turns ह into हँ, “yes.” Then त (*ta*).

Both द and त are made at the **teeth** — which is the whole point of Devanagari’s mouth-map. The word for *tooth* is spelled with the two consonants your tongue makes *against your teeth*. Say *dāmit* and feel where it happens.

Grammar Lens: the trap

दाँत (*dāmit*) = “tooth,” and it is **masculine** — मेरा दाँत.

Now put the two side by side. आँख and दाँत: same long *ā*, same chandrabindu, same single final consonant, both parts of the body, both everyday. आँख is feminine. दाँत is masculine.

There is no rule underneath that. There is no reasoning that gets you from one to the other. This is the pair to hold up whenever you are tempted to guess: मेरी आँख, मेरा दाँत.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

दाँत is Sanskrit दन्त (*danta*), from ***h₃dónts*** — and like *akṣi* this is one of the family’s best-attested words.

- Latin **dēns**, stem *dentis* — English **dentist**, **dental**, **trident** (a “three-tooth”).

- Greek **odoús** — English **odontology**.
- Old English **tōþ**, which is **tooth**.

Two body parts in a row, both plain cousins of their English translations. That is not a coincidence about eyes and teeth; it is what a core inherited vocabulary looks like from the inside.

And the older reading of *h₃dónts* makes it a participle of *h₃ed-*, “to bite” — so a tooth is “**the biting one**,” which is what खाना needs it for. Same move as दूध, “the milked one”: name the thing after what happens.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *dāmit*, then *merā dāmit*
- the trap pair, twice — *merī āmikh*, *merā dāmit*; again
- *hāmī*, then *dāmit* — the same moon-dot doing the same job
- *danta*, *dēns*, *odoús*, *tooth* — one word, four languages
- the two “named for the action” words — *dugdha*, the milked; the tooth, the biting one

Before you move on

आँख and दाँत look alike — do they share a gender? (**No** — *merī āmikh*, *merā dāmit*.) Which English words carry the Latin form? (**Dentist**, **dental**, **trident**.) What does the older reading make a tooth? (**The biting one** — from a root meaning “to bite.”)

38.3 पैर (pair) — the foot, and the ancestor it does not have

Down from the head, past the hand, to what carries you. And this word’s obvious ancestor turns out to belong to a different Hindi word.

Grammar Lens: masculine, and the sentence that uses it

पैर (*pair*) = “foot,” and it is **masculine** — मेरा पैर.

The ै is a single mātrā for one vowel, *ai* — not *a* then *i*. One sign, one sound, sitting above the head-line on प.

Now the sentence you would actually say to a doctor, using the नहीं you already have: मेरा पैर ठीक नहीं है — “my foot is not well.” Watch the नहीं sit directly before है, which is where Hindi puts its negation.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Here is the obvious guess, and it is wrong. Sanskrit has पाद (*pāda*), “foot” — long *ā*, famous, the source of English’s borrowed *pada*- words. It looks like it must be the parent of *pair*. It is not.

पाँव (*pānv*), Hindi’s *other* everyday word for foot, is the descendant of पाद. पैर comes from the shorter Sanskrit stem पद् (*pad*-), through Prakrit *paya*, picking up a Middle Indo-Aryan **-ra-** ending on the way. So Hindi inherited the same body part **twice**, down two different stems of the same word — and both survive, side by side, meaning the same thing.

Further back both are *ped-*, “to walk, to tread”:

- Latin **pēs**, stem *pedis* — **pedal**, **pedestrian**, **pedicure**.
- Greek **πούς**, stem *podós* — **podium**, and the eight of an **octopus**.
- Old English **fōt**, which is **foot**.

Three body words in three lessons, and every one of them is the same word your own language uses. हाथ had to be argued for through a sound change. These three simply *are* the cousins.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *pair*, then *merā pair*
- the four body words with their possessives — *merā hāth*, *merī āmikh*, *merā dāmīt*, *merā pair*
- *merā pair thīk nahīm hai* — and hear where the *nahīm* sits

- which Hindi word came from *pāda*, and which from *pad-* (*pāmiv*; *pair*)

Before you move on

Does पैर come from पाद? (No — from पद; पाँव is the *pāda* one.) Which English words carry the Latin and Greek forms? (**Pedal**, **pedestrian**; **podium**, **octopus**.) Say “my foot is not well,” and say where नहीं goes. (*Merā pair thik nahī hai* — immediately before है.)

38.4 पेट (peṭ) — the belly, and a trail that genuinely stops

Three clean cousins in a row. This one breaks the run — and the break is worth more than another neat answer.

The letters in this word

पे • ट — one known letter, one known mātṛā, one consonant to feel.

प takes े, the mātṛā that perches on the head-line and turns the built-in *a* into *e* — the second of the two vowel signs you practised on नाम and मेरा.

Then ट: a **retroflex** ṭ, tongue-tip curled back, not the त of दाँत made flat against the teeth. Say *dāṇit*, then *peṭ*.

Grammar Lens: masculine, and the whole set together

पेट (*peṭ*) = “stomach, belly,” and it is **masculine** — मेरा पेट.

Now you can answer a doctor, and exactly one of the six takes मेरी: *merā sir*, *merā hāth*, **merī āṁkh**, *merā dāṇit*, *merā pair*, *merā peṭ* — feminine company for कुर्सी and किताब.

The sentence, with नहीं in its usual place just before है: मेरा पेट ठीक नहीं है — which, said in India, means what it says and rather more.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

पेट goes back to Prakrit पेट्ट (*peṭṭa*) — and there the clean line ends. The mainstream account treats it as a **Dravidian** word taken into Indo-Aryan; compare reconstructed Dravidian ***poṭṭ-**. Turner’s comparative dictionary does not name Dravidian, but neither does he derive *peṭṭa* from any Sanskrit word: he only remarks that it sits close to Indo-Aryan words for “basket.” That resemblance is a note, not a

derivation, and it is often quoted as one.

So: **the origin of पेट is unsettled**, with Dravidian leading — the honesty रोटी needed, one lesson away from पानी, whose story is exact. A language is made of what people said, and some of that came from neighbours speaking something else.

There is even a fingerprint: the **retroflex** consonants, the ढ you just curled your tongue for, are the feature of Indian Indo-Aryan most often credited to long contact with Dravidian.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all six — *merā sir, merā hāth, merī āmikh, merā dāmit, merā pair, merā peṭ*
- *merā peṭ thāik nahīmī hai; then merī āmikh thāik nahīmī hai*
- every feminine noun you own — *kursī, chāy, kitāb, āmikh*
- the three exact ancestries — *āmikh, dāmit, pair*; then the two unsettled — *peṭ, roṭī*

Before you move on

Where does पेट come from? (**Unsettled** — Prakrit *peṭṭa*, most likely a **Dravidian** loan; the “basket” link is a resemblance.) Of your six body words, which takes मेरी? (आँख.) Which earlier word had the same honest dead end? (रोटी, beside पानी.)

Chapter 39

The People Around You

Modes: ⇐ voice (3) 👁 eyes (1) ⇐ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the friend, the child, the man and the woman around me, I know that दोस्त takes its possessive from the person while आँख never does, and I can choose between औरत and महिला by register.

Say the whole household with every possessive right — मेरा पिता, मेरी माता, मेरा भाई, मेरी बहन, मेरा बच्चा, मेरी बच्ची — then मेरा दोस्त or मेरी दोस्त depending on who the friend is, and say why Arabic ‘awra does not mean “woman” even though औरत does.

39.1 दोस्त (dost) — the friend, who is “the one chosen”

You can name a brother and a sister. Here is the person you picked rather than were given, and the word says exactly that.

The letters in this word

दो • स्त — an ending you have already assembled by hand.

द with ो gives दो. Then स्त — स stripped of its built-in *a* by the **virāma**, fusing with त into one conjunct: the cluster inside नमस्ते, the first conjunct you ever wrote.

So मेरा दोस्त is built entirely from strokes already yours.

Grammar Lens: the noun that leans on who you mean

दोस्त (*dost*) = “friend,” and in the dictionary it is **masculine** — मेरा दोस्त.

But it bends. When the friend is a woman, ordinary modern Hindi says मेरी दोस्त. The word has not changed shape; the **possessive** followed the person. Both are current; neither is a mistake.

That is unlike everything so far. आँख is feminine whatever you mean. दोस्त takes its gender from **who the friend is**.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

दोस्त is **Persian**, دوست (*dōst*); Old Persian had **dauštā**, an agent noun, “the one held dear.”

Its root is *ǵews-*, and the old meaning is not “love” but “to taste, to try, to choose.” Sanskrit inherited it as जुष् (*jus-*). Latin has **gustāre** — English **gusto**, **disgust** — and English **choose** is the same root.

So a *dōst* is one you have **tried and chosen**; the narrowing to “beloved” happened inside the Indo-Iranian branch alone.

You’ll want to know — why it starts with a d

The consonant at the front of this root came out as **z-** in Avestan and **d-** in **Old Persian**, by a regular sound law across the vocabulary.

Which is why “friend” starts with **द** in Persian and Hindi while its Sanskrit cousin *jus-* starts with something else. An initial consonant is a passport stamp: it says which road the word came by.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *merā dost* for a man, *merī dost* for a woman
- the given and the chosen — *merā bhāī*, *merī bahin*, *merā dost*
- *namaste*, then *dost* — one conjunct
- *dōst*, *jus-*, *gustāre*, *choose*

Before you move on

How do you say “my friend” about a woman? (मेरी दोस्त — the possessive follows the person.) What did the root behind *dōst* first mean? (**To taste, try, choose.**) Why does Persian say *d-* where Avestan says *z-*? (**A regular sound law.**)

39.2 बच्चा (bacchā) — the child, who is a “yearling”

You have पिता and माता. Here is the third person at that table — and this word finally lets the masculine and feminine forms stand side by side.

Grammar Lens: a pair you can see

बच्चा (*bacchā*) = “child,” masculine — मेरा बच्चा.

Here the lean does real work at last. Swap the final -ा for -ी and you get बच्ची (*bacchī*), a girl child, **feminine** — मेरी बच्ची.

This is what दरवाज़ा and कुर्सी only hinted at: for *this* class of noun -ā/-ī is not a lean but the machinery, and the word changes with the person. Which is exactly what दोस्त would not do.

You already know how to ask this child’s age: कितने साल के हो? — how many years someone *is of*, rather than how many they *have*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

बच्चा is **Persian**, بچه (*bacca*) — and the obvious story is wrong.

Persian *bacca* did **not** come from Sanskrit वत्स (*vatsa*), “calf, young one.” The two are **sisters**: one Indo-Iranian word inherited down two separate branches. Centuries later the Persian one was borrowed into Hindi — which had *already* inherited the Sanskrit one as बछड़ा (*bachṛā*), “calf.”

So Hindi holds both, the same ancient word by two roads — the pattern दरवाज़ा and द्वार showed you, running again, and the same Persian relay that brought दोस्त.

Behind both stands **wet-**, “year.” Latin **vetus**, “old,” is from it — English **veteran** — and so are Latin **vitulus**, “calf,” and English **wether**, a yearling sheep.

A child, at the root, is a **yearling**. पिता and माता are named by relationship; बच्चा is named by age.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *bacchā* and *bacchī*; then *merā bacchā*, *merī bacchī*
- the family — *merā pitā*, *merī mātā*, *merā bacchā*
- the two roads — *bacchā* from Persian, *bachṛā* inherited; one word
- *vetus*, *vitulus*, *wether* — and the meaning under all of them (year)

Before you move on

What is the feminine of बच्चा, and how does the possessive move? (बच्ची — *merā bacchā*, *merī bacchī*.) Is Persian *bacca* descended from Sanskrit *vatsa*? (No — they are **sisters**; Hindi’s inherited cousin is बछड़ा.) What does the root mean? (**Year** — a child is a yearling.)

39.3 आदमी (*ādmī*) — the man, and the lean breaking backwards

The child has grown up. And this word does what none so far has — it ends in -ी and is masculine anyway.

Grammar Lens: the lean breaks the other way

आदमी (*ādmī*) = “**man, person**,” and it is **masculine**. Say एक आदमी — it is also the ordinary word for “person” in general, and stays masculine doing that. Ask कितने साल के हो? of him and you are asking how many years he *is of*, the way Hindi counts age.

A warning before you reach for the possessive: मेरा आदमी is real Hindi but means what English’s *my man* means. Keep एक आदमी.

The gender still shows the instant anything agrees with the noun. Put it beside कुर्सी: both end in long -ी, one is feminine, one masculine, and no reasoning takes you from the ending to the answer. Beside बच्चा / बच्ची, where the ending *does* carry the gender, the contrast is sharper.

So the lean has failed in **both** directions: चाय and किताब feminine with no -ी, आदमी masculine with one.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

आदमी is **Arabic**, آدمي (*ādamī*), and it came the Persian way — the road of कुर्सी and किताब.

Now the ending. That -ī is not Hindi at all. It is the **Arabic ending meaning “belonging to, of the kind of.”** Attach it to آدم (*Ādam*) and you get “**of Adam.**” A human being, in this word, is one of Adam’s.

آدم is Hebrew *ʿādām*, and here care is needed. You have probably heard that *ʿādām* comes from *ʿadāmāh*, “ground” — man made of earth. Genesis sets the two side by side and means you to notice: a **deliberate pun**, and a famous one.

It is not the etymology. The prevailing view links the root *ʿ-d-m* to **redness** — behind Hebrew *ʿādōm*, “red,” and **Edom**. Beyond that, unsettled.

Worth keeping: **a wordplay a text makes on purpose is not where a word came from.**

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ādmī*, then *ek ādmī*
- *kursī* feminine, *ādmī* masculine; then *merī kursī*, and stop
- the lean, and both ways it fails — *chāy*, *kitāb*, *ādmī*
- what the -ī on *ādamī* means

Before you move on

कुर्सी and आदमी end alike — same gender? (**No.**) What is the -ī of *ādamī* doing? (**Arabic “belonging to”** — “of Adam.”) Is *ʿādām* from the word for ground? (**No** — Genesis is making a deliberate pun; the root is usually connected to **redness**.)

39.4 औरत (aurat) — the word for “woman,” and which one to use

The last word of the chapter, and the one where Hindi hands you a choice rather than a word.

Grammar Lens: the pair, and the family complete

औरत (*aurat*) = “**woman**,” and it is **feminine**. Say एक औरत — and for the reason एक आदमी was the safe phrase, leave मेरी औरत alone: it means *my woman*, a wife. औ is one vowel letter, *au*, standing alone. Consonant ending, feminine — as चाय, किताब and आँख were. Beside it आदमी: -ी ending, masculine. Neither adult’s gender is reachable from spelling. Where you *can* hear the agreement is on the child: मेरा बच्चा, मेरी बच्ची, the yearling who takes the ending seriously. The family: पिता, माता, भाई, बहन, बच्चा, आदमी, औरत — and the chosen one, दोस्त.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

औरत is **Arabic**, عورة (*‘awra*), on the three-consonant root **‘-w-r** — built the way **k-t-b** built किताब — whose senses run to *a weak point, a gap in a defence, something left uncovered*. Then the fact that changes what you do with all that: **Arabic ‘awra does not mean “woman.”** That sense is a **Persian** development. Persian moved the noun to mean a woman or a wife and handed *that* to Hindi and Urdu, on record from around 1420 — the same Persian relay that carried दोस्त. So the harsh root sense is not a claim Arabic makes about women. It is the earlier life of a word another language repurposed.

You’ll want to know — three words, and which to say

Three words, and the choice is **register**, exactly as for किताब / पुस्तक / पोथा.

- औरत — Perso-Arabic, plain and everyday. Common in speech; some speakers avoid it formally, partly because of the origin above.
- महिला (*mahilā*) — a Sanskrit borrowing, the **respectful, public** word: signs, announcements, official prose. Its Sanskrit origin is **uncertain**; one serious proposal traces it to Dravidian.

- स्त्री (*strī*) — Sanskrit, older and literary. Secure back to Indo-Iranian, no further.

महिला where you would write, औरत where you would talk.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ek aurat*, then *ek ādmī* — neither ending gives its gender away
- *merā pitā*, *merī mātā*, *merā bhāī*, *merī bahīn*, *merā bacchā*, *merī bacchī*
- *merā dost*, then *merī dost*
- every feminine noun you own — *kursī*, *chāy*, *kitāb*, *ānīkh*, *bacchī*

Before you move on

Does Arabic عورة mean “woman”? (**No** — that sense is **Persian**.) Which goes on a public sign, which in conversation? (महिला written; औरत spoken.) Your family, minding every possessive? (*Merā pitā*, *merī mātā*, *merā bhāī*, *merī bahīn*, *merā bacchā*.)

Chapter 40

Pointing, and Asking

Modes: ⇄ voice (7) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 7 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can point at something in Hindi and ask who or where it is — and I can say what the six words have in common.

Say the near word, the far word and the question word in a row, and name the part that changed.

40.1 यह (yah) — this one — the thing near me

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: यह

यह — *yah* — this one — the thing near me.

Say it, and point while you say it. That is the whole word: it does not mean anything on its own, it means whatever your finger is on.

Its partner is वह *vah*, which you will meet in a moment. The two of them differ by one sound at the front — **y-** for near — and that is not a coincidence. It is the whole system, and the last lesson of this chapter says so.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “यह” three times, pointing at something different each time

- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *yah*? (this one — the thing near me.) What sound does it start with, and does that sound mean near, far, or a question? (**y** — near.)

40.2 वह (vah) — that one — the thing over there

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: वह

वह — *vah* — that one — the thing over there.

Say it, and point while you say it. That is the whole word: it does not mean anything on its own, it means whatever your finger is on.

Its partner is यह *yah*, which you will meet just now. The two of them differ by one sound at the front — **v**- for far — and that is not a coincidence. It is the whole system, and the last lesson of this chapter says so.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “वह” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *vah*? (that one — the thing over there.) What sound does it start with, and does that sound mean near, far, or a question? (**v** — far.)

40.3 यहाँ (yahā) — here — where I am

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: यहाँ

यहाँ — *yahā* — here — where I am.

Say it, and point while you say it. That is the whole word: it does not mean anything on its own, it means whatever your finger is on.

Its partner is वहाँ *vahā*, which you will meet in a moment. The two of them differ by one sound at the front — **y-** for near — and that is not a coincidence. It is the whole system, and the last lesson of this chapter says so.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “यहाँ” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *yahā*? (here — where I am.) What sound does it start with, and does that sound mean near, far, or a question? (**y-** — near.)

40.4 वहाँ (vahā) — there — where I am not

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: वहाँ

वहाँ — *vahā* — there — where I am not.

Say it, and point while you say it. That is the whole word: it does not mean anything on its own, it means whatever your finger is on.

Its partner is यहाँ *yahā*, which you will meet just now. The two of them differ by one sound at the front — **v-** for far — and that is not a coincidence. It is the whole system, and the last lesson of this chapter says so.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “वहाँ” three times, pointing at something different each time

- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *vahā*? (there — where I am not.) What sound does it start with, and does that sound mean near, far, or a question? (**v-** — far.)

40.5 कौन (kaun) — who? — asking about a person

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: कौन

कौन — *kaun* — who? — asking about a person.

Say it, and point while you say it. That is the whole word: it does not mean anything on its own, it means whatever your finger is on.

Its partner is कहाँ *kahā*, which you will meet in a moment. The two of them differ by one sound at the front — **k-** for ask — and that is not a coincidence. It is the whole system, and the last lesson of this chapter says so.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “कौन” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *kaun*? (who? — asking about a person.) What sound does it start with, and does that sound mean near, far, or a question? (**k-** — ask.)

40.6 कहाँ (kahā) — where? — asking about a place

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: कहाँ

कहाँ — *kahā* — where? — asking about a place.

Say it, and point while you say it. That is the whole word: it does not mean anything on its own, it means whatever your finger is on.

Its partner is कौन *kaun*, which you will meet just now. The two of them differ by one sound at the front — **k-** for ask — and that is not a coincidence. It is the whole system, and the last lesson of this chapter says so.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “कहाँ” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *kahā*? (where? — asking about a place.) What sound does it start with, and does that sound mean near, far, or a question? (**k-** — ask.)

40.7 y- / v- / k- — six words, one machine

Say the six words from this chapter out loud, in order. Listen to how they begin.

Grammar lens: one slot changes

You did not learn six words. You learned **three beginnings** and reused them.

meaning	word
near	यहाँ <i>yahā</i>
far	वहाँ <i>vahā</i>
question	कहाँ <i>kahā</i>

Hindi runs the same machine on different consonants: यहाँ, वहाँ, कहाँ. Change the front, and the meaning walks from **near** to **far** to a **question**. Nothing else in the word moves.

The same three beginnings run the thing-words too: यह *yah* and वह

vah start exactly like the first two rows. This chapter did not teach you the matching question word for things — that one arrives later, and when it does you will already know what it has to start with. This is worth more than the six words are. When you meet a new word in this family later, you will not have to be taught all three of it — you will be taught one and work out the others.

Your turn

- *Say it:* the near word, then the far word, then the question word
- *Say it:* them again for place, not for things
- *Notice:* the part that did NOT change

Before you move on

Which beginning means near? (**y**-) Far? (**v**-) And which one turns the word into a question? (**k**-)

Chapter 41

Describing Things

Modes: ⇄ voice (6) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 6 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can point at something in Hindi and ask who or where it is — and I can say what the six words have in common.

Say the near word, the far word and the question word in a row, and name the part that changed.

41.1 बड़ा (baṛā) — big

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: बड़ा

बड़ा — baṛā — big.

Put it in front of a word you already know and you have said something new. That is all an adjective does in this language.

The last lesson of this chapter gives the one rule that governs every adjective you will ever meet here.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “बड़ा” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *baṛā*? (**big.**) Where does it go — before the word it describes, or after? (**Before.**)

41.2 छोटा (*choṭā*) — small

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: छोटा

छोटा — *choṭā* — small.

Put it in front of a word you already know and you have said something new. That is all an adjective does in this language.

You met बड़ा *baṛā* a moment ago. Put them side by side and nothing about either one changes.

The last lesson of this chapter gives the one rule that governs every adjective you will ever meet here.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “छोटा” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *choṭā*? (**small.**) Where does it go — before the word it describes, or after? (**Before.**)

41.3 अच्छा (*acchā*) — good

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: अच्छा

अच्छा — *acchā* — good.

Put it in front of a word you already know and you have said something new. That is all an adjective does in this language.

You met छोटा *chotā* a moment ago. Put them side by side and nothing about either one changes.

The last lesson of this chapter gives the one rule that governs every adjective you will ever meet here.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “अच्छा” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *acchā*? (**good.**) Where does it go — before the word it describes, or after? (**Before.**)

41.4 नया (*nayā*) — new

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: नया

नया — *nayā* — new.

Put it in front of a word you already know and you have said something new. That is all an adjective does in this language.

You met अच्छा *acchā* a moment ago. Put them side by side and nothing about either one changes.

The last lesson of this chapter gives the one rule that governs every adjective you will ever meet here.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “नया” three times, pointing at something different each time

- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *nayā*? (**new.**) Where does it go — before the word it describes, or after? (**Before.**)

41.5 पुराना (*purānā*) — old — of a thing, not of a person

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: पुराना

पुराना — *purānā* — old — of a thing, not of a person.

Put it in front of a word you already know and you have said something new. That is all an adjective does in this language.

You met नया *nayā* a moment ago. Put them side by side and nothing about either one changes.

The last lesson of this chapter gives the one rule that governs every adjective you will ever meet here.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “पुराना” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *purānā*? (**old — of a thing, not of a person.**) Where does it go — before the word it describes, or after? (**Before.**)

41.6 before the noun, and it AGREES — five words, one rule

Say the five words from this chapter out loud, then say each one in front of a noun you already know.

Grammar lens: where an adjective goes

You did not learn five separate words. You learned **where an adjective goes**, and five words that go there.

meaning	word
big	बड़ा <i>baṛā</i>
small	छोटा <i>choṭā</i>
good	अच्छा <i>acchā</i>

Hindi is the one that changes: बड़ा for a masculine noun, बड़ी for a feminine one.

This is worth more than the five words are. Every noun you already know — your name, the house, the water, the day — can now take any of them in front, and every adjective you meet from here goes in the same place.

Your turn

- *Say it*: each of the five in front of a noun you already know
- *Say it*: two of them with the same noun, one after the other
- *Notice*: whether the adjective changed shape when the noun did

Before you move on

Where does an adjective go in this language? (**In front of the noun.**) Does it change shape to match the noun? (and it AGREES.)

Devanagari — a reference

Not to be read before the lessons — they teach reading through real words, each letter introduced as a word needs it. This page just gathers the system.

The three facts

1. **Consonants carry a built-in “a”**: क = ka, न = na, म = ma.
2. **A vowel sign (*mātrā*) changes that vowel**: ा = ā (का kā), ि = i (written before, read after), े = e (के ke), and ि ु ू ै ौ for ī, u, ū, ai, o, au.
3. **A halant (ँ)** removes the built-in vowel: क् = bare k. A vowel-less consonant leans onto the next as a **conjunct**: स् + त → स्त (st), न् + य → न्य (ny).

Independent vowels (word-initial)

अ a · आ ā · इ i · ई ī · उ u · ऊ ū · ए e · ऐ ai · ओ o · औ au.

Worth flagging

- **Aspiration** distinguishes letters: क k / ख kh, त t / थ th, द d / ध dh — the “h” is a real puff.
- **Retroflex** (ट ढ ण) vs. **dental** (त द न): tongue curled back vs. on the teeth.
- **Nukta** (a dot below) marks Perso-Arabic/English sounds: ज़ z, फ़ f, क़ q.

The two vocabularies

Many everyday ideas have two Hindi words — a **Sanskrit** one, often formal (*dhanyavād*, *namaste*), and a **Perso-Arabic** one, often everyday (*shukriyā*, *alvidā*). The lessons trace which is which.

Glossary

This glossary collects every word and phrase taught in the book. Pronunciation appears when it differs from the written form; chapter numbers show where each entry is introduced.

आभार *ābhār*

gratitude

Introduced in Chapter 50.

अभी *abhī*

right now

Introduced in Chapter 49.

अच्छा *acchā*

good

Introduced in Chapter 41.

आदर *ādar*

respect

Introduced in Chapter 50.

आँगन *āṅgan*

a courtyard

Introduced in Chapter 51.

आना *ānā*

to come

Introduced in Chapter 42.

आशीर्वाद *āśīrvād*

a blessing

Introduced in Chapter 50.

बच्चा *bacca*

child — masculine, with a feminine बच्ची, and a Persian word that landed on top of an inherited Sanskrit cousin

Introduced in Chapter 39.

बैठना *baiṭhnā*

to sit

Introduced in Chapter 42.

बाल *bāl*

hair

Introduced in Chapter 46.

बड़ा *baṛā*

big

Introduced in Chapter 41.

बस *bas*

enough, that's all

Introduced in Chapter 48.

बेटा *beṭā*

son

Introduced in Chapter 44.

बेटी *beṭī*

daughter

Introduced in Chapter 44.

बिल्कुल *bilkul*

absolutely

Introduced in Chapter 48.

बोलना *bolnā*

to speak

Introduced in Chapter 43.

छात्र *chātra*

a student

Introduced in Chapter 47.

छोटा *choṭā*

small

Introduced in Chapter 41.

दाँत *dantā*

tooth — masculine, though it is built exactly like the feminine आँख, and a cousin of Latin *dēns* and English tooth

Introduced in Chapter 38.

देखना *dekhnā*

to look, to see

Introduced in Chapter 43.

देना *denā*

to give

Introduced in Chapter 42.

दीया *dīyā*

an oil lamp

Introduced in Chapter 45.

एहसान *ehsān*

a favour

Introduced in Chapter 50.

गला *galā*

the throat

Introduced in Chapter 46.

घंटा *ghaṇṭā*

hour — literally “bell,” from the historical practice of striking a bell to mark the hour

Introduced in Chapter 18.

है *hai*

is

Introduced in Chapter 2.

हरा *harā*

green — a deep cousin of German *gelb* and English *yellow* from an ancient shining-color root

Introduced in Chapter 24.

हूँ *hūmī*

am (1st-person of होना, “to be”)

Introduced in Chapter 3.

कहाँ *kahā*

where? — asking about a place

Introduced in Chapter 40.

कैसे *kaise*

how (also कैसा/कैसी, agreeing)

Introduced in Chapter 3.

कान *kān*

an ear

Introduced in Chapter 46.

कपड़ा *kapṛā*

cloth

Introduced in Chapter 45.

कौन *kaun*

who? — asking about a person

Introduced in Chapter 40.

खाना *khānā*

food — masculine, from a Sanskrit verb of eating, and not to be confused with its Persian look-alike meaning “house”

Introduced in Chapter 37.

खड़ा होना *khaṛā honā*

to stand

Introduced in Chapter 42.

किसान *kisān*

a farmer

Introduced in Chapter 47.

कृपया *kṛpayā*

please (kṛpayā — “kindly,” from kṛpā “grace/compassion”)

Introduced in Chapter 8.

कुर्सी *kursī*

chair — your first feminine noun, and a word that has been passing between Middle Eastern languages for four thousand years

Introduced in Chapter 36.

कुत्ता *kuttā*

dog — a third uncertain-origin everyday word displacing an inherited PIE

dog-word

Introduced in Chapter 23.

क्या *kyā*

what

Introduced in Chapter 2.

लेना *lenā*

to take — worn down from Sanskrit labh-, which also sits, undisguised, in the noun लाभ

Introduced in Chapter 35.

लिखना *likhnā*

to write

Introduced in Chapter 43.

लोग *log*

people

Introduced in Chapter 44.

मैं *maini*

I

Introduced in Chapter 3.

माला *mālā*

a garland

Introduced in Chapter 51.

मेहमान *mehmān*

a guest

Introduced in Chapter 47.

मेरा *merā*

my

Introduced in Chapter 2.

मेज़ *mez*

a table

Introduced in Chapter 51.

मिलेंगे *milenge*

(we) will meet

Introduced in Chapter 4.

मिठाई *mithāi*

a sweet

Introduced in Chapter 51.

मुलाक्रात *mulāqāt*

a meeting

Introduced in Chapter 49.

नाक *nāk*

a nose

Introduced in Chapter 46.

नमक *namak*

salt

Introduced in Chapter 45.

नमस्ते *namaste*

hello / goodbye (namaste — “I bow to you”)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

नया *nayā*

new

Introduced in Chapter 41.

निकलना *nikalnā*

to set out, to leave

Introduced in Chapter 49.

पानी रोटी *pānī roṭī*

water (literally “the drinkable one,” not the ancient Sanskrit word for water) and bread/flatbread

Introduced in Chapter 15.

परिवार *parivār*

family

Introduced in Chapter 44.

पड़ोसी *paṛosī*

a neighbour

Introduced in Chapter 47.

परसों *parsonī*

the day after tomorrow

Introduced in Chapter 49.

फल *phal*

a fruit

Introduced in Chapter 45.

फूल *phul*

a flower

Introduced in Chapter 51.

प्रणाम *praṇām*

a bow, a salutation

Introduced in Chapter 50.

पुराना *purānā*

old — of a thing, not of a person

Introduced in Chapter 41.

साबुन *sābun*

soap

Introduced in Chapter 45.

सच *sac*

true

Introduced in Chapter 48.

सफ़र *safar*

a journey

Introduced in Chapter 49.

शायद *śāyad*

perhaps

Introduced in Chapter 48.

शिक्षक *śikṣak*

a teacher

Introduced in Chapter 47.

सुनना *sunnā*

to listen, to hear

Introduced in Chapter 43.

उँगली *uṅglī*

a finger

Introduced in Chapter 46.

वह *vah*

that one — the thing over there

Introduced in Chapter 40.

वहाँ *vahā*

there — where I am not

Introduced in Chapter 40.

यह *yah*

this one — the thing near me

Introduced in Chapter 40.

यहाँ *yahā*

here — where I am

Introduced in Chapter 40.

ज़रूर *zarūr*

certainly

Introduced in Chapter 48.

अलविदा

goodbye (alvidā — a final farewell, Persian/Arabic-derived)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

आँख

eye — feminine, and a word-for-word cousin of English “eye” and Latin “oculus”

Introduced in Chapter 38.

आदमी

man, person — masculine despite its -ī ending, and literally “of Adam”

Introduced in Chapter 39.

आप / तुम

you (respectful / familiar)

Introduced in Chapter 2.

आप कैसे हैं?

how are you? (respectful)

Introduced in Chapter 3.

आपका नाम क्या है?

what’s your name?

Introduced in Chapter 2.

आपका स्वागत है

you’re welcome (also “welcome!”)

Introduced in Chapter 3.

उम्र

age — the same word as Arabic’s ‘umr, borrowed through Persian, beside formal Sanskrit āyu

Introduced in Chapter 19.

एक दो तीन चार पाँच

one to five, with familiar Devanagari pieces and the chandrabindu in पाँच

Introduced in Chapter 6.

औरत

woman — feminine, an Arabic word that only came to mean “woman” in Persian, and one of three Hindi words separated by register

Introduced in Chapter 39.

किताब

book — feminine, built on the Arabic root for writing, and one of three Hindi words for a book that differ by register

Introduced in Chapter 37.

कमरा

room — masculine, and the same Latin word as English “camera”, brought to India by Portuguese ships
Introduced in Chapter 36.

करना

to do, to make (and काम करना, “to work”)
Introduced in Chapter 5.

कल मिलते हैं

see you tomorrow (and the कल puzzle)
Introduced in Chapter 4.

काला सफ़ेद

black and white — one Sanskrit word tangled up with time and death, one a Persian loan
Introduced in Chapter 11.

खुशी

happiness / pleased to meet you
Introduced in Chapter 2.

ग्यारह — बीस

11-20 — genuinely irregular, must be memorized individually; but उन्नीस (19) most likely preserves Sanskrit’s OWN subtractive naming, the same logic as Latin’s undeviginti
Introduced in Chapter 22.

घर

house, home — masculine, and from a Sanskrit word that meant a fenced enclosure before it meant a building
Introduced in Chapter 36.

चाय

tea — feminine, and one of the two names the world uses for the same leaf
Introduced in Chapter 37.

चलता हूँ

I’ll be off (lit. “I go”), gendered
Introduced in Chapter 4.

छह सात आठ नौ दस

six to ten, with seven and eight repeating the same Prakrit weight trade as three
Introduced in Chapter 21.

जनवरी फ़रवरी मार्च अप्रैल मई जून जुलाई अगस्त सितंबर अक्टूबर नवंबर दिसंबर

the Gregorian months — borrowed English/international names, running ALONGSIDE the traditional Vikram Samvat calendar’s own six-ritu-linked months
Introduced in Chapter 16.

ठीक

fine, well, correct — and the reply “मैं ठीक हूँ”

Introduced in Chapter 3.

दूध

milk — masculine, and literally “the milked thing”, a past participle that hardened into a noun

Introduced in Chapter 37.

दिन

“day” — shares its ultimate PIE root with Latin’s *diēs*, but through a separate derivational branch (din patterns with Baltic/Slavic “day”-words); Sanskrit’s own दिव्/द्यु are actually the closer, more direct cousins of *diēs*

Introduced in Chapter 25.

दोपहर

“afternoon” — the same word already met meaning precisely “noon” (two pahars after sunrise, HI-C17), now widened in modern everyday usage to cover the whole afternoon stretch, not just the exact midday moment

Introduced in Chapter 30.

दोपहर आधी रात

noon (literally “two pahars,” a traditional ~3-hour time unit) and midnight (“half night,” fully transparent)

Introduced in Chapter 17.

दरवाज़ा

door — masculine, a Persian loan whose first syllable is the same ancient word as English “door”

Introduced in Chapter 36.

दोस्त

friend — a Persian word for “the one chosen”, masculine by default but taking either possessive depending on who the friend is

Introduced in Chapter 39.

धन्यवाद

thank you (dhanyavād — formal, Sanskritic)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

नाम

name

Introduced in Chapter 2.

नमस्कार

hello (namaskār — more formal)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

नहीं

no / not (nahīm)

Introduced in Chapter 7.

पूछना

to ask — the same inherited verb as English “pray”, which once meant nothing more than asking

Introduced in Chapter 35.

पेट

stomach, belly — masculine, and the one word in this chapter with no clean ancestry at all

Introduced in Chapter 38.

पढ़ना

to read — and equally “to study”, because the Sanskrit verb underneath it meant “to recite aloud”

Introduced in Chapter 34.

पिता माता

father and mother — Sanskrit cousins of Latin pater/mater and English father/mother

Introduced in Chapter 12.

पैर

foot — masculine, and NOT the descendant of Sanskrit pāda; that honour belongs to पाँव

Introduced in Chapter 38.

पसंद

liked, pleasing — a Persian noun, not a verb, in a sentence where the thing you like is the subject and you are only the person it happens to

Introduced in Chapter 35.

फिर

again, then

Introduced in Chapter 4.

फिर मिलेंगे

we’ll meet again (goodbye)

Introduced in Chapter 4.

बोलता हूँ, बोलती हूँ, बोलते हैं

the present-habitual template — stem + -tā/-tī/-te + honā

Introduced in Chapter 5.

बोलना

to speak

Introduced in Chapter 5.

भाई बहन

brother (a PIE cousin of English “brother”) and sister (a DIFFERENT Sanskrit word entirely, not the PIE cousin of “sister”)

Introduced in Chapter 12.

मैं हिंदी बोलता हूँ

I speak Hindi (gendered)

Introduced in Chapter 5.

मदद करना

to help — a noun plus करना, which is how Hindi turns almost anything into a verb

Introduced in Chapter 35.

माफ़ कीजिए

please forgive me / sorry (māf kījiye — “please do forgiveness”)

Introduced in Chapter 9.

मेरा नाम ... है

my name is...

Introduced in Chapter 2.

मौसम

weather — the SAME root as English “monsoon”; rain has TWO words that sound alike but are NOT related, a real false-friend trap

Introduced in Chapter 20.

रात

“night” — already met inside aadhi raat (“midnight”); despite meaning the same thing as Latin’s nox, in a related Indo-European language, it comes from a COMPLETELY DIFFERENT PIE root — a genuine false cousin

Introduced in Chapter 26.

रहना

to live, to stay

Introduced in Chapter 5.

लिखना

to write — from a Sanskrit verb meaning “to scratch”, the same picture five language families reached independently

Introduced in Chapter 34.

लाल नीला

red and blue — a Persian gemstone-name, and the Sanskrit word behind the world’s word for “indigo”

Introduced in Chapter 11.

वसंत ग्रीष्म वर्षा शरद् हेमंत शिशिर

SIX traditional seasons, not four — India’s own ऋतु system, which the Western four-season frame doesn’t map onto cleanly

Introduced in Chapter 14.

शुक्रिया

thanks (shukriyā — everyday, Persian/Arabic-derived)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

शनिवार रविवार

Saturday and Sunday — completing Hindi’s planet-week

Introduced in Chapter 10.

शुभ दोपहर

“good afternoon” (shubh dopahar) — uses दोपहर in its modern, widened “afternoon” sense (HI-C30), not the narrow etymological “noon”; the rarest of this arc’s three शुभ+noun greetings in actual casual use, with नमस्ते/नमस्कार covering the afternoon in practice
Introduced in Chapter 33.

शुभ रात्रि

“good night” — literally “auspicious night,” using the formal literary raatri, not the everyday raat just taught, plus shubh, an “auspicious” word that started life meaning “shining”
Introduced in Chapter 27.

शुभ संध्या

“good evening” — sandhyā is the Sanskrit junction of day and night, with the register-crossing doublet sāñjh
Introduced in Chapter 32.

शाम

“evening” (shaam) — another genuine Persian loanword, like subah; looks tempting to connect to Sanskrit श्यामा (śyāmā, “night/dark”), but that’s a false cognate — different root entirely, despite the resemblance
Introduced in Chapter 29.

सोचना

to think — a verb that began life meaning “to grieve,” and still keeps the worry inside the noun सोच
Introduced in Chapter 34.

सुप्रभात

“good morning” (suprabhat) — सु (“good”) + प्रभात (prabhāt, native Sanskrit “dawn,” from prabhā, “light, splendour,” itself from bhā, “to shine”) — a completely different word from सुबह, the Persian-loan everyday noun; skews formal/written (radio, greeting cards) rather than casual spoken Hindi, where नमस्ते covers mornings too — but there’s no strong evidence it’s being displaced by English the way some other languages’ night greetings were found to be
Introduced in Chapter 31.

सुबह

“morning” (subah) — a Persian/Arabic loanword, NOT Sanskrit tatsama like din/raat; shares the Arabic root ص-ب-ح with ṣabāḥ (“morning”) and with the tuṣbiḥ inside the Arabic “good night” phrase
Introduced in Chapter 28.

समझना

to understand — literally “to wake up fully,” on the same root as Buddha
Introduced in Chapter 34.

सोमवार मंगलवार बुधवार गुरुवार शुक्रवार

Monday–Friday — Hindi’s own planet-week, independent of Rome’s
Introduced in Chapter 10.

सिर

the head — from Sanskrit śiras, worn down through a thousand years of everyday speech

Introduced in Chapter 13.

हाँ

yes (hām)

Introduced in Chapter 7.

हाथ

the hand — from Sanskrit hasta, with a real (if non-obvious) sound-change story

Introduced in Chapter 13.

Review Questions

Try these without looking ahead. Every prompt comes from the same canonical lesson data as its chapter. Answers begin in the next section.

Chapter 1

1.1 *The line on top — Devanagari's head-line*

When is the shirorekha usually drawn?

Answer Key

The first response is the canonical display answer. When a question accepts other authored forms, they appear underneath.

Chapter 1

1.1 *The line on top — Devanagari's head-line*

Answer: last

Also accepted: at the end; after the letter bodies

Index

Look up an English meaning, a dedicated language topic, or a chapter topic. Each linked reference opens the chapter where the material is introduced; the focus labels name only explicitly typed lesson sections.

0–9

11-20 — genuinely irregular, must be memorized individually;
but उन्नीस (19) most likely preserves Sanskrit’s OWN subtractive
naming, the same logic as Latin’s ūndēvīgintī ग्यारह — बीस
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A

a blessing आशीर्वाद (āśīrvād)
Chapter 50, p. 277

a bow, a salutation प्रणाम (praṇām)
Chapter 50, p. 277

a courtyard आँगन (āṅgan)
Chapter 51, p. 283

a farmer किसान (kisān)
Chapter 47, p. 259

a favour एहसान (ehsān)
Chapter 50, p. 277

a finger उँगली (uṅlī)
Chapter 46, p. 253

a flower फूल (phūl)
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a fruit फल (phal)
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a garland माला (mālā)
Chapter 51, p. 283

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a journey सफ़र (safar)

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a meeting मुलाक़ात (mulāqāt)

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a neighbour पड़ोसी (paṛosī)

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a table मेज़ (mez)

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absolutely बिलकुल (bilkul)

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Afternoon

chapter topic; Chapter 30, p. 129

“afternoon” — the same word already met meaning precisely

“noon” (two pahars after sunrise, HI-C17), now widened in modern everyday usage to cover the whole afternoon stretch, not just the exact midday moment दोपहर

Chapter 30, p. 129

again, then फिर

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age — the same word as Arabic’s ʿumr, borrowed through Persian, beside formal Sanskrit āyu उम्र

Chapter 19, p. 95

am (1st-person of होना, “to be”) हूँ (hūmī)

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 11

an ear कान (kān)

Chapter 46, p. 253

an oil lamp दीया (dīyā)

Chapter 45, p. 247

Asking Someone’s Age

chapter topic; Chapter 19, p. 95

B

before the noun, and it AGREES — five words, one rule

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 41, p. 193

big बड़ा (baṛā)

Chapter 41, p. 193

black and white — one Sanskrit word tangled up with time and death, one a Persian loan काला सफ़ेद

Chapter 11, p. 57

book — feminine, built on the Arabic root for writing, and one of three Hindi words for a book that differ by register किताब

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 37, p. 163

brother (a PIE cousin of English “brother”) and sister (a DIFFERENT Sanskrit word entirely, not the PIE cousin of “sister”) भाई बहन

Chapter 12, p. 63

C

certainly ज़रूर (zarūr)

Chapter 48, p. 265

chair — your first feminine noun, and a word that has been passing between Middle Eastern languages for four thousand years कुर्सी (kursī)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 36, p. 155

child — masculine, with a feminine बच्ची, and a Persian word that landed on top of an inherited Sanskrit cousin बच्चा (bacca)

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 39, p. 179

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Courtesy Words

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D

daughter बेटी (beṭī)

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chapter topic; Chapter 25, p. 119

“day” — shares its ultimate PIE root with Latin’s *diēs*, but through a separate derivational branch (din patterns with Baltic/Slavic “day”-words); Sanskrit’s own दिव्/द्यु are actually the closer, more direct cousins of *diēs* दिन

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Days of the Week

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Describing Things

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dog — a third uncertain-origin everyday word displacing an inherited PIE dog-word कुत्ता (kuttā)

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Dog and Cat

chapter topic; Chapter 23, p. 111

door — masculine, a Persian loan whose first syllable is the same ancient word as English “door” दरवाज़ा

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 36, p. 155

E

enough, that’s all बस (bas)

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Evening

chapter topic; Chapter 29, p. 127

“evening” (shaam) — another genuine Persian loanword, like subah; looks tempting to connect to Sanskrit श्यामा (*śyāmā*, “night/dark”), but that’s a false cognate — different root entirely, despite the resemblance शाम

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eye — feminine, and a word-for-word cousin of English “eye” and Latin “oculus” आँख

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 38, p. 171

F

Family

chapter topic; Chapter 12, p. 63

family परिवार (parivār)

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Farewells

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father and mother — Sanskrit cousins of Latin pater/mater and English father/mother पिता माता

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fine, well, correct — and the reply “मैं ठीक हूँ” ठीक

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 11

food — masculine, from a Sanskrit verb of eating, and not to be confused with its Persian look-alike meaning “house” खाना (khānā)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 37, p. 163

foot — masculine, and NOT the descendant of Sanskrit pāda; that honour belongs to पाँव पैर

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Four Verbs of the Mind

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friend — a Persian word for “the one chosen”, masculine by default but taking either possessive depending on who the friend is दोस्त

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 39, p. 179

G

good अच्छा (acchā)

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Good Afternoon

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“good afternoon” (shubh dopahar) — uses दोपहर in its modern, widened “afternoon” sense (HI-C30), not the narrow etymological “noon”; the rarest of this arc’s three शुभ+noun greetings in actual casual use, with नमस्ते/नमस्कार covering the afternoon in practice शुभ दोपहर

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“good evening” — sandhyā is the Sanskrit junction of day and night, with the register-crossing doublet sāñjh शुभ संध्या

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“good morning” (suprabhat) — सु (“good”) + प्रभात (prabhāt, native Sanskrit “dawn,” from prabhā, “light, splendour,” itself from bhā, “to shine”) — a completely different word from सुबह, the Persian-loan everyday noun; skews formal/written (radio, greeting cards) rather than casual spoken Hindi, where नमस्ते covers mornings too — but there’s no strong evidence it’s being displaced by English the way some other languages’ night greetings were found to be सुप्रभात

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Good Night

chapter topic; Chapter 27, p. 123

good night” — literally “auspicious night,” using the formal literary raatri, not the everyday raat just taught, plus shubh, an “auspicious” word that started life meaning “shining शुभ रात्रि

Chapter 27, p. 123

goodbye (alvidā — a final farewell, Persian/
Arabic-derived) अलविदा

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 1, p. 1

gratitude आभार (ābhār)

Chapter 50, p. 277

green — a deep cousin of German gelb and English yellow from an ancient shining-color root हरा (harā)

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Green and Yellow

chapter topic; Chapter 24, p. 115

Greetings

chapter topic; Chapter 1, p. 1

H

hair बाल (bāl)

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Hair, Ear, and Throat

chapter topic; Chapter 46, p. 253

happiness / pleased to meet you खुशी

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 2, p. 5

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hello / goodbye (namaste — “I bow to you”) नमस्ते (namaste)

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 1, p. 1

hello (namaskār — more formal) नमस्कार

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 1, p. 1

here — where I am यहाँ (yahā)

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hour — literally “bell,” from the historical practice of striking a bell to mark the hour घंटा (ghaṇṭā)

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house, home — masculine, and from a Sanskrit word that meant a fenced enclosure before it meant a building घर

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 36, p. 155

how (also कैसा/कैसी, agreeing) कैसे (kaise)

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How Are You?

chapter topic; Chapter 3, p. 11

how are you? (respectful) आप कैसे हैं?

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 11

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I मैं (main)

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I’ll be off (lit. “I go”), gendered चलता हूँ

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 4, p. 15

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Introducing Yourself

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is है (hai)

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 5

L

ि — left on the page, right in the mouth

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liked, pleasing — a Persian noun, not a verb, in a sentence where the thing you like is the subject and you are only the person it happens to पसंद

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M

man, person — masculine despite its -ī ending, and literally “of Adam” आदमी

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milk — masculine, and literally “the milked thing”, a past participle that hardened into a noun दूध

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Months

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More Everyday Verbs

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chapter topic; Chapter 28, p. 125

“morning” (subah) — a Persian/Arabic loanword, NOT Sanskrit tatsama like din/raat; shares the Arabic root ح-ب-ص with ṣabāḥ (“morning”) and with the tuṣbiḥ inside the Arabic “good night”

phrase सुबह

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my मेरा (merā)

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my name is... मेरा नाम ... है

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N

name नाम

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 5

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“night” — already met inside aadhi raat (“midnight”); despite meaning the same thing as Latin’s nox, in a related Indo-European language, it comes from a COMPLETELY DIFFERENT PIE root — a genuine false cousin रात

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noon (literally “two pahars,” a traditional ~3-hour time unit)

and midnight (“half night,” fully transparent) दोपहर आधी रात

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Numbers Eleven to Twenty

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Numbers One to Five

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Numbers Six to Ten

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O

old — of a thing, not of a person पुराना (purānā)

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े — **one character, met inside words you already say**

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 8, p. 37

् — **one character, met inside words you already say**

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ी — **one character, met inside words you already say**

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ी — **one character, met inside words you already say**

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ँ — **one character, met inside words you already say**

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ु — **one character, met inside words you already say**

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One House, Four Languages

chapter topic; Chapter 36, p. 155

One Tea, Please

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one to five, with familiar Devanagari pieces and the

chandrabindu in पाँच एक दो तीन चार पाँच

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P

people लोग (log)

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perhaps शायद (śāyad)

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Please

chapter topic; Chapter 8, p. 37

please forgive me / sorry (māf kījiye — “please do forgiveness”) माफ़ कीजिए

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 9, p. 43

please (kṛpayā — “kindly,” from kṛpā “grace/compassion”) कृपया (kṛpayā)

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R

red and blue — a Persian gemstone-name, and the Sanskrit word behind the world’s word for “indigo” लाल नीला

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respect आदर (ādar)

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right now अभी (abhī)

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room — masculine, and the same Latin word as English “camera”, brought to India by Portuguese ships कमरा

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S

salt नमक (namak)

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Saturday and Sunday — completing Hindi’s planet-week शनिवार रविवार

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Seasons

chapter topic; Chapter 14, p. 75

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explicit focus: pronunciation, script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 4, p. 15

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six to ten, with seven and eight repeating the same Prakrit weight trade as three छह सात आठ नौ दस

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**SIX traditional seasons, not four — India’s own ऋतु system,
which the Western four-season frame doesn’t map onto
cleanly वसंत ग्रीष्म वर्षा शरद् हेमंत शिशिर**

Chapter 14, p. 75

Six Words for Where It Hurts

chapter topic; Chapter 38, p. 171

small छोटा (choṭā)

Chapter 41, p. 193

soap साबुन (sābun)

Chapter 45, p. 247

son बेटा (betā)

Chapter 44, p. 243

Sons, Daughters, and Everyone Else

chapter topic; Chapter 44, p. 243

Sorry

chapter topic; Chapter 9, p. 43

stomach, belly — masculine, and the one word in this chapter

with no clean ancestry at all पेट

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 38, p. 171

T

Taking, Asking, Helping — and Liking

chapter topic; Chapter 35, p. 147

Taking Your Leave

chapter topic; Chapter 49, p. 271

**tea — feminine, and one of the two names the world uses for the
same leaf चाय**

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 37, p. 163

Telling Time

chapter topic; Chapter 18, p. 91

thank you (dhanyavād — formal, Sanskritic) धन्यवाद

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 1, p. 1

thanks (shukriyā — everyday, Persian/Arabic-derived) शुक्रिया

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 1, p. 1

that one — the thing over there वह (vah)

Chapter 40, p. 187

the day after tomorrow परसों (parsoni)

Chapter 49, p. 271

The First Verbs

chapter topic; Chapter 5, p. 19

the Gregorian months — borrowed English/international names, running ALONGSIDE the traditional Vikram Samvat calendar's own six-ritu-linked months जनवरी फ़रवरी मार्च अप्रैल मई जून जुलाई अगस्त सितंबर अक्टूबर नवंबर दिसंबर

Chapter 16, p. 83

the hand — from Sanskrit hasta, with a real (if non-obvious) sound-change story हाथ

Chapter 13, p. 69

the head — from Sanskrit śiras, worn down through a thousand years of everyday speech सिर

Chapter 13, p. 69

The line on top — Devanagari's head-line

script and writing topic; Chapter 1, p. 1

The People Around You

chapter topic; Chapter 39, p. 179

the present-habitual template — stem + -tā/-tī/-te + honā बोलता हूँ, बोलती हूँ, बोलते हैं

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 5, p. 19

the throat गला (galā)

Chapter 46, p. 253

The vowel killer — virama and halant

script and writing topic; Chapter 2, p. 5

The vowel that is already there — the abugida

script and writing topic; Chapter 1, p. 1

there — where I am not वहाँ (vahā)

Chapter 40, p. 187

Things You Ask For

chapter topic; Chapter 45, p. 247

this one — the thing near me यह (yah)

Chapter 40, p. 187

to ask — the same inherited verb as English “pray”, which once meant nothing more than asking पूछना

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 35, p. 147

to come आना (ānā)

Chapter 42, p. 235

to do, to make (and काम करना, “to work”) करना

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 5, p. 19

to give देना (denā)

Chapter 42, p. 235

to help — a noun plus करना, which is how Hindi turns almost anything into a verb मदद करना

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 35, p. 147

to listen, to hear सुनना (sunnā)

Chapter 43, p. 239

to live, to stay रहना

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 5, p. 19

to look, to see देखना (dekhnā)

Chapter 43, p. 239

to read — and equally “to study”, because the Sanskrit verb underneath it meant “to recite aloud” पढ़ना

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 34, p. 139

to set out, to leave निकलना (nikalnā)

Chapter 49, p. 271

to sit बैठना (baiṭhnā)

Chapter 42, p. 235

to speak बोलना

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 5, p. 19

to speak बोलना (bolnā)

Chapter 43, p. 239

to stand खड़ा होना (kharā honā)

Chapter 42, p. 235

to take — worn down from Sanskrit labh-, which also sits,

undisguised, in the noun लाभ लेना (lenā)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 35, p. 147

to think — a verb that began life meaning “to grieve,” and still keeps the worry inside the noun सोच सोचना

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 34, p. 139

to understand — literally “to wake up fully,” on the same root as Buddha समझना

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 34, p. 139

to write लिखना (likhnā)

Chapter 43, p. 239

to write — from a Sanskrit verb meaning “to scratch”, the same picture five language families reached independently लिखना

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 34, p. 139

tooth — masculine, though it is built exactly like the feminine

आँख, and a cousin of Latin dēns and English tooth दाँत (danta)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 38, p. 171

true सच (sac)

Chapter 48, p. 265

V

Verbs of Seeing and Saying

chapter topic; Chapter 43, p. 239

W

Water and Bread

chapter topic; Chapter 15, p. 79

water (literally “the drinkable one,” not the ancient Sanskrit word for water) and bread/flatbread पानी रोटी (pānī roṭī)

Chapter 15, p. 79

we’ll meet again (goodbye) फिर मिलेंगे

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 4, p. 15

(we) will meet मिलेंगे (milenge)

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 4, p. 15

Weather

chapter topic; Chapter 20, p. 99

weather — the SAME root as English “monsoon”; rain has TWO words that sound alike but are NOT related, a real false-friend trap मौसम

Chapter 20, p. 99

Welcoming a Guest

chapter topic; Chapter 51, p. 283

what क्या (kyā)

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 5

what’s your name? आपका नाम क्या है?

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 2, p. 5

where? — asking about a place कहाँ (kahā)

Chapter 40, p. 187

who? — asking about a person कौन (kaun)

Chapter 40, p. 187

Who Someone Is

chapter topic; Chapter 47, p. 259

woman — feminine, an Arabic word that only came to mean “woman” in Persian, and one of three Hindi words separated by register औरत

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 39, p. 179

Y

y- / v- / k- — six words, one machine

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 40, p. 187

Yes and No

chapter topic; Chapter 7, p. 31

yes (hām) हाँ

Chapter 7, p. 31

you're welcome (also "welcome!") आपका स्वागत है

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 11

you (respectful / familiar) आप / तुम

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 5

Other

अ — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 8, p. 37

आ — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 9, p. 43

क and त — two letters on a map of the mouth

script and writing topic; Chapter 1, p. 1

क — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 7, p. 31

कितने साल के हो? — belonging to so many years

grammar topic; Chapter 19, p. 95

ख — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 18, p. 91

च — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 13, p. 69

छह, नौ, दस — three different paths

etymology topic; Chapter 21, p. 103

त — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 12, p. 63

तीन and चार — weight moves from consonants to vowels

etymology topic; Chapter 6, p. 23

द — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 19, p. 95

ध — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 20, p. 99

न and म — two bodies under one head-line

script and writing topic; Chapter 1, p. 1

न — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 7, p. 31

नमस्ते — assemble the greeting at last

script and writing topic; Chapter 2, p. 5

प — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 9, p. 43

पाँच — the nasal moved into the vowel

etymology topic; Chapter 6, p. 23

पीला — clear sounds, uncertain meaning

etymology topic; Chapter 24, p. 115

बिल्ली — a probable fourth cat-word family

etymology topic; Chapter 23, p. 111

म — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 6, p. 23

मेरा नाम — two words, two head-lines

script and writing topic; Chapter 2, p. 5

य — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 11, p. 57

र and स — a spineless letter and a possible cousin

script and writing topic; Chapter 2, p. 5

र — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 6, p. 23

ल — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 17, p. 87

शुभ संध्या or नमस्ते? — choose by setting

grammar topic; Chapter 32, p. 133

ष — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 15, p. 79

स — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 13, p. 69

स्त — two consonants squeezed together

script and writing topic; Chapter 2, p. 5

ह — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 10, p. 49

More Everyday Verbs

Modes: ⇄ voice (4) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name four everyday actions in Hindi and recognise the infinitive ending they share.

Complete HI-C42-give and say all four verbs in order.

41.7 आना (ānā) — to come

A short run of everyday verbs, one at a time.

You'll want to know: आना

आना (ānā) — “to come”.

Every Hindi infinitive ends in -ना (-nā), so this is ‘to come’ in the form a dictionary lists.

What you've built

One more everyday action. Three more follow, and each reuses the ones before it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- ānā
- it again, to someone standing in a doorway

Before you move on

What does आना mean? (“to come”.) Say it once more.

41.8 बैठना (baiṭhnā) — to sit

Before the new one: what did ānā mean?

You’ll want to know: बैठना

बैठना (baiṭhnā) — “to sit”.

Same -ना ending. Once you see it, you can spot an infinitive anywhere in a text without knowing the verb.

What you’ve built

One more everyday action. Three more follow, and each reuses the ones before it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- baiṭhnā
- it again, to someone standing in a doorway
- it after ānā, so the two sit together

Before you move on

What does बैठना mean? (“to sit”.) Say it once more.

41.9 खड़ा होना (kharā honā) — to stand

Before the new one: what did baiṭhnā mean?

You'll want to know: खड़ा होना

खड़ा होना (*khaṛā honā*) — “to stand”.

Two words: an adjective *khaṛā*, ‘upright’, plus *honā*, ‘to be’. Hindi builds many verbs this way, from a word plus a light verb.

What you've built

One more everyday action. Three more follow, and each reuses the ones before it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *khaṛā honā*
- it again, to someone standing in a doorway
- it after *baiṭhnā*, so the two sit together

Before you move on

What does खड़ा होना mean? (“to stand”.) Say it once more.

41.10 देना (*denā*) — to give

Before the new one: what did *khaṛā honā* mean?

You'll want to know: देना

देना (*denā*) — “to give”.

The plain ‘give’, and one of the light verbs Hindi uses to build compounds of its own.

What you've built

One more everyday action. That closes the run: four everyday actions, each met on its own.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *denā*
- it again, to someone standing in a doorway
- it after *khaṛā honā*, so the two sit together

Before you move on

What does देना mean? (“to give”.) Say it once more.

Verbs of Seeing and Saying

Modes: ⇄ voice (4) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name four verbs of perceiving and expressing in Hindi and recognise the infinitive ending they share.

Complete HI-C43-write and say all four verbs in order.

41.11 देखना (dekhnā) — to look, to see

Four verbs for taking things in and putting them out, one at a time.

You'll want to know: देखना

देखना (*dekhnā*) — “to look, to see”.

The -ना infinitive again. *Dekh-* is the stem you will meet inside every other form of this verb.

What you've built

One more. Three follow, and each reuses the ones before.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *dekhnā*
- it once more, slowly

Before you move on

What does देखना mean? (“to look, to see”.) Say it once more.

41.12 सुनना (sunnā) — to listen, to hear

Before the new one: what did *dekhnā* mean?

You’ll want to know: सुनना

सुनना (*sunnā*) — “to listen, to hear”.

Hindi does not separate listening from hearing; context does the work that a second verb does in English.

What you’ve built

One more. Three follow, and each reuses the ones before.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *sunnā*
- it once more, slowly
- it after *dekhnā*, so the two sit together

Before you move on

What does सुनना mean? (“to listen, to hear”.) Say it once more.

41.13 बोलना (bolnā) — to speak

Before the new one: what did *sunnā* mean?

You’ll want to know: बोलना

बोलना (*bolnā*) — “to speak”.

‘To speak’ as an activity. Hindi has a second verb, *kahnā*, for saying a particular thing — the difference English draws between *speak* and *say*.

What you've built

One more. Three follow, and each reuses the ones before.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *bolnā*
- it once more, slowly
- it after *sunṇā*, so the two sit together

Before you move on

What does बोलना mean? (“to speak”.) Say it once more.

41.14 लिखना (likhnā) — to write

Before the new one: what did *bolnā* mean?

You'll want to know: लिखना

लिखना (*likhnā*) — “to write”.

From the Sanskrit root √लिख् (*likh*), ‘to scratch’ — writing named after what a stylus did to a surface, long before ink.

What you've built

That closes the run: look, listen, speak, write.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *likhnā*
- it once more, slowly
- it after *bolnā*, so the two sit together

Before you move on

What does लिखना mean? (“to write”.) Say it once more.

Sons, Daughters, and Everyone Else

Modes: ⇄ voice (4) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name four more family and people words in this language.

Complete HI-C44-people and say all four words in order.

41.15 बेटा (beṭā) — son

Before the new one: what did *likhnā* mean?

You'll want to know: बेटा

बेटा (beṭā) — “son”.

The everyday word, not the Sanskrit *putra* that formal Hindi holds in reserve. Its *-ā* is the masculine ending you already met on बच्चा. Where the word itself came from is genuinely unsettled: comparative dictionaries reconstruct a Middle Indo-Aryan child-word behind it, with cousins in Punjabi, Gujarati and Marathi, and no agreed Sanskrit source.

What you've built

The first of four words for the people around you. Three follow, and each reuses the ones before.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *beṭā*
- it once more, slowly
- it after *likhnā*, so the two sit together

Before you move on

What does बेटा mean? (“son”.) Say it once more.

41.16 बेटी (*beṭī*) — daughter

Before the new one: what did *beṭā* mean?

You’ll want to know: बेटी

बेटी (*beṭī*) — “daughter”.

The same stem, with *-ī* in place of *-ā* — exactly the swap that turns बच्चा into बच्ची. A great deal of Hindi gender lives in that one final vowel, and this pair is the cleanest example you have met so far: nothing else in the word moves.

What you’ve built

Two of four, and one vowel doing all the work.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *beṭī*
- it once more, slowly
- it after *beṭā*, and hear only the last vowel move

Before you move on

What does बेटी mean? (“daughter”.) Say it once more.

41.17 परिवार (parivār) — family

Before the new one: what did *beṭī* mean?

You'll want to know: परिवार

परिवार (*parivār*) — “family”.

Sanskrit, and it comes apart in the hand: *pari-*, ‘around’, on the root *vr*, ‘to cover, to enclose’. Your family, in this word, is what surrounds you. The same root gives आवरण (*āvaran*), ‘a covering’ — one root, two very different everyday words.

What you've built

Three of four, and a word you can take apart rather than memorise.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *parivār*
- it once more, slowly, hearing *pari-* at the front
- it after *beṭī*, so the two sit together

Before you move on

What does परिवार mean? (“family”.) Say it once more.

41.18 लोग (log) — people

Before the new one: what did *parivār* mean?

You'll want to know: लोग

लोग (*log*) — “people”.

From Sanskrit लोक (*loka*), ‘world, realm’: the word for the world slid across to mean the people in it. Latin *lucus*, a clearing in a forest, and *lux*, ‘light’, grow from the same ancient root — an open, lit space first, then whoever stands in it. Hindi hears लोग as already plural, so it needs no further ending.

What you've built

That closes the run: son, daughter, family, and everyone else.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *log*
- it once more, slowly
- it after *parivār*, so the two sit together

Before you move on

What does लोग mean? (“people”.) Say it once more.

Things You Ask For

Modes: ⇌ voice (5) ⇌ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name five everyday things I might ask someone for in Hindi, and say which of them came down from Sanskrit and which walked in with Persian.

Complete HI-C45-soap and say all five words in order.

41.19 फल (phal) — a fruit

Before the new run of words: what did *parivār* mean, and what did *log* mean?

You'll want to know: फल

फल (*phal*) — “a fruit”.

Sanskrit *phala*, which named the fruit on the tree and, in the same breath, the result of anything you did. Hindi still carries both senses: the mango in your hand and the outcome of a year's work take the same word.

English readers meet the second sense in translations of the Gita, where “the fruit of action” is a word-for-word rendering rather than a figure the translator reached for. The Persian layer of Hindi later brought *mevā* for dried fruit and nuts, so the orchard and the shop shelf can be named separately — an inherited word and a borrowed one dividing the work between them, which is a habit worth watching for.

What you've built

The first of five things you might ask someone for.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *phal*
- it once more, slowly
- *phal*, then *log*, so the new one sits beside the last one you learned

Before you move on

What does फल mean? (“a fruit”.) Say it once more.

41.20 कपड़ा (kapṛā) — cloth

Before the new one: what did *phal* mean?

You’ll want to know: कपड़ा

कपड़ा (*kapṛā*) — “cloth”.

The plain, unceremonious word: the bolt on the shelf, the washing on the line, the shirt on your back. Behind it is Sanskrit *karpāṭa*, a rag or a patched garment, and the ढ़ in the middle is what a thousand years of ordinary speech did to that -ṭ- caught between two vowels.

Beside it Hindi keeps *vastra*, lifted from Sanskrit untouched, which turns up on a wedding invitation rather than over a washing line. Two words, one meaning, and the register telling them apart.

What you’ve built

Two: a fruit and a cloth.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kapṛā*
- it once more, slowly
- *phal*, then *kapṛā*, and ask for each with *krpayā* in front

Before you move on

What does कपड़ा mean? (“cloth”.) Say it once more.

41.21 दीया (dīyā) — an oil lamp

Before the new one: what did *kapṛā* mean?

You’ll want to know: दीया

दीया (*dīyā*) — “an oil lamp”.

A small clay lamp with a wick floating in oil — the kind lit in rows along a wall at Diwali. Behind it is Sanskrit *dīpa*, ‘lamp’, on the root *dīp-*, ‘to blaze’.

The *p* softened away in everyday speech and left दीया behind, while the formal *dīpak* kept it. Diwali is that same *dīpāvalī*, ‘a row of lamps’, worn down in the same direction: the lamps are still in the name of the festival, only harder to see.

What you’ve built

Three: a fruit, a cloth, and a lamp.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *dīyā*
- it once more, slowly
- *dīyā*, then *kapṛā*, so the two objects sit together

Before you move on

What does दीया mean? (“an oil lamp”.) Say it once more.

41.22 नमक (namak) — salt

Before the new one: what did *dīyā* mean?

You'll want to know: नमक

नमक (*namak*) — “salt”.

Persian *namak*, taken whole, and one of the plainest examples of Hindi's second inheritance. The word that came down from Sanskrit is *lavāṇa*, and it survives mostly in careful writing and in chemistry, while the borrowed word does the cooking.

Persian salt also handed Hindi a measure of character: *namak-halāl* is someone true to the salt they have eaten at your table, and *namak-harām* is the one who is not. A pantry word doing moral work.

What you've built

Four, and one of them is not a thing you can hold.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *namak*
- it once more, slowly
- *namak*, then *dīyā*, then *kapṛā*, backwards down the run

Before you move on

What does नमक mean? (“salt”.) Say it once more.

41.23 साबुन (sābun) — soap

Before the new one: what did *namak* mean?

You'll want to know: साबुन

साबुन (*sābun*) — “soap”.

Arabic *ṣābūn*, reaching Hindi through Persian — and behind the Arabic sits Latin *sāpō*, which the Romans had themselves borrowed from their northern neighbours, who used the stuff on their hair before anyone used it for washing.

So the word went north to south, south to east, and arrived here. English “soap” and साबुन are the same ancient word arriving by two different roads, one short and one very long.

What you’ve built

Five, and the run is closed: a fruit, cloth, a lamp, salt, soap.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *sābun*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order — *phal, kapṛā, dīyā, namak, sābun*

Before you move on

What does साबुन mean? (“soap”.) Say it once more.

Hair, Ear, and Throat

Modes: ⇌ voice (5) ⇌ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name five more parts of the body in Hindi, and follow the wearing-down that turned each Sanskrit word into the one people say.

Complete HI-C46-throat and say all five words in order.

41.24 बाल (bāl) — hair

Before the new run of words: what did *namak* mean, and what did *sābun* mean?

You'll want to know: बाल

बाल (bāl) — “hair”.

One hair, and by extension all the hair on a head. Sanskrit *vāla*, a hair or a horse's tail, stands behind it, and the turn from *v-* to *b-* is regular enough between Sanskrit and Hindi that you can use it as a rule of thumb.

Take care with its neighbour: *bāl-* also means 'child' in words borrowed straight from Sanskrit, as in *bālak*. Those are two different words that happened to fall together in sound, and only the sentence around them says which one is meant.

What you've built

The first of five more body words.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *bāl*
- it once more, slowly
- *bāl*, then *sābun*, so the washing and the washed sit together

Before you move on

What does बाल mean? (“hair”.) Say it once more.

41.25 उँगली (uṅglī) — a finger

Before the new one: what did *bāl* mean?

You’ll want to know: उँगली

उँगली (*uṅglī*) — “a finger”.

Sanskrit *aṅgulī*, a finger, built on *aṅga*, ‘a limb’. That one root supports a whole small household of hand-words: *aṅgūṭhā* is the thumb and *aṅgūṭhī* is the ring that goes on it.

The mark above the line here is doing the work the *ṇ* used to do. The nasal consonant dissolved into the vowel and left only the little moon-and-dot behind, which is the same trade you already saw inside *pāṇich*.

What you’ve built

Two of five.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *uṅglī*
- it once more, slowly
- *uṅglī*, then *bāl*, and touch each as you name it

Before you move on

What does उँगली mean? (“a finger”.) Say it once more.

41.26 कान (kān) — an ear

Before the new one: what did *uṅglī* mean?

You’ll want to know: कान

कान (*kān*) — “an ear”.

Sanskrit *kaṇṇa*, the ear — also the name of the warrior in the Mahabharata who was born wearing earrings. The path to कान is the ordinary one: the *-rṇ-* cluster collapses, the vowel that survives it lengthens, and a two-syllable word becomes one.

The same collapse is what turned *suvarṇa*, ‘good colour’, into *sonā*, gold. Once you have seen it twice it stops looking like an accident and starts looking like the machine it is.

What you’ve built

Three: hair, a finger, an ear.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kān*
- it once more, slowly
- *kān*, then *uṅglī*, then *bāl*, back down the run

Before you move on

What does कान mean? (“an ear”.) Say it once more.

41.27 नाक (nāk) — a nose

Before the new one: what did *kān* mean?

You'll want to know: नाक

नाक (*nāk*) — “a nose”.

From Sanskrit *nāsikā*, ‘nostril’, by way of Prakrit — and *nāsikā* is a cousin of Latin *nāsus* and of English “nose”, which makes this one of the clearest family resemblances anywhere on the body.

Hindi puts the nose where English puts the face: to have your नाक cut is to be humiliated, and to keep it high is to keep your honour. The idiom is old enough that the literal sense has stopped showing through.

What you've built

Four, and the last one is on the inside.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *nāk*
- it once more, slowly
- *nāk*, then *kān*, so the two openings of the head sit together

Before you move on

What does नाक mean? (“a nose”.) Say it once more.

41.28 गला (*galā*) — the throat

Before the new one: what did *nāk* mean?

You'll want to know: गला

गला (*galā*) — “the throat”.

Sanskrit *gala*, the throat, a cousin of Latin *gula*, the gullet — the word English took twice over, once as “gullet” and once, by a longer road, as “gluttony”.

Hindi keeps the plain sense and adds the obvious extension: your गला is also your voice, and to say that it has gone is to say you have gone hoarse. The organ and what comes out of it share one word, which is a bargain most languages strike somewhere.

What you've built

Five, and the run is closed: hair, a finger, an ear, a nose, the throat.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *galā*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order — *bāl, uṅglī, kān, nāk, galā*

Before you move on

What does गला mean? (“the throat”.) Say it once more.

Who Someone Is

Modes: ⇌ voice (5) ⇌ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what someone’s work is in Hindi, and tell an inherited word for a person from a borrowed one.

Complete HI-C47-neighbour and say all five words in order.

41.29 शिक्षक (śikṣak) — a teacher

Before the new run of words: what did *nāk* mean, and what did *galā* mean?

You’ll want to know: शिक्षक

शिक्षक (*śikṣak*) — “a teacher”.

Sanskrit, and it comes apart cleanly in the hand: the root *śikṣ-*, ‘to learn, to be taught’, with the agent ending *-aka* — the one who brings the learning about. The same root gives *śikṣā*, education, and *śikṣit*, educated.

Everyday speech reaches for *ustād* or *guru* depending on what is being taught and by whom, but शिक्षक is the word on the school form, and the feminine *śikṣikā* is built from it by the ending alone.

What you’ve built

The first of five words for who someone is.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *śikṣak*

- it once more, slowly
- *śikṣak*, then *galā*, so the teacher and the voice sit together

Before you move on

What does शिक्षक mean? (“a teacher”.) Say it once more.

41.30 छात्र (chātra) — a student

Before the new one: what did *śikṣak* mean?

You’ll want to know: छात्र

छात्र (*chātra*) — “a student”.

Sanskrit *chātra*, and the picture inside it is unexpected. *Chattra* is a parasol, and the traditional Indian etymologists read *chātra* as the one who stands in the teacher’s shade. Whether that is the true history is argued about; that it is the story the tradition told is not.

The feminine is *chātrā*. The transparent alternative is *vidyārthī*, ‘one who seeks knowledge’, which says on its face what छात्र only hints at.

What you’ve built

Two: a teacher and a student.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *chātra*
- it once more, slowly
- *chātra*, then *śikṣak*, the pair that needs each other

Before you move on

What does छात्र mean? (“a student”.) Say it once more.

41.31 किसान (kisān) — a farmer

Before the new one: what did *chātra* mean?

You'll want to know: किसान

किसान (*kisān*) — “a farmer”.

From *kṛṣāṇa*, on the Sanskrit root *kṛṣ-*, ‘to plough, to drag through the ground’ — the same root behind *kṛṣi*, agriculture. A farmer, in this word, is simply the one who drags the plough.

Latin reached for the same picture and got there with different material: *sulcus*, a furrow, is not related to *kṛṣ-* at all. Two families, no shared word, and the identical image — which is worth noticing precisely because it proves nothing about descent.

What you've built

Three, and each one names work rather than family.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kisān*
- it once more, slowly
- *kisān*, then *chātra*, then *śikṣak*, back down the run

Before you move on

What does किसान mean? (“a farmer”.) Say it once more.

41.32 मेहमान (mehmān) — a guest

Before the new one: what did *kisān* mean?

You'll want to know: मेहमान

मेहमान (*mehmān*) — “a guest”.

Persian *mihmān*, and Hindi took the whole vocabulary of hospitality along with it: *mehmān-nawāzī*, hospitality, is literally the cherishing of guests.

The inherited word is *atithi*, and it is built out of a small argument: *a-tithi*, 'without a date' — a guest being, by definition, someone who has not told you when they are coming. Two words, two theories of the thing. One names the arrival, the other names the welcome.

What you've built

Four, and this one arrives at your door.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *mehmān*
- it once more, slowly
- *mehmān*, then *kisān*, so the visitor and the host sit together

Before you move on

What does मेहमान mean? ("a guest".) Say it once more.

41.33 पड़ोसी (*paṛosī*) — a neighbour

Before the new one: what did *mehmān* mean?

You'll want to know: पड़ोसी

पड़ोसी (*paṛosī*) — "a neighbour".

Built on *paṛos*, the neighbourhood, with the *-ī* that turns a place into a person — the very ending that makes आदमी out of Adam.

Behind *paṛos* is Sanskrit *prati-veśa*, 'the dwelling opposite', on *veś-*, 'to enter, to settle'. So a neighbour here is not merely the one who is near you. It is the one whose door faces yours.

What you've built

Five, and the run is closed: a teacher, a student, a farmer, a guest, a neighbour.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *paṛosī*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order — *śikṣak, chātra, kisān, mehmān, paṛosī*

Before you move on

What does पड़ोसी mean? (“a neighbour”.) Say it once more.

Short Replies

Modes: ⇄ voice (5) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can answer someone in Hindi with one word, and pick how certain that one word sounds.

Complete HI-C48-absolutely and say all five words in order.

41.34 सच (sac) — true

Before the new run of words: what did *mehmān* mean, and what did *paṛosī* mean?

You'll want to know: सच

सच (*sac*) — “true”.

Sanskrit *satya*, ‘true, real’, worn down to a single syllable — and *satya* is itself built on *sat*, the participle of the verb ‘to be’. What is true, at the bottom of this word, is simply what is.

Hindi keeps the long form as well, in names and in solemn speech, so one idea can arrive dressed either way. सच is the one you say when somebody tells you something you did not expect.

What you've built

The first of five short replies.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *sac*

- it once more, slowly
- *sac*, then *paṛosī*, so the reply and the person sit together

Before you move on

What does सच mean? (“true”.) Say it once more.

41.35 बस (bas) — enough, that’s all

Before the new one: what did *sac* mean?

You’ll want to know: बस

बस (*bas*) — “enough, that’s all”.

Persian *bas*, ‘enough’. One syllable that stops a pouring hand, ends a list, or closes an argument, and it does all three on tone alone.

Doubled, *bas bas*, it is the polite way to say enough while somebody is still serving you. Stretched out, it is what you say when they are plainly not listening. Very few words in the language do this much work for so little.

What you’ve built

Two, and both are one syllable.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *bas*
- it once more, slowly
- *bas*, then *sac*, one after the other, as answers

Before you move on

What does बस mean? (“enough, that’s all”.) Say it once more.

41.36 ज़रूर (zarūr) — certainly

Before the new one: what did *bas* mean?

You'll want to know: ज़रूर

ज़रूर (*zarūr*) — “certainly”.

Arabic *ḍarūr*, ‘necessity’, arriving through Persian — and the word has walked from necessity to certainty by the shortest possible route: what must be, will be. Its relative *zarūrat* is still the plain Hindi word for a need.

The dot written under the ज़ marks a sound that came in with the Persian layer rather than down from Sanskrit. The letter underneath it was already here; the dot is the passport.

What you've built

Three: true, enough, certainly.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *zarūr*
- it once more, slowly
- *zarūr*, then *bas*, then *sac*, back down the run

Before you move on

What does ज़रूर mean? (“certainly”.) Say it once more.

41.37 शायद (*śāyad*) — perhaps

Before the new one: what did *zarūr* mean?

You'll want to know: शायद

शायद (*śāyad*) — “perhaps”.

Persian *shāyad*, ‘it may be’, out of *shāyistan*, ‘to be fitting, to be possible’. A whole conjugated form collapsed into a single hedge.

The inherited alternative is *sambhavataḥ*, four syllables of Sanskrit that belong to written prose and to careful speeches. When somebody is guessing out loud in a kitchen, they say शायद.

What you've built

Four, and this one takes a step back.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *śāyad*
- it once more, slowly
- *śāyad*, then *zarūr*, the two ends of how sure you are

Before you move on

What does शायद mean? (“perhaps”.) Say it once more.

41.38 बिलकुल (bilkul) — absolutely

Before the new one: what did *śāyad* mean?

You'll want to know: बिलकुल

बिलकुल (*bilkul*) — “absolutely”.

Arabic *bi-l-kull*, ‘with the whole’ — a preposition, the definite article *al-*, and *kull*, ‘all’, fused into one Hindi word. That same *al-* is sitting, equally hidden, inside अलविदा.

It answers a yes-or-no question with more weight than a bare yes. Put *nahīmi* after it and it does exactly the same for no, which makes it the most emphatic thing on this page in either direction.

What you've built

Five, and the run is closed: true, enough, certainly, perhaps, absolutely.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *bilkul*

- it once more, slowly
- all five in order — *sac*, *bas*, *zarūr*, *śāyad*, *bilkul*

Before you move on

What does बिलकुल mean? (“absolutely”.) Say it once more.

Taking Your Leave

Modes: ⇌ voice (5) ⇌ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say when I am leaving and when I will be back in Hindi.

Complete HI-C49-meeting and say all five words in order.

41.39 अभी (abhī) — right now

Before the new run of words: what did *śāyad* mean, and what did *bilkul* mean?

You'll want to know: अभी

अभी (*abhī*) — “right now”.

Ab, ‘now’, with the emphatic *-hī* welded onto it: now and nothing but now. Behind *ab* stands Sanskrit *adhunā*.

That little *-hī* is one of the most useful pieces in the language. It narrows whatever it lands on, and you will meet it stuck to other words later. Here it turns a vague present into a pointed one — not now-ish, but this moment, and no other.

What you've built

The first of five words for leaving.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *abhī*

- it once more, slowly
- *abhī*, then *bilkul*, so the timing and the emphasis sit together

Before you move on

What does अभी mean? (“right now”.) Say it once more.

41.40 परसों (parsom) — the day after tomorrow

Before the new one: what did *abhī* mean?

You’ll want to know: परसों

परसों (*parsom*) — “the day after tomorrow”.

And also the day before yesterday. Like कल, which does duty for both tomorrow and yesterday, परसों counts two days out from today and leaves the direction to the sentence.

Sanskrit *parasu*, ‘the far day’, lies underneath, and the language evidently never felt the lack of two separate words. Time is being measured here by distance from now, with the direction supplied by whatever the sentence is already doing.

What you’ve built

Two, and both of them are about when.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *parsom*
- it once more, slowly
- *parsom*, then *abhī*, the far day beside this very moment

Before you move on

What does परसों mean? (“the day after tomorrow”.) Say it once more.

41.41 सफ़र (safar) — a journey

Before the new one: what did *parsoni* mean?

You'll want to know: सफ़र

सफ़र (*safar*) — “a journey”.

Arabic *safar*, ‘travel’, through Persian. The same root gives *safīr*, an ambassador — somebody sent out on a journey and expected back.

The inherited word is *yātrā*, from the Sanskrit root *yā-*, ‘to go’, and it leans toward pilgrimage. So a सफ़र is the road itself, while a *yātrā* is the road with a reason at the end of it.

What you've built

Three: right now, the far day, a journey.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *safar*
- it once more, slowly
- *safar*, then *parsoni*, then *abhī*, back down the run

Before you move on

What does सफ़र mean? (“a journey.”) Say it once more.

41.42 निकलना (nikalnā) — to set out, to leave

Before the new one: what did *safar* mean?

You'll want to know: निकलना

निकलना (*nikalnā*) — “to set out, to leave”.

What you say when you are on the point of walking out of a door. It is the going-out kind of action, where the thing leaves under its own steam, and it has a partner, *nikālṇā*, with a long *ā*, which means to take something out.

Lengthen the vowel and the doer changes: that pairing is one of Hindi's tidiest machines, and it runs through dozens of everyday words. Sanskrit *niṣkal-*, 'to go forth', stands behind both.

What you've built

Four, and this one is something you do.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *nikalnā*
- it once more, slowly
- *nikalnā*, then *saḥar*, the leaving and the road it opens

Before you move on

What does निकलना mean? ("to set out, to leave".) Say it once more.

41.43 मुलाक़ात (mulāqāt) — a meeting

Before the new one: what did *nikalnā* mean?

You'll want to know: मुलाक़ात

मुलाक़ात (*mulāqāt*) — "a meeting".

Arabic *mulāqāt*, on *laqiya*, 'to meet', arriving through Persian. It covers everything from bumping into somebody on a street to a scheduled interview in an office.

It sits inside the ordinary parting line *phir mulāqāt hogī*, 'there will be a meeting again' — which is what फिर मिलेंगे says using inherited material instead of borrowed. Same farewell, two vocabularies, and a speaker can pick either without changing the meaning by a hair.

What you've built

Five, and the run is closed: right now, the far day, a journey, setting out, a meeting.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *mulāqāt*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order — *abhī, parsomī, safar, nikalnā, mulāqāt*

Before you move on

What does मुलाक़ात mean? (“a meeting”.) Say it once more.

Courtesy Words

Modes: ⇌ voice (5) ⇌ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can thank someone in Hindi at the weight the occasion asks for.

Complete HI-C50-salutation and say all five words in order.

41.44 आभार (ābhār) — gratitude

Before the new run of words: what did *nikalnā* mean, and what did *mulāqāt* mean?

You'll want to know: आभार

आभार (*ābhār*) — “gratitude”.

Sanskrit *ā-bhāra*, ‘a load carried toward’ — built on *bhṛ-*, ‘to bear’, which is the same ancient root as Latin *ferre* and English “bear”. To be grateful, on the evidence of this word, is to be carrying a weight that somebody else put there.

It stands above धन्यवाद in formality, and well above शुक्रिया. It is the word a written speech uses, or a letter, or the last line of a printed programme.

What you've built

The first of five courtesy words.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ābhār*

- it once more, slowly
- *ābhār*, then *mulāqāt*, the thanks and the meeting it ends

Before you move on

What does आभार mean? (“gratitude”.) Say it once more.

41.45 एहसान (ehsān) — a favour

Before the new one: what did *ābhār* mean?

You’ll want to know: एहसान

एहसान (*ehsān*) — “a favour”.

Arabic *iḥsān*, ‘the doing of what is good’, on the root *ḥ-s-n*, which carries both beauty and goodness and also gives the names *ḥasan* and *ḥusn*. Persian passed it on to Hindi as the word for a kindness done to you and not forgotten.

Two phrases live on it and point opposite ways. *Ehsān mānnā* is to acknowledge a favour; *ehsān jatānā* is to keep reminding somebody that you did them one. The language leaves you in no doubt which of the two it thinks less of.

What you’ve built

Two: gratitude, and the thing it is owed for.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ehsān*
- it once more, slowly
- *ehsān*, then *ābhār*, the favour and the thanks for it

Before you move on

What does एहसान mean? (“a favour”.) Say it once more.

41.46 आदर (ādar) — respect

Before the new one: what did *ehsān* mean?

You'll want to know: आदर

आदर (*ādar*) — “respect”.

Sanskrit *ādara*, ‘regard, attentiveness’, from *ā-dṛ-*, ‘to heed’. Hindi carries this word inside its own machinery: the आप form is called *ādar-sūcak*, the respect-marking form.

So this is not only a word for a feeling somebody has. It is the name of a choice the language makes you make in nearly every sentence you speak, whether you have thought about it or not.

What you've built

Three, and this one is built into the grammar.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ādar*
- it once more, slowly
- *ādar*, then *ehsān*, then *ābhār*, back down the run

Before you move on

What does आदर mean? (“respect”.) Say it once more.

41.47 आशीर्वाद (āśīrvād) — a blessing

Before the new one: what did *ādar* mean?

You'll want to know: आशीर्वाद

आशीर्वाद (*āśīrvād*) — “a blessing”.

Sanskrit *āśīr-vāda*: *āśis*, ‘a wish, a prayer’, joined to *vāda*, ‘speech’. A blessing is literally a wish said out loud. The *s* turning into *r* before the *v* is a regular joint in Sanskrit rather than a quirk of this one word.

It travels downward. An elder gives आशीर्वाद; the younger person asks for it by bending to touch the elder's feet, and the giving is spoken over the bent head.

What you've built

Four, and this one is given rather than said.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *āśīrvād*
- it once more, slowly
- *āśīrvād*, then *ādar*, the blessing and the respect that asks for it

Before you move on

What does आशीर्वाद mean? (“a blessing”.) Say it once more.

41.48 प्रणाम (praṇām) — a bow, a salutation

Before the new one: what did *āśīrvād* mean?

You'll want to know: प्रणाम

प्रणाम (*praṇām*) — “a bow, a salutation”.

Sanskrit *pra-ṇāma*, ‘a bending forward’, on *nam-*, ‘to bow’ — the identical root standing inside नमस्ते and नमस्कार. Three words, one gesture, three heights of formality.

प्रणाम is what a younger person says to an elder, often while bending to touch the feet, and what it expects back is आशीर्वाद. The pair of words is the pair of movements: one goes down, one comes back over the top.

What you've built

Five, and the run is closed: gratitude, a favour, respect, a blessing, a bow.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *praṇām*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order — *ābhār, ehsān, ādar, āśīrvād, praṇām*

Before you move on

What does प्रणाम mean? (“a bow, a salutation”.) Say it once more.

Welcoming a Guest

Modes: ⇌ voice (5) ⇌ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name what a Hindi household puts in front of a guest at the door.

Complete HI-C51-sweet and say all five words in order.

41.49 फूल (phūl) — a flower

Before the new run of words: what did *āśīrvād* mean, and what did *praṇām* mean?

You'll want to know: फूल

फूल (*phūl*) — “a flower”.

Sanskrit *phulla*, ‘blossomed, opened out’, from *phull-*, ‘to bloom’. So the Hindi word for a flower is at bottom a word for the act of opening, with the object named after the event.

The double *ll* collapsed and paid for itself by lengthening the vowel in front of it, which is the standard trade in this family — the same bargain that gave you कान out of *karṇa*. It is also the measure of lightness: something that weighs nothing at all is *phūl jaisā*.

What you've built

The first of five things at a welcome.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *phūl*
- it once more, slowly
- *phūl*, then *praṇām*, the flower and the bow at the door

Before you move on

What does फूल mean? (“a flower”.) Say it once more.

41.50 माला (mālā) — a garland

Before the new one: what did *phūl* mean?

You’ll want to know: माला

माला (*mālā*) — “a garland”.

Sanskrit *mālā*, a garland or a string of beads, and the second sense has travelled furthest: the string of a hundred and eight beads counted through the fingers is a *mālā*, and English borrowed the word back, unchanged, for that same object.

Around the neck of a guest it is a welcome. Around the frame of a photograph it is mourning. The object does not change at all; where it is hung decides everything.

What you’ve built

Two: a flower and a garland made of them.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *mālā*
- it once more, slowly
- *mālā*, then *phūl*, the string and the thing it is made of

Before you move on

What does माला mean? (“a garland”.) Say it once more.

41.51 आँगन (āṅgan) — a courtyard

Before the new one: what did *mālā* mean?

You'll want to know: आँगन

आँगन (*āṅgan*) — “a courtyard”.

Sanskrit *aṅgaṇa*, the open ground a house encloses — the room with no roof over it. Old town houses are built around one, and a great deal of what English would put in a living room happens there instead: the drying, the talking, the sitting with a guest.

The mark above the line marks a nasal that used to be a whole consonant, exactly as it does in *uṅgl̄*.

What you've built

Three, and this one is where you seat the guest.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *āṅgan*
- it once more, slowly
- *āṅgan*, then *mālā*, then *phūl*, back down the run

Before you move on

What does आँगन mean? (“a courtyard”.) Say it once more.

41.52 मेज़ (mez) — a table

Before the new one: what did *āṅgan* mean?

You'll want to know: मेज़

मेज़ (*mez*) — “a table”.

Persian *mez*, and behind the Persian sits Portuguese *mesa*, out of Latin *mēnsa*. Portuguese ships carried the object and its name into the Indian Ocean, which is the same route that brought कमरा in from *camera*.

There was no inherited word for a raised surface on four legs because the household had not had one; people ate and wrote and worked at floor level. The word arrived with the furniture, which is usually how that happens.

What you've built

Four, and one of them came off a ship.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *mez*
- it once more, slowly
- *mez*, then *āṁgan*, one of them standing inside the other

Before you move on

What does मेज़ mean? (“a table”.) Say it once more.

41.53 मिठाई (miṭhāī) — a sweet

Before the new one: what did *mez* mean?

You'll want to know: मिठाई

मिठाई (*miṭhāī*) — “a sweet”.

From *mīṭhā*, ‘sweet’, with the *-āī* ending that turns a quality into a thing you can hold — sweetness first, then the sweet itself. Behind *mīṭhā* is Sanskrit *miṣṭa*, ‘sweetened, relished’.

Nothing closes a welcome better: the garland at the door, the seat in the courtyard, and something sweet in the hand before anybody says why they have come.

What you've built

Five, and the run is closed: a flower, a garland, a courtyard, a table, a sweet.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *mīṭhāī*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order — *phūl, mālā, āmīgan, mez, mīṭhāī*

Before you move on

What does मिठाई mean? (“a sweet”.) Say it once more.